FlashGenius

Paper Decoder

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Thursday, 1 October 2026

GS3 · Economy

1. Registered manufacturing output expands 7.81 percent in FY25

Industrial output rose 7.81 percent and employment increased 7.2 percent, with five states accounting for over 56 percent of factory jobs.

What happened	Output in the registered manufacturing sector rose 7.81 percent in financial year 2025, while total employment grew by almost 7.2 percent.
Why UPSC cares	Important for understanding industrial growth trends. The Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) data is crucial for analyzing employment and manufacturing sector performance, a key syllabus hook under industrial growth.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Industrial policy and growth, changes in industrial policy and their effects on industrial growth.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Trends in organized factory employment and real wage growth across states.
2. Regional concentration of industrial establishments and employment generation.
3. Role of the Annual Survey of Industries in capturing formal manufacturing data.

Key terms

Annual Survey of Industries (ASI)
The principal source of industrial statistics in India, covering factories registered under the Factories Act, 1948.

Registered Manufacturing
The formal factory sector comprising manufacturing units that employ ten or more workers using power, or twenty or more without power.

Emoluments
The aggregate of all salaries, wages, allowances, and bonuses paid to employees for work done during an accounting year.

Index of Industrial Production (IIP)
A short term monthly economic indicator measuring the volume changes in industrial production relative to a chosen base year.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) in India, consider the following statements:
1. It covers all factories registered under Sections 2m(i) and 2m(ii) of the Factories Act, 1948.
2. It provides detailed statistics on capital, employment, output, and value added for the registered industrial sector.
3. The survey is conducted under the statutory provisions of the Collection of Statistics Act.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because the Annual Survey of Industries covers factories registered under Sections 2m(i) and 2m(ii) of the Factories Act, 1948. Statement 2 is correct because the survey provides comprehensive annual data on fixed capital, physical working capital, employment, emoluments, gross output, and net value added. Statement 3 is correct because the survey is conducted under the provisions of the Collection of Statistics Act, 2008 (and rules framed thereunder), which makes response mandatory.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the spatial disparity in India's registered manufacturing sector. What structural measures are required to ensure balanced regional industrialization and formal job creation? (150 words, 10 marks)

India's organized manufacturing exhibits marked geographical concentration, with five states accounting for over 56 percent of total factory employment.

- Coastal and western states benefit from historical port infrastructure, robust logistical networks, and better ease of doing business.
- Inland and eastern states lag due to logistical bottlenecks, lower capital formation, and inadequate skill ecosystems.
- Structural imbalances lead to distress interstate labour migration and uneven regional economic growth.
- National programmes require tailored state industrial corridors, dedicated freight connectivity, and local cluster development.

Decentralizing infrastructure investment, enhancing plug-and-play industrial parks in lagging states, and rationalizing state level logistics policies are critical for inclusive industrial expansion.

Keywords to use: spatial concentration, registered manufacturing, industrial corridors, labour migration, balanced regional development

GS3 · Environment

2. Guidelines released for National Coastal Mission 2.0 to protect marine ecosystems

Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav released the guidelines for the National Coastal Mission 2.0 to strengthen coastal conservation.

What happened	Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav released the guidelines for the National Coastal Mission (NCM) 2.0.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for coastal zone management and climate change adaptation. The National Coastal Mission 2.0 guidelines directly link to environmental conservation and disaster management syllabus topics.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment.
Chapter	Environment: Green Laws & Policies of India

Read it for

1. Objectives and structure of the National Coastal Mission (NCM) under India's climate action plans.
2. The role of Integrated Coastal Zone Management (ICZM) in balancing development and ecology.
3. Regulatory frameworks like Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) notifications for protecting marine life.

Key terms

Integrated Coastal Zone Management (ICZM)
A process for the management of the coast using an integrated approach, regarding all aspects of the coastal zone, including geographical and political boundaries, to achieve sustainability.

Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ)
Areas declared under the Environment Protection Act, 1986, to regulate and restrict activities along India's coasts, estuaries, and backwaters.

Blue Flag Certification
An international eco-label awarded to clean, safe, and environmentally friendly beaches and marinas, managed by the Foundation for Environmental Education (FEE).

Marine Protected Areas (MPAs)
Designated marine spaces, such as sanctuaries or national parks, managed to conserve biodiversity, ecological processes, and cultural resources.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) in India:
1. Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) notifications are issued under the Environment Protection Act, 1986.
2. The CRZ notifications apply to land area up to 1000 meters from the High Tide Line (HTL).
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct because Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) notifications are issued by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change under Section 3 of the Environment Protection Act, 1986. Statement 2 is incorrect because the CRZ notifications apply to the land area up to 500 meters from the High Tide Line (HTL), not 1000 meters.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the ecological and economic challenges faced by India's coastal regions. How does the National Coastal Mission (NCM) aim to address these challenges through an integrated approach? (150 words, 10 marks)

India has a vast coastline of over 7,500 km, which is highly vulnerable to climate change, sea-level rise, and anthropogenic pressures.

- Ecological challenges include coastal erosion, loss of mangrove cover, marine pollution, and habitat destruction.
- Economic challenges involve the vulnerability of fishing communities, unsustainable tourism, and infrastructure damage from extreme weather events.
- The National Coastal Mission (NCM) addresses these by promoting Integrated Coastal Zone Management (ICZM) to balance conservation and livelihood.
- It strengthens Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) enforcement and enhances climate resilience through nature-based solutions.

Effective implementation requires decentralised governance, active participation of local communities, and robust scientific monitoring of coastal dynamics.

Keywords to use: Integrated Coastal Zone Management (ICZM), Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ), Coastal Erosion, Blue Economy, Climate Resilience

GS2 · Polity

3. Supreme Court rejects complete ban on firecrackers ahead of Diwali

The apex court favoured a balanced approach to protect both religious sentiments and the environment by imposing time limits and permitting specific firecrackers.

What happened	The Supreme Court of India ruled out a complete ban on firecrackers during Diwali, opting instead for specified time limits and permitting certain categories of crackers to balance religious sentiments with environmental and health concerns.
Why UPSC cares	Highlights environmental jurisprudence and judicial balancing. The Supreme Court's stance on balancing religious sentiments and the right to a clean environment is a prime example of judicial intervention in public health.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Structure, organization and functioning of the Judiciary
Chapter	Polity: Apex Court of India

Read it for

1. The judicial doctrine of proportionality in balancing competing fundamental rights under Article 21 and Article 25.
2. The role and statutory powers of the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) in regulating hazardous chemicals like barium.
3. The limits of judicial intervention in cultural practices and policy matters concerning public health.

Key terms

Doctrine of Proportionality

A constitutional doctrine used by courts to ensure that government actions or judicial restrictions do not restrict fundamental rights more than necessary to achieve a legitimate goal.

Article 21 of the Constitution

A fundamental right that guarantees protection of life and personal liberty, which the Supreme Court of India has interpreted to include the right to a clean and healthy environment.

Article 25 of the Constitution

A fundamental right that guarantees freedom of conscience and the free profession, practice, and propagation of religion, subject to public order, morality, and health.

Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)

A statutory organization established in 1974 under the Water Prevention and Control of Pollution Act, responsible for monitoring air and water quality and advising the government.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to environmental governance and constitutional provisions in India, consider the following statements:
1. The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) is a statutory body established under the Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1981.
2. The right to a wholesome environment has been recognized as an integral part of the Right to Life under Article 21 of the Constitution of India.

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) was established in 1974 under the Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1974. It was later entrusted with powers and functions under the Air (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act, 1981. Statement 2 is correct because the Supreme Court of India, through various landmark judgments, has expanded the scope of Article 21 (Right to Life and Personal Liberty) to include the right to a clean, healthy, and wholesome environment.

Mains: how it could come

The Supreme Court of India often has to balance competing fundamental rights, such as the right to a clean environment and the freedom to practice religion. Discuss the role of the judiciary in achieving this balance, with reference to recent interventions in environmental matters. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Indian judiciary frequently encounters cases where the Right to Life (Article 21), which includes a clean environment, conflicts with religious and cultural freedoms protected under Article 25.

- Doctrine of Proportionality: The judiciary applies this doctrine to ensure that restrictions on religious practices are minimal and strictly necessary for public health.
- Harmonious Construction: Courts attempt to read Articles 21 and 25 harmoniously, ensuring that public health is protected without completely extinguishing cultural celebrations.
- Regulated Enforcement: Instead of absolute bans, courts often prescribe graded restrictions, such as time limits and chemical regulations (e.g., banning barium-based crackers), to mitigate environmental harm.
- Scientific Input: The judiciary relies on technical bodies like the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) to make evidence-based decisions rather than arbitrary prohibitions.

The way forward lies in strengthening executive enforcement of green standards and promoting public awareness, reducing the need for constant judicial intervention in cultural spheres.

Keywords to use: Article 21, Article 25, Doctrine of Proportionality, Harmonious Construction, Judicial Balancing

Newspaper words

disparities	असमानताएं	Differences or inequalities between things or groups
revival	पुनरुद्धार	An improvement in the condition or strength of something
adaptation	अनुकूलन	The process of changing to suit new conditions
hazardous	खतरनाक	Risky or dangerous to health or safety
intervention	हस्तक्षेप	Action taken to intentionally get involved in a situation

Friday, 2 October 2026

GS2 · Polity

1. Centre convenes meeting to resolve Mahanadi river water dispute

Union Home Minister Amit Shah chaired a meeting in New Delhi with Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil and the Chief Ministers of Chhattisgarh and Odisha to resolve the Mahanadi water dispute.

What happened	Union Home Minister Amit Shah chaired a New Delhi meeting with Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil and the Chief Ministers of Chhattisgarh and Odisha to resolve the Mahanadi water dispute.
Why UPSC cares	Interstate water disputes test India's federal structure and cooperative federalism. Aspirants must study constitutional mechanisms like Article 262 and tribunals for GS2 Polity.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Functions and responsibilities of the Union and the States, issues and challenges pertaining to the federal structure.
Chapter	Polity: When States Interact

Read it for

1. Constitutional mechanisms under Article 262 for resolving inter-state river water disputes.
2. Role of Union executive and political negotiation in resolving inter-state conflicts.
3. Statutory framework of the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956 and tribunal adjudications.

Key terms

Article 262
A constitutional provision that empowers Parliament to legislate for the adjudication of disputes relating to the use, distribution, or control of waters of any inter-state river or river valley. It also allows Parliament to bar the jurisdiction of the Supreme Court of India or any other court over such disputes.

Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956
An Act of Parliament enacted under Article 262 to set up ad-hoc tribunals for the adjudication of water disputes between state governments. It provides the statutory procedure when bilateral negotiations fail.

Mahanadi Water Disputes Tribunal
A judicial body constituted by the Central Government in 2018 under the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956 to adjudicate the dispute over Mahanadi river waters between Chhattisgarh and Odisha.

Cooperative Federalism
A concept where the Centre and State governments work together jointly to resolve common issues and policy challenges through consultation and consensus.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to inter-state river water disputes in India, consider the following statements:
1. Parliament may by law provide for the adjudication of any dispute relating to the use, distribution or control of the waters of any inter-state river.
2. Article 262 of the Constitution of India explicitly prevents Parliament from barring the jurisdiction of the Supreme Court of India in such disputes.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: Article 262(1) empowers Parliament to enact laws for adjudicating disputes related to the use, distribution, or control of inter-state river waters. Statement 2 is incorrect: Article 262(2) explicitly allows Parliament to enact laws that exclude the jurisdiction of the Supreme Court of India or any other court over inter-state river water disputes.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the constitutional and statutory mechanisms for resolving inter-state river water disputes in India. Why have these mechanisms often faced delays in achieving final settlements? (150 words, 10 marks)

Article 262 of the Constitution of India and the Inter-State River Water Disputes (ISRWD) Act, 1956 govern the adjudication of water conflicts between state governments in India.

- Constitutional framework: Article 262 enables Parliament to establish ad-hoc tribunals and exclude Supreme Court of India jurisdiction to ensure specialized adjudication.
- Statutory setup: Under the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956, the Central Government constitutes tribunals upon state requests when negotiations fail.
- Causes of delays: Absence of binding statutory timelines historically, political sensitivities among states, non-compliance with interim orders, and protracted litigation through Special Leave Petitions under Article 136.
- Data and institutional gaps: Lack of trusted, centralized hydrological data leads to extended technical disputes between riparian states.

Establishing a single permanent tribunal with standing benches and standardizing national water data architecture will ensure time-bound and evidence-based conflict resolution.

Keywords to use: Article 262, ISRWD Act 1956, Article 136, Water Disputes Tribunal, Cooperative Federalism

GS3 · Economy

2. Energy security requires market reforms and strong regulatory bodies

A National Institution for Transforming India (NITI Aayog) member highlighted the role of regulation and open access gas pipeline infrastructure in strengthening energy security.

What happened	A NITI Aayog member emphasized that robust regulation by the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) and common carrier pipeline access are essential for India's energy transition.
Why UPSC cares	Energy security is vital for achieving Viksit Bharat at 2047 amid geopolitical risks. This provides key inputs for GS3 Economy on infrastructure, reforms and growth.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Infrastructure: Energy, Investment models, and Regulatory framework.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Role of regulatory bodies like Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) in building predictable markets.
2. Concept of open access through common carrier and contract carrier principles in natural gas pipelines.
3. Strategic importance of transitioning towards a gas based economy for national energy security.

Key terms

Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB)
A statutory body established under the PNGRB Act, 2006, to regulate downstream activities in the petroleum and natural gas sector and protect consumer interests.

Common Carrier Principle
A regulatory requirement forcing pipeline owners to grant non-discriminatory access to uncommitted capacity to third party shippers.

Gas-Based Economy
An economic structure where natural gas forms a significantly higher share in the primary energy mix compared to coal or crude oil.

Open Access
The non-discriminatory provision for the use of transmission lines or pipelines by any eligible entity to move fuel across regions.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding energy sector regulation in India:
1. The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) is a statutory body set up to foster fair competition and protect consumer interests.
2. Appeals against the decisions of the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) are heard by the Appellate Tribunal for Electricity (APTEL).
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct. The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) was constituted under the PNGRB Act, 2006, as a statutory regulatory body to ensure competitive downstream gas markets and safeguard consumer interest. Statement 2 is correct. Under Section 30 of the PNGRB Act, 2006, appeals against the orders and decisions of PNGRB lie before the Appellate Tribunal for Electricity (APTEL).

Mains: how it could come

Independent regulatory architecture and market reforms are crucial for attracting private investment and strengthening energy security in India. Discuss with reference to the natural gas sector. (150 words, 10 marks)

Energy security requires predictable market rules, transparent tariff setting, and open access infrastructure, making effective regulation vital.

- Role of PNGRB: The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) provides predictable regulatory oversight, builds investor confidence, and protects downstream consumers.
- Open Access Infrastructure: Enforcing common carrier and contract carrier principles prevents natural monopolies and allows multiple suppliers to utilize gas pipelines.
- Market Integration: De-bottlenecking transportation infrastructure facilitates nationwide gas grid development and aligns domestic prices with competitive market forces.
- Global Geopolitical Hedging: Developing domestic storage and regulatory agility helps mitigate supply chain risks arising from international conflicts.

India should expedite unbundling of gas transport from marketing and include natural gas under the Goods and Services Tax (GST) framework to achieve a 15% gas share in its energy mix.

Keywords to use: Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB), Common Carrier, Open Access, Gas-Based Economy, Energy Security

GS2 · International Relations

3. India hosts ninth Deputy NSA-level meeting of Colombo Security Conclave

Member states reviewed cooperation in maritime safety, security and disaster relief during a virtual meeting hosted by India.

What happened	India virtually hosted the ninth Deputy NSA-level meeting of the Colombo Security Conclave, reviewing progress across five pillars of cooperation with regional partners.
Why UPSC cares	Regional security groupings in the Indian Ocean are crucial for India's maritime diplomacy. Read this for GS2 International Relations and security architecture.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: India and its neighborhood- bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the objectives and founding members of the Colombo Security Conclave.
2. Analyze the strategic significance of the Indian Ocean Region for Indian diplomacy.
3. Examine India's role in humanitarian assistance and disaster relief in South Asia.

Key terms

Colombo Security Conclave

A regional security grouping comprising India, Sri Lanka, Maldives, Mauritius, Bangladesh and Seychelles to address maritime security in the Indian Ocean Region.

Indian Ocean Region

A vital geopolitical and economic body of water connecting three continents, serving as a primary transit route for global trade and energy supplies.

Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief

Cooperative measures undertaken by nations to provide emergency aid, rescue operations, and rehabilitation during natural or man-made disasters.

National Security Adviser

A senior official appointed by a government to advise on national security and foreign policy matters.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Colombo Security Conclave:
1. It is exclusively focused on land-based border security among South Asian nations.
2. Member states cooperate across multiple identified pillars including maritime safety and security.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) The Colombo Security Conclave focuses primarily on maritime safety, security, and humanitarian assistance in the Indian Ocean Region, making the first statement incorrect and the second correct.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the strategic significance of minilateral groupings like the Colombo Security Conclave in enhancing India's maritime security architecture in the Indian Ocean Region. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Colombo Security Conclave serves as a key minilateral framework for maritime security and cooperative engagement among Indian Ocean littoral states.

- Fosters institutionalized cooperation across maritime safety, counter-terrorism, and cyber security.
- Positions India as a preferred security partner and net security provider in the neighborhood.
- Counterbalances extra-regional dominance through transparent regional partnerships.
- Strengthens humanitarian assistance and disaster relief operational readiness among island nations.

India must leverage these minilateral platforms to build trust, share maritime domain awareness, and ensure a free and open Indo-Pacific.

Keywords to use: Colombo Security Conclave, Minilateralism, Net Security Provider, Maritime Domain Awareness, Indian Ocean Region

Newspaper words

convenes	आयोजित करता है	calls people together for a formal meeting
statutory	वैधानिक	decided, controlled, or required by a law
adjudications	न्यायिक निर्णय	formal judgments or decisions made by a court or tribunal
robust	मजबूत या सशक्त	strong, effective, and unlikely to fail
hegemony	वर्चस्व	dominance or supreme influence by one group or country over others

Saturday, 3 October 2026

GS2 · Polity

1. Over two lakh special Gram Sabhas held across India on Gandhi Jayanti

Around 2.42 lakh special Gram Sabhas focused on people-centric initiatives and grassroots discussions to strengthen local governance.

What happened	On Gandhi Jayanti, 2.42 lakh special Gram Sabhas were organized across the country to discuss and implement grassroots, people-centric initiatives.
Why UPSC cares	Gram Sabhas are the cornerstone of decentralized governance. This highlights grassroot democracy and participatory planning under Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs).
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Devolution of powers and finances up to local levels and challenges therein.
Chapter	Polity: Village Democracy: Panchayats

Read it for

1. Structure and constitutional status of Gram Sabhas under the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act.
2. Role of Gram Sabhas in decentralized planning and implementing welfare schemes.
3. Challenges faced by local bodies in terms of functional autonomy and financial resources.

Key terms

Gram Sabha
A constitutional body consisting of all persons registered in the electoral rolls relating to a village comprised within the area of Panchayat at the village level.

73rd Constitutional Amendment Act
The landmark legislation of 1992 that institutionalized Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) by adding Part IX and the Eleventh Schedule to the Constitution of India.

Decentralized Planning
A planning process where local communities and grassroots institutions participate in decision-making, formulation, and execution of development plans.

Gram Panchayat Development Plan (GPDP)
An annual development plan prepared by Gram Panchayats for economic development and social justice using resources available to them.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Gram Sabha under the Constitution of India:
1. The Constitution of India defines Gram Sabha as a body consisting of persons registered in the electoral rolls relating to a village comprised within the area of Panchayat at the village level.
2. The Constitution of India provides that the Gram Sabha may exercise such powers and perform such functions at the village level as the Legislature of a State may, by law, provide.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: Article 243(b) of the Constitution of India defines Gram Sabha as a body consisting of persons registered in the electoral rolls relating to a village comprised within the area of Panchayat at the village level. Statement 2 is correct: Article 243A of the Constitution states that a Gram Sabha may exercise such powers and perform such functions at the village level as the Legislature of a State may, by law, provide.

Mains: how it could come

Gram Sabhas were envisioned as the bedrock of participatory democracy in India. However, they have often been reduced to mere advisory bodies with limited impact. Critically analyze. (150 words, 10 marks)

The 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act institutionalized Gram Sabhas as the foundation of the Panchayati Raj system, aiming to promote direct democracy and grassroots participation.

- Significance: Gram Sabhas facilitate decentralized planning, identify beneficiaries for welfare schemes, conduct social audits, and ensure executive accountability at the village level.
- Structural Challenges: Infrequent meetings, low attendance, particularly of women and marginalized groups, and lack of awareness about their rights and roles.
- Functional Issues: Dominance of local elites, lack of financial autonomy, and the reluctance of state governments to devolve adequate powers and funds.

To empower Gram Sabhas, states must mandate regular meetings, build capacity among members, enforce active social audits, and ensure genuine devolution of financial resources.

Keywords to use: Participatory Democracy, Decentralized Planning, Social Audit, Devolution of Powers, Panchayati Raj Institutions

GS3 · Economy

2. India advocates for WTO compliant measures to address global trade distortions

At the G20 Trade Ministers Meeting, India defended its domestic industrial capacity and called for rules-based remedies against trade-distorting subsidies.

What happened	At the G20 Trade Ministers Meeting in Milwaukee, India called for World Trade Organization (WTO) compliant measures to tackle global trade distortions like

	dumping and predatory pricing, while defending its own industrial capacity and policy space.
Why UPSC cares	Highlights India's shift towards global value chains and World Trade Organization (WTO) compliant trade strategies. Crucial for Mains questions on manufacturing sector and export growth.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Effects of liberalization on the economy, changes in industrial policy and their effects on industrial growth.
Chapter	Economy: External Sector of India

Read it for

1. Understand the concepts of dumping, predatory pricing, and how they distort international trade.
2. Analyze the legal trade remedies under the World Trade Organization (WTO) framework, such as anti-dumping and countervailing duties.
3. Examine the balance between global supply chain diversification and the policy space required by developing countries for industrialisation.

Key terms

Anti-dumping Duty (ADD)
A protectionist tariff that a domestic government imposes on foreign imports that it believes are priced below fair market value.

Countervailing Duty (CVD)
Tariffs levied on imported goods to offset subsidies given to producers of these goods in the exporting country.

Predatory Pricing
The pricing of goods or services at such a low level that other firms cannot compete and are forced to leave the market.

Policy Space
The freedom and flexibility of national governments to design and implement economic and social policies to achieve development goals.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding trade remedial measures:
1. Countervailing duties are imposed by an importing country to counteract the effect of product dumping by foreign private exporters without any state involvement.
2. In India, the final decision to impose anti-dumping or countervailing duties is taken by the Ministry of Finance, based on recommendations from the Directorate General of Trade Remedies.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect. Countervailing duties (CVD) are specific tariffs imposed to offset subsidies provided by foreign governments to their exporters, which distort market prices. Anti-dumping duties (ADD) are imposed to counteract the effect of dumping (selling below fair market value) by foreign exporters. Statement 2 is correct. In India, the Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR) under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry conducts investigations and recommends these duties, but the final notification and imposition of the duties are done by the Ministry of Finance.

Mains: how it could come

Explain the concepts of dumping and trade-distorting subsidies in international trade. Discuss how developing nations like India can utilize WTO-compliant trade remedies to protect domestic industries while maintaining policy space for industrialisation. (150 words, 10 marks)

Define dumping as exporting goods below their normal value, and subsidies as state support that distorts fair competition, both of which are addressed under the World Trade Organization (WTO) framework.

- Explain WTO-compliant remedies: Anti-Dumping Duties (ADD) to counter predatory pricing, and Countervailing Duties (CVD) to offset foreign state subsidies.
- Discuss the importance of retaining 'policy space' for developing countries to industrialise without facing unilateral or protectionist barriers disguised as supply chain diversification.
- Highlight the role of evidence-based investigations (like those by the Directorate General of Trade Remedies in India) and judicial reviews to ensure compliance with international trade laws.

India must strengthen its domestic trade defense mechanisms, enhance data sharing, and collaborate with other developing nations to resist protectionist measures outside the WTO framework.

Keywords to use: Anti-dumping duties, Countervailing duties, Policy space, Predatory pricing, Trade remedies

GS3 · Science and Technology

3. Ebola outbreak in DR Congo claims over 4000 lives amid surveillance challenges

The Democratic Republic of the Congo reports over 4,000 deaths from Ebola across seven provinces, with health agencies warning that surveillance gaps may hide the true scale of transmission.

What happened	The Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) has recorded over 4,000 deaths and 8,300 confirmed cases of Ebola across seven provinces, with health officials warning that surveillance gaps and insecurity hinder containment.
Why UPSC cares	Public health emergencies of international concern are vital. Understand the transmission of Ebola virus and the role of global health bodies like Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention (Africa CDC).
Syllabus	General Studies 3 (GS3) Science and Technology: developments and their applications and effects in everyday life, awareness in the fields of IT, Space, Computers, Robotics, Nanotechnology, Biotechnology and issues relating to intellectual property rights.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. Understand the transmission dynamics of the Ebola virus, its reservoir hosts, and symptoms in humans.
2. Examine the role of surveillance, case detection, and community engagement in controlling epidemics.
3. Analyze the challenges of managing public health emergencies in conflict-prone or insecure regions.

Key terms

Ebola Virus Disease (EVD)
A severe, often fatal illness in humans caused by the Ebola virus, transmitted to people from wild animals and spreading through human-to-human transmission.

Case Fatality Rate (CFR)
The proportion of people diagnosed with a significant disease who die from it, serving as a measure of the disease's severity.

Zoonotic Disease
An infectious disease that has jumped from a non-human animal to humans, often caused by viruses, bacteria, or parasites.

Disease Surveillance
The continuous, systematic collection, analysis, and interpretation of health-related data needed for the planning, implementation, and evaluation of public health practice.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to Ebola Virus Disease (EVD), consider the following statements:
1. The virus is primarily transmitted through airborne droplets, similar to the influenza virus.
2. Fruit bats of the Pteropodidae family are considered to be accidental hosts rather than the natural reservoir hosts of the virus.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is incorrect. Ebola virus disease is not transmitted through the air. It is transmitted through direct contact, through broken skin or mucous membranes, with the blood, secretions, organs, or other bodily fluids of infected people, and with surfaces and materials contaminated with these fluids. Statement 2 is incorrect. Fruit bats of the Pteropodidae family are considered to be the natural reservoir hosts of the Ebola virus, not accidental hosts. Humans and other primates become infected through contact with infected bats or other animals.

Mains: how it could come

The management of highly infectious epidemics like Ebola in developing nations is often complicated by socio-political and infrastructural challenges. Discuss the critical barriers to containment and suggest a comprehensive strategy to strengthen global health security against such outbreaks. (150 words, 10 marks)

Ebola outbreaks highlight how public health emergencies are deeply intertwined with socio-political stability, infrastructure, and community trust.

- Infrastructural Gaps: Weak disease surveillance, lack of rapid diagnostic facilities, and inadequate healthcare personnel delay early detection.
- Socio-Political Insecurity: Armed conflict and regional instability prevent medical teams from safely reaching affected communities.
- Community Resistance: Deep-seated mistrust in public authorities and cultural burial practices often accelerate transmission.
- Resource Limitations: Shortage of funding, vaccines, personal protective equipment (PPE), and isolation facilities in remote areas.

Strengthening local primary healthcare, building community trust through local leaders, and ensuring sustained international funding are vital for global health security.

Keywords to use: Zoonotic transmission, Disease surveillance, Community engagement, Global health security, Case fatality rate

Newspaper words

grassroots	जमीनी स्तर का, बुनियादी	relating to common people at the local level rather than a center of power
autonomy	स्वायत्तता, स्वतंत्रता	the right or condition of self-government or independence
predatory	शोषक, परभक्षी	using aggressive or unfair methods to exploit others or eliminate competition
surveillance	निगरानी, चौकसी	close observation, especially of a disease, situation, or person
containment	रोकथाम, नियंत्रण	the action of keeping something harmful under control or within limits

Sunday, 4 October 2026

GS3 · Science & Technology

1. India demonstrates its first 5.56 km free-space quantum key distribution link

India has successfully demonstrated a 5.56 km free-space Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) link to secure optical communication.

What happened	India successfully demonstrated a 5.56 km free-space Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) link for secure optical communication.
Why UPSC cares	Secure quantum communications are crucial for national security and cyber infrastructure. Important for General Studies Paper 3 questions on emerging technologies and the National Quantum Mission.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Developing new technologies and awareness in Information Technology (IT) and computers.
Chapter	Science & Tech: AI & Emerging Digital Tech

Read it for

1. Understand how Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) uses quantum physics principles to create unbreakable cryptographic keys.
2. Examine the distinction between free-space Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) optical communication and fibre-based systems.
3. Analyze the significance of indigenous quantum communication technology for national security and strategic data protection.

Key terms

Quantum Key Distribution (QKD)

Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) is a secure communication technique that uses quantum mechanics to exchange encryption keys between two parties. It detects any eavesdropping because measuring a quantum state inherently alters it.

No-Cloning Theorem

The no-cloning theorem is a fundamental principle of quantum mechanics stating that it is impossible to create an identical copy of an unknown quantum state. This guarantees that eavesdroppers cannot duplicate quantum cryptographic keys without detection.

Free-Space Optical Communication

Free-space optical communication transmits data wirelessly through air or outer space using laser light beams. It enables high bandwidth secure transmission without needing physical optical fibre cables.

Superposition

Superposition is a quantum principle where a particle can exist in multiple physical states simultaneously until it is measured. Measuring the particle collapses its superposition into a single definitive state.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding Quantum Key Distribution (QKD):
1. QKD transmits actual user message payloads directly using entangled photon states over long distance networks.
2. An eavesdropper can intercept and clone a quantum key without alerting the sender or receiver.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is incorrect because Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) is used solely to generate and share random secret cryptographic keys, not to send the full message payload directly over quantum channels. Statement 2 is incorrect because according to the No-Cloning Theorem in quantum mechanics, an unknown quantum state cannot be cloned. Any attempt to measure or intercept the quantum key alters its state, immediately alerting the legitimate users to the presence of an eavesdropper.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the principles behind Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) and evaluate its significance in safeguarding India's critical information infrastructure against emerging cyber threats. (150 words, 10 marks)

Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) is an emerging cybersecurity technology that leverages the principles of quantum mechanics to generate unhackable encryption keys.

- Core Quantum Principles: Relies on photon polarization, superposition, and the No-Cloning Theorem, ensuring that any attempt at eavesdropping alters the quantum state and reveals the intrusion.
- Quantum Threat Mitigation: Traditional mathematical encryption can be broken by future quantum computers, whereas QKD provides quantum safe cryptographic protection based on laws of physics.
- Strategic Applications: Enables tamper-proof encryption for defense communications, banking networks, power grids, and free-space satellite based secure links.

India should scale funding under the National Quantum Mission to indigenous QKD hardware manufacturing, expand satellite-based links, and standardise quantum-resistant communication protocols.

Keywords to use: Quantum Key Distribution, No-Cloning Theorem, National Quantum Mission, Critical Information Infrastructure

GS1 · Art and Culture

2. Ministry of Education approves five Centres of Excellence for classical languages

The Department of Higher Education has approved five Centres of Excellence across India for research, digitisation, and preservation of Classical Assamese, Bengali, Marathi, Pali, and Prakrit.

What happened	The Department of Higher Education under the Ministry of Education approved five Centres of Excellence for Classical Assamese, Bengali, Marathi, Pali, and Prakrit

	across five universities.
Why UPSC cares	Classical language designation and institutional support preserve India's literary heritage. Important for General Studies Paper 1 questions on Indian culture, heritage and language promotion.
Syllabus	GS1 Indian Culture: salient aspects of Art Forms, Literature and Architecture from ancient to modern times

Read it for

1. Criteria and benefits associated with the official declaration of Classical Languages in India.
2. Locations and host institutions selected for the newly approved Centres of Excellence.
3. Role of institutional support in preserving, digitising, and researching ancient literary heritage.

Key terms

Classical Language
A official designation granted by the Government of India to languages with high antiquity, valuable ancient literature, and an original literary tradition.

Centre of Excellence (CoE)
A specialized institutional setup created to lead advanced academic research, digitisation, and training in a specific field of study.

Pali and Prakrit
Ancient Middle Indo-Aryan languages that served as major vehicles for Buddhist and Jain canonical literature and early inscriptions in India.

Digitisation of Heritage
The process of converting manuscript archives and historical literary texts into digital formats for long term preservation and wider access.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the criteria for declaring a language as a 'Classical Language' in India, consider the following statements:
1. High antiquity of its early texts or recorded history over a period of 1500 to 2000 years is a mandatory criterion.
2. The Ministry of Culture is responsible for establishing Centres of Excellence for classical languages under its Department of Higher Education.
3. Originality of literary tradition that is not borrowed from another speech community is one of the essential criteria.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because high antiquity of early texts or recorded history over a period of 1500 to 2000 years is a primary criterion set by the Government of India for Classical Language status. Statement 2 is incorrect because the Department of Higher Education functions under the Ministry of Education, not the Ministry of Culture. Statement 3 is correct because an original literary tradition that is not borrowed from another speech community, along with a body of ancient literature considered valuable heritage, are mandatory criteria.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the significance of conferring Classical Language status to regional languages in India. How do dedicated institutional frameworks and digitisation help in preserving ancient literary heritage? (150 words, 10 marks)

Granting Classical Language status recognizes India's civilizational depth and provides direct governmental support to safeguard ancient literary traditions.

- Fosters advanced academic research, translation work, and critical editing of ancient manuscripts through dedicated university centers.
- Facilitates digitisation of fragile texts, preventing total loss of indigenous manuscripts and enabling global access for scholars.
- Provides structured financial assistance, international awards, and professional university chairs to encourage scholarship.
- Promotes national integration and linguistic equity by highlighting the ancient historical roots of non-Sanskrit traditions.

Integrating artificial intelligence translation tools and strengthening open access manuscript repositories will secure long term preservation and wider public awareness.

Keywords to use: Classical Languages, Centres of Excellence, Digitisation of Manuscripts, Linguistic Heritage

GS3 · Environment

3. UN commends India approval of GEC Phase-III clean energy scheme

The Cabinet approved the Green Energy Corridor Phase-III outlay of 1.86 lakh crore rupees to strengthen intra-State power transmission and deploy Battery Energy Storage Systems.

What happened	The Union Cabinet approved Green Energy Corridor Phase-III (GEC-III) with a total outlay of 1.86 lakh crore rupees, including 54,082 crore rupees as Central Financial Assistance.
Why UPSC cares	Grid integration and energy storage are vital for India's renewable energy targets. Relevant for General Studies Paper 3 questions on climate change mitigation and clean energy infrastructure.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Clean Energy Options and Renewable Infrastructure
Chapter	Environment: Clean Energy Options

Read it for

1. Role of intra-state transmission grid infrastructure in absorbing intermittent solar power.
2. Importance of Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) for grid stability and energy security.
3. Economic and employment dividends arising from large scale clean energy investments.

Key terms

Green Energy Corridor (GEC)
An infrastructure project aimed at synchronizing electricity produced from renewable sources such as solar and wind with the conventional grid network.

Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS)

Devices that store energy from renewable sources during peak production and discharge it when power demand increases, ensuring grid stability.

Intermittent Energy Resources

Energy sources like solar and wind that are not continuously available due to environmental factors, requiring flexible power systems.

Intra-State Transmission System (InSTS)

An electrical grid network designed to transport electricity within the geographical boundary of a single state.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the integration of renewable energy into electricity grids:
1. Solar and wind energy provide continuous baseline electricity generation without causing grid frequency fluctuations.
2. Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) help stabilize power grids by storing surplus power generated during off-peak demand hours.

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because solar and wind energy are intermittent resources that fluctuate based on weather and diurnal patterns, causing grid variability. Statement 2 is correct because battery energy storage systems absorb excess electricity generated during low demand and dispatch it during peak demand, maintaining grid balance.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the technical and operational challenges associated with integrating high proportions of variable renewable energy into the national grid. How do battery storage and grid strengthening initiatives resolve these issues? (150 words, 10 marks)

Integrating renewable energy into national grids requires addressing supply intermittency, local transmission bottlenecks, and grid frequency stability.

- Intermittency issues: Solar and wind sources vary based on daily weather, causing fluctuations in power frequency and voltage.
- Transmission constraints: Sub-optimal intra-state grid infrastructure leads to power curtailment in high-yield renewable zones.
- Battery storage mitigation: Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) absorb excess generation during low-demand daytime hours and discharge power during peak evening loads.
- Grid resilience: Infrastructure investments under schemes like Green Energy Corridor strengthen transmission networks and maintain grid operational balance.

Simultaneous focus on grid expansion, localized storage deployment, and smart grid automation will secure India clean energy goals.

Keywords to use: Intermittency, Battery Storage, Grid Stability, Intra-State Transmission

Newspaper words

demonstrates	प्रदर्शित करना	shows clearly or proves something through actions
strategic	रणनीतिक	planned to achieve a long term or overall aim
preservation	संरक्षण	the action of maintaining something in its original state
intermittent	रुक-रुक कर होने वाला	occurring at irregular intervals; not continuous
dividends	लाभ या प्रतिफल	a benefit or advantage from an action or policy

Monday, 5 October 2026

GS3 · Science and Technology

1. National Supercomputing Mission drives India towards self reliance

The joint initiative by the Department of Science and Technology and the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology aims to build a globally competitive, indigenous high performance computing ecosystem.

What happened	The government highlighted the progress of the National Supercomputing Mission, launched in April 2015 with an outlay of about 4,500 crore rupees to build indigenous high performance computing capabilities.
Why UPSC cares	High performance computing builds technological self-reliance and cuts import reliance. The National Supercomputing Mission (NSM) is crucial for indigenous research, system software, and hardware development.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: developments and their applications and effects in everyday life, indigenisation of technology and developing new technology.
Chapter	Science & Tech: AI & Emerging Digital Tech

Read it for

1. The institutional structure and steering ministries of the National Supercomputing Mission.
2. The core objectives of the mission including indigenous hardware and software development.
3. The applications and benefits of high performance computing for research and industry.

Key terms

Supercomputing
High performance computing using powerful systems to perform complex calculations at extremely high speeds.

High Performance Computing (HPC)
The practice of aggregating computing power in a way that delivers much higher performance than typical computers to solve large problems.

Indigenisation
The process of developing and manufacturing technologies, hardware, and software within the country to reduce dependence on imports.

FLOPS
Floating Point Operations Per Second, which is a metric used to measure the processing speed and performance of a supercomputer.

Mains: how it could come

What is the significance of the National Supercomputing Mission in fostering technological self-reliance in India? Discuss the key challenges in building an indigenous high-performance computing ecosystem. (150 words, 10 marks)

The National Supercomputing Mission (NSM), launched in 2015 as a joint initiative of the Department of Science and Technology (DST) and the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), aims to build a competitive indigenous supercomputing grid.

- Significance: Enhances research capabilities in weather forecasting, climate modeling, and drug discovery.
- Significance: Reduces dependence on imported technology and fosters domestic hardware and software design.
- Challenges: High capital costs and infrastructure requirements for establishing supercomputing centers.
- Challenges: Heavy reliance on imported critical components like advanced semiconductor chips and processors.
- Challenges: Shortage of highly skilled professionals trained in parallel programming and high-performance computing software.

To achieve true self-reliance, India must link the National Supercomputing Mission with the India Semiconductor Mission to manufacture indigenous chips, while expanding academic collaborations to train specialized talent.

Keywords to use: High Performance Computing, Indigenisation, Parallel Processing, Semiconductor Chips, Research and Development

GS2 · Government Policies

2. Central release for rural housing project in Andhra Pradesh includes 3D printing pilot

The Union Minister for Rural Development handed over the first instalment of 3,600 crore rupees for 3 lakh houses in Andhra Pradesh under PMAY-G 2.0.

What happened	The Union Minister for Agriculture, Farmers' Welfare and Rural Development handed over 3,600 crore rupees for 3 lakh houses in Andhra Pradesh under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) 2.0 and laid the foundation for a 3D concrete printing pilot project.
Why UPSC cares	Rural housing under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) addresses basic infrastructure and social inclusion. It highlights cooperative federalism and targeted delivery of welfare benefits in rural areas.
Syllabus	GS2 Governance: Welfare schemes for vulnerable sections of the population by the Centre and States.
Chapter	Polity: Guiding Principles for Governance

Read it for

1. Operational guidelines and central-state funding ratio under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) 2.0.
2. Integration of modern construction methods like 3D concrete printing technology in public infrastructure.
3. Role of technology in lowering construction time, material costs, and labour demands in rural housing.

Key terms

Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G)
A flagship social welfare scheme launched by the Ministry of Rural Development to provide pucca houses with basic amenities to homeless and kutcha house dwellers in rural areas.

3D Concrete Printing Technology
An automated additive manufacturing technique that builds physical structures layer by layer using computer-controlled extruders with specialized concrete mixtures.

Additive Manufacturing
An industrial production process where digital 3D design data is used to build objects by joining materials layer upon layer, minimizing raw material waste.

Pucca House
A permanent residential structure designed with durable materials such as burnt bricks, cement, stone, and iron, intended to withstand extreme environmental conditions.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G):
1. Under PMAY-G, the cost of assistance is shared between the Central Government and State Governments in a 60:40 ratio in plain areas.
2. Beneficiary identification under PMAY-G is done solely through door-to-door physical verification by central officers without involving local Gram Sabhas.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct because financial assistance under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) is shared between the Centre and States in the ratio of 60:40 in plain areas and 90:10 in North Eastern and Himalayan States. Statement 2 is incorrect because beneficiary identification is done using Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) 2011 data, which is mandatorily verified and finalized by the Gram Sabha.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how the integration of advanced technologies like 3D concrete printing can transform the implementation of rural housing schemes in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

Rural housing schemes like Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) aim to ensure dignified living, but traditional construction faces delays and rising material costs.

- Rapid construction speed allows completion of homes in months rather than years.
- Reduced material waste and lower overall labour costs improve cost efficiency for government schemes.
- Improved structural durability and precision engineering ensure resistance to environmental hazards.
- Challenges include high initial capital cost for machinery and requirement of skilled operators in rural areas.

Promoting localized training programs for machine operators and encouraging public-private partnerships can scale 3D printing in affordable housing across India.

Keywords to use: Additive manufacturing, Rural infrastructure, Cost efficiency, Disaster resilience

GS3 · Economy

3. Financial sector restoration drives economic stability and growth

India's Gross Non-Performing Assets fell to 1.68 percent in June while external sector stability was maintained with a Current Account Deficit of 0.6 percent of Gross Domestic Product.

What happened	Official statements highlighted that India's Gross Non-Performing Assets fell to 1.68 percent in June while Current Account Deficit remained manageable at 0.6 percent of Gross Domestic Product.
Why UPSC cares	Bank recapitalisation and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) have strengthened balance sheets, ensuring financial stability. Regulatory oversight and credit flow remain pivotal for sustained national growth.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: money and banking, external sector reforms and economic stability.
Chapter	Economy: Money and Banking

Read it for

1. Role of Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) and recapitalization in lowering bank Gross Non-Performing Assets (GNPA).
2. External sector resilience through export diversification and Free Trade Agreements (FTA).
3. Impact of improved corporate performance on India's macroeconomic stability.

Key terms

Gross Non-Performing Assets (GNPA)
Total value of loans that default or are in arrears where principal or interest payments are overdue beyond a specified period.

Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC)
A comprehensive law enacted in 2016 to consolidate and reorganize insolvency resolution processes for corporate debtors and individuals in a time-bound manner.

Current Account Deficit (CAD)

A measurement of a country's trade where the value of imported goods and services exceeds the value of exported goods and services.

Bank Recapitalization

The process of injecting capital into financial institutions, often by government equity investment or bonds, to help them maintain capital adequacy and meet regulatory requirements.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding Non-Performing Assets (NPA) and insolvency resolution in India:
1. A loan asset is classified as non-performing if the interest or principal payment remains overdue for more than 180 days.
2. The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) provides a time-bound insolvency resolution framework for corporate persons and individuals.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because standard regulatory guidelines classify a loan as a Non-Performing Asset when payments remain overdue for more than 90 days, not 180 days. Statement 2 is correct because the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code of 2016 creates a unified, time-bound legal framework for corporate and individual insolvency resolution.

Mains: how it could come

"Restoration of financial sector health and prudent external sector management are twin pillars of economic growth." Discuss in the context of recent financial reforms in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

A robust financial sector combined with external sector stability provides the foundation for sustainable macroeconomic growth and investment.

- Legislative reforms such as the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) and bank recapitalization helped lower Gross Non-Performing Assets (GNPA) to 1.68 percent.
- Improved commercial bank profitability and stronger capital buffers enhanced credit growth to key economic sectors.
- Prudent external balance management kept the Current Account Deficit (CAD) low at 0.6 percent of Gross Domestic Product (GDP).
- Diversification of export markets, Free Trade Agreements (FTA), and resilient service exports buffered the economy against global economic shocks.

Continued structural governance in public sector banks and expanding bilateral Free Trade Agreements will sustain this growth trajectory.

Keywords to use: Gross Non-Performing Assets (GNPA), Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), Current Account Deficit (CAD), Bank Recapitalization, External Sector Resilience

Newspaper words

indigenous	स्वदेशी, स्थानीय	originating or occurring naturally in a particular place; native
outlay	परिव्यय, कुल खर्च	an amount of money spent on something
integration	एकीकरण, समन्वय	the act of combining or coordinating separate elements into a whole
resilience	लचीलापन, आघातसह्यता	the capacity to recover quickly from difficulties; toughness
diversification	विविधीकरण	the process of expanding or varying range of products or activities

Tuesday, 6 October 2026

GS2 · International Relations

1. India calls for restructuring global financial institutions at UN

At the United Nations General Assembly Second Committee, India pushed for reforms to ensure fair financing and voice for the Global South.

What happened	India reiterated its call at the UN General Assembly Second Committee to reform international financial institutions, pledging grants and sharing expertise in digital public infrastructure.
Why UPSC cares	India highlighted reforms in International Financial Institutions (IFIs) at the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA). Reforming global governance bodies is vital for the Global South.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity and Governance: India's external relations, bilateral and multilateral groupings involving India.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Why India demands restructuring of Bretton Woods and international financial bodies.
2. The role and mandate of the United Nations General Assembly Second Committee.
3. India's South-South cooperation model based on grants, digital public goods and capacity building.

Key terms

Global South
A term referring broadly to developing, emerging or lower-income nations, mostly located in Africa, Latin America and Asia.

UNGA Second Committee
The Economic and Financial Committee of the United Nations General Assembly, dealing with global macroeconomic policy, financing for development and sustainable growth.

Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)
Digital networks such as open identity, payment and data-sharing systems that allow governments and businesses to deliver essential public services efficiently.

South-South Cooperation
A framework where developing nations share knowledge, skills, resources and technical expertise with one another without traditional donor conditionalities.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) and its subsidiary bodies:
1. The Second Committee of the UNGA deals with economic, financial, and sustainable development matters.
2. All member states of the United Nations are entitled to representation on the Second Committee.
3. The resolutions passed by the Second Committee and endorsed by the UNGA are generally non-binding in nature.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: The Second Committee is designated as the Economic and Financial Committee, handling issues related to economic growth, financing for development, and the 2030 Agenda. Statement 2 is correct: Like all six Main Committees of the UNGA, all member states of the United Nations have the right to be represented. Statement 3 is correct: UN General Assembly resolutions, including those arising from the Second Committee, carry political weight but are recommendatory and non-binding in international law.

Mains: how it could come

The existing multilateral financial architecture fails to reflect the economic realities and developmental imperatives of the 21st century. Discuss the reforms needed, highlighting India's role in advancing the priorities of the Global South. (150 words, 10 marks)

The post-World War II Bretton Woods institutions face a legitimacy and effectiveness crisis due to disproportionate Western control, rigid lending conditions, and inadequate climate financing for developing nations.

- Structural imbalances: Quota and voting distributions in bodies like the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and World Bank fail to represent the growing economic weight of emerging markets.
- Financing challenges: Developing countries face high borrowing costs, debt distress, and conditional lending, limiting their fiscal space for Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).
- Key reforms needed: Expanding concessional capital, democratising voting governance, re-channelling Special Drawing Rights (SDRs), and delinking climate finance from commercial debt.
- India's leadership: Championing South-South partnerships via non-conditional grant funds (India-UN Fund), initiating global coalitions (ISA, CDRI), and promoting Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) as an open development model.

Revamping global governance requires multilateral institutions to adopt predictable, accessible financing instruments that align with nationally determined development priorities rather than imposing external mandates.

Keywords to use: Bretton Woods institutions, Global South, Quota reforms, Concessional finance, Digital Public Infrastructure

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. India's eSanjeevani crosses fifty crore teleconsultations

The national telemedicine platform has emerged as the world's largest digital primary healthcare initiative, conducting up to three lakh consultations daily.

What happened	The eSanjeevani platform has crossed fifty crore teleconsultations, supporting over 1.42 lakh Ayushman Arogya Mandir spokes and nineteen thousand medical hubs.
Why UPSC cares	National Telemedicine Service, eSanjeevani, achieved 50 crore teleconsultations. Digital healthcare expansion is a vital topic under healthcare infrastructure and technology integration in governance.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: developments and their applications and effects in everyday life.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. The architecture of eSanjeevani and its integration with the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM).
2. The role of digital technology in overcoming geographical barriers to deliver equitable primary healthcare.
3. The challenges of digital literacy and internet connectivity in rural telemedicine implementation.

Key terms

Telemedicine
The delivery of healthcare services using information and communication technologies where distance is a critical factor.

Hub and Spoke Model
A distribution network where a centralized hub offers specialized services to multiple connected spokes at the periphery.

Ayushman Arogya Mandir
Primary healthcare centres in India upgraded to provide comprehensive healthcare closer to people's homes.

Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM)
A national initiative to develop the digital backbone necessary to support the integrated digital health infrastructure of India.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the telemedicine ecosystem in India, consider the following statements:
1. Telemedicine Practice Guidelines in India allow Registered Medical Practitioners (RMPs) to provide consultations using chat, video, and audio mediums.
2. Under the eSanjeevani platform, the patient-to-doctor model enables direct consultations between citizens and doctors.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: The Telemedicine Practice Guidelines, issued jointly by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and NITI Aayog, allow Registered Medical Practitioners (RMPs) to provide telemedicine consultations using various digital mediums like text, audio, or video. Statement 2 is correct: eSanjeevani operates in two modes: eSanjeevaniABDM (assisted telemedicine, provider-to-provider model) and eSanjeevaniOPD (patient-to-doctor model), which enables direct consultations between citizens and doctors from their homes.

Mains: how it could come

Digital health interventions like eSanjeevani are transforming healthcare delivery in rural India. Discuss the opportunities and challenges associated with the scaling up of telemedicine in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

Introduce eSanjeevani as a key component of India's digital health ecosystem, bridging the geographical divide in healthcare access.

- Opportunities: Overcomes specialist shortages in rural areas, reduces out-of-pocket expenditure on travel, and integrates with Ayushman Arogya Mandirs.
- Challenges: Digital divide and poor internet connectivity in remote areas, lack of physical examination limitations, and data privacy concerns under digital health records.

Strengthening rural digital infrastructure, training community health officers, and ensuring robust data protection frameworks will make telemedicine more effective.

Keywords to use: Out-of-pocket expenditure, Digital divide, Hub and spoke model, Universal Health Coverage (UHC)

GS1 · Geography

3. First cargo vessel sails from Assam to Bangladesh via national waterway

A vessel carrying methanol from Dibrugarh set sail for Dhaka, reviving the Brahmaputra trade corridor after eight decades.

What happened	A maiden international cargo ship carrying methanol from Assam Petro-Chemicals Limited sailed from Bogibeel in Dibrugarh to Pangaon Port in Dhaka.
Why UPSC cares	The first international cargo vessel carrying methanol was flagged off from Dibrugarh to Bangladesh on the Brahmaputra. Inland Water Transport (IWT) development is

	critical for regional trade and logistics.
Syllabus	GS1 Geography: distribution of key infrastructure and economic geography of transport corridors.
Chapter	Geography: Physiography of India

Read it for

1. Inland waterways geography: the stretch and significance of National Waterway-2 along the Brahmaputra river.
2. Cross-border connectivity: the Indo-Bangladesh Protocol Route and its role in multimodal transit for Northeast India.
3. Economic geography: lowering logistics costs and shifting freight transport from congested road corridors to waterways.

Key terms

National Waterway-2 (NW-2)
A designated inland waterway spanning 891 kilometres on the Brahmaputra river between Dhubri and Sadiya in Assam.

Indo-Bangladesh Protocol (IBP) Route
A bilateral inland water transit and trade framework allowing vessels of both nations to navigate designated river stretches across shared borders.

Inland Waterways Authority of India (IWAI)
The statutory body established in 1986 under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways responsible for regulating and developing national waterways.

Multimodal Logistics
A freight transportation system that integrates two or more distinct transport modes under a single contract to improve speed and reduce costs.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to inland water transport in India, consider the following statements:
1. National Waterway-2 is situated on the Brahmaputra river between Sadiya and Dhubri.
2. The Indo-Bangladesh Protocol on Inland Water Transit and Trade permits trade movement between West Bengal and the northeastern states through Bangladeshi waters.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: National Waterway-2 covers an 891 km stretch on the Brahmaputra river extending from Sadiya to Dhubri in Assam. Statement 2 is correct: The Indo-Bangladesh Protocol (IBP) on Inland Water Transit and Trade enables designated vessels to move between India and Bangladesh and provides transit routes linking mainland India (such as Haldia and Kolkata) with the northeastern states.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the strategic and economic significance of developing inland waterways in Northeast India. What physical and infrastructural challenges constrain round-the-year navigation in the Brahmaputra river? (150 words, 10 marks)

Inland waterways offer a fuel-efficient and cost-effective transport alternative, critical for reducing Northeast India's isolation caused by the narrow Siliguri Corridor bottleneck.

- Economic significance: Drastically cuts freight costs for bulk goods such as petrochemicals, coal, and agricultural produce compared to surface transport.
- Strategic connectivity: Revives historical river corridors through Bangladesh via the Indo-Bangladesh Protocol routes, enhancing trade integration and regional resilience.
- Physical challenges: Heavy silt load, seasonal braiding, massive sandbar formation (chars), and acute dry-season discharge reduction limit Least Available Depth (LAD).
- Infrastructural bottlenecks: Inadequate night navigation aids, limited terminal handling capacity, and insufficient permanent dredging infrastructure.

Promoting regular capital dredging, expanding automated fairways, and deepening multimodal transit agreements with Bangladesh will make the Brahmaputra an enduring commercial spine.

Keywords to use: National Waterway-2, Indo-Bangladesh Protocol Route, Least Available Depth, Siliguri Corridor, braided river channel

Newspaper words

reiterated	दौहराया, बार-बार कहना	repeated something already said in order to emphasize it
multilateral	बहुपक्षीय	involving or participated in by three or more parties, especially countries
equitable	न्यायसंगत, निष्पक्ष	fair and impartial; treating everyone equally
revival	पुनरुद्धार, पुनर्जीवन	an improvement in the condition or strength of something; restoration to use
congested	भीड़भाड़ वाला, संकुलित	overcrowded, full of traffic or people

Wednesday, 7 October 2026

GS3 · Economy

1. India GDP growth forecast raised to 7.1 percent for current fiscal year

Strong first quarter expansion of 7.8 percent driven by private consumption and industrial activity prompted an upward revision of economic projections.

What happened	Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth forecast was upgraded to 7.1 percent for the fiscal year following a 7.8 percent expansion in the first quarter.
Why UPSC cares	The World Bank has upgraded India's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth projection based on strong private consumption and investment, linking directly to economic growth models and national income accounting.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: issues relating to planning, mobilization of resources, growth, development and employment.
Chapter	Economy: Basics of Macroeconomics

Read it for

1. Components of Gross Domestic Product (GDP) expenditure including private consumption and public investment.
2. Sectoral performance variations across industry, services, and monsoon impacted agriculture.
3. Global downside risks such as trade uncertainties and geopolitical tensions affecting investment.

Key terms

Gross Domestic Product (GDP)
The total monetary value of all finished goods and services produced within a country during a specified time period.

Private Final Consumption Expenditure (PFCE)
The aggregate expenditure incurred by resident households and non-profit institutions on individual goods and services.

Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF)
A component of GDP expenditure measuring the net additions to fixed assets such as infrastructure, machinery, and equipment.

Monsoon Deficit
A situation where seasonal precipitation during the southwest monsoon falls below the long term regional average.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the major domestic drivers supporting India's economic growth momentum and discuss the structural risks posed by monsoon fluctuations and global headwinds. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's recent economic momentum highlights resilient domestic aggregate demand driven by robust private consumption and accelerated public capital investment.

- Growth Drivers: Strong Private Final Consumption Expenditure (PFCE) supported by urban demand, alongside robust Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF) in infrastructure and construction.
- Sectoral Trends: Outperformance in industrial activity, electricity generation, and services sector expansion.
- Domestic Risk Factors: Monsoon deficits weaken agricultural yield, dampening rural household demand and inflationary pressures.
- External Challenges: Geopolitical uncertainties and sluggish global trade weigh heavily on private sector capital investment.

Strengthening climate-resilient agriculture and executing key structural reforms will insulate domestic demand against external and seasonal shocks.

Keywords to use: Private Consumption, Capital Formation, Aggregate Demand, Monsoon Deficit, Geopolitical Risks

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. Francis Halzen wins Physics Nobel for neutrino research

Francis Halzen has won the Nobel Prize in Physics for his leadership of the IceCube Neutrino Observatory and the discovery of high-energy astrophysical neutrinos.

What happened	Belgian-born scientist Francis Halzen has been awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics for developing the IceCube Neutrino Observatory and discovering high-energy astrophysical neutrinos.
Why UPSC cares	Particle physics and detector experiments like the IceCube Neutrino Observatory are vital for Mains questions on advancements in fundamental physics and space observation technologies.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Awareness in the fields of Space and basic sciences
Chapter	Science & Tech: Nuclear Energy: Fission to Fusion

Read it for

1. Understand what neutrinos are and why they are called ghost particles.
2. Examine how underground and deep ice detectors like IceCube work.
3. Explore the significance of multi-messenger astronomy in modern science.

Key terms

Neutrino

An elementary particle that has an extremely small mass and no electrical charge, making it pass through matter almost unaffected.

IceCube Neutrino Observatory

A particle detector built at the South Pole designed to observe high-energy neutrinos from deep space by detecting Cherenkov radiation.

Astroparticle Physics

A branch of research that combines particle physics and astronomy to study elementary particles of astronomical origin.

Cherenkov Radiation

Electromagnetic radiation emitted when a charged particle passes through a dielectric medium at a speed greater than the phase velocity of light in that medium.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the significance of neutrino astronomy in modern physics. How do large-scale underground and ice-based detectors help unlock the mysteries of the universe? (150 words, 10 marks)

Neutrinos are elusive subatomic particles whose detection opens a new window for astronomy beyond traditional light and electromagnetic radiation.

- Neutrinos travel across the universe without being absorbed by dust or deflected by magnetic fields, pointing directly to their cosmic sources.
- Detectors like IceCube use massive volumes of natural ice to capture faint Cherenkov light produced by rare neutrino interactions.
- This enables multi-messenger astronomy, combining neutrino data with gravitational waves and electromagnetic observations.
- Such research deepens our understanding of high-energy cosmic accelerators, active galactic nuclei, and dark matter.

Expanding global collaboration in astroparticle physics will allow humanity to probe deeper into the fundamental laws of nature and origin of the cosmos.

Keywords to use: Neutrino, IceCube Observatory, Astrophysical origin, Cherenkov radiation, Multi-messenger astronomy

GS2 · International Relations

3. UN Secretary-General warns against stalling Security Council reforms

United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres warned member states about the consequences of failing to reform the Security Council as global membership has quadrupled since 1945.

What happened	United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres urged member nations to move forward with UNSC reforms, pointing out that membership has quadrupled since 1945.
Why UPSC cares	United Nations Security Council (UNSC) reforms and multilateral governance structures are key recurring topics in General Studies Paper 2 regarding international organizations.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Important International institutions, their structure, mandate and functioning.
Chapter	Polity: India's External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the structural composition and voting mechanisms of the United Nations Security Council (UNSC).
2. Examine the reasons for stalled Intergovernmental Negotiations (IGN) on UNSC expansion.
3. Analyze India's stance and arguments for permanent membership in a reformed UNSC.

Key terms

United Nations Security Council (UNSC)
One of the six principal organs of the United Nations, charged with ensuring international peace and security. It consists of five permanent members with veto power and ten non-permanent members elected for two-year terms.

Veto Power
The power of any of the five permanent members of the UNSC to block the adoption of any non-procedural draft resolution, regardless of international support for the draft.

Intergovernmental Negotiations (IGN)
A group of member states working within the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) to consider structural reforms of the UNSC, including expansion of membership and veto rights.

G4 Nations
An alliance comprising Brazil, Germany, India, and Japan that mutually supports each other's bids for permanent seats on the UNSC.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the United Nations Security Council (UNSC):
1. The Security Council consists of five permanent members and ten non-permanent members elected for two-year terms by the United Nations General Assembly.
2. Under the United Nations Charter, decisions on non-procedural matters require nine affirmative votes, including the concurring votes of all five permanent members.
3. Amendments to the United Nations Charter require approval by a simple majority of the United Nations General Assembly without needing ratification by permanent members.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: The UNSC consists of 15 members, 5 permanent and 10 non-permanent members elected for 2 years by the UNGA. Statement 2 is correct: Article 27 of the UN Charter specifies that non-procedural decisions require 9 affirmative votes including concurring votes of all 5 permanent members (P5). Statement 3 is incorrect: Article 108 states that amendments to the UN Charter require a vote of two-thirds of the members of the UNGA and ratification by two-thirds of the UN members, including all permanent members of the Security Council.

Mains: how it could come

The United Nations Security Council in its current structure reflects an outdated geopolitical architecture. Discuss the major impediments to structural reform of the Security Council and present India's rationale for seeking a permanent seat. (150 words, 10 marks)

Established in 1945, the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) represented post-World War II global dynamics, but its structure has failed to keep pace with the expansion of UN membership from 51 to 193 nations.

- Major Impediments to Reform: Resistance from Permanent Five (P5) members to dilute veto power, lack of consensus within regional groupings like Uniting for Consensus (Coffee Club), and complex UN Charter amendment procedures requiring two-thirds approval and P5 ratification.
- Under-representation of Developing World: Absolute lack of permanent representation for Africa and Latin America, alongside significant under-representation of Asia.
- India's Case for Permanent Membership: Represents one-fifth of global population, robust economic power, world's largest democracy, historical contribution to UN Peacekeeping operations, and commitment to multilateralism.

Comprehensive reform through text-based Intergovernmental Negotiations is essential to restore the credibility, legitimacy, and efficacy of the UNSC in maintaining global peace.

Keywords to use: Intergovernmental Negotiations, G4 Nations, P5 Veto Power, UN Peacekeeping, Global South representation

Newspaper words

projections	पूर्वानुमान	Estimates or forecasts of a future situation based on current data
geopolitical	भू-राजनीतिक	Relating to international politics as influenced by geographical factors
quadrupled	चार गुना बढ़ा	Increased or multiplied four times in size or amount
rationale	तर्कसंगत आधार	A set of reasons or a logical basis for a course of action
multilateral	बहुपक्षीय	Involving or agreed upon by three or more nations or parties

Thursday, 8 October 2026

GS3 · Economy

1. GST Council to meet in New Delhi to discuss administrative reforms

The 57th Goods and Services Tax Council meeting will propose a five-pronged plan to reduce compliance burdens and resolve disputes.

What happened	The 57th Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council meeting will discuss a five-pronged reform plan to ease compliance for small businesses.
Why UPSC cares	The Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council meeting addresses tax dispute resolution and input tax credit rules, which are relevant for Goods and Services Tax governance under Mains Economy.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Fiscal Policy and Indirect Taxes
Chapter	Economy: Fiscal Policy

Read it for

1. Constitutional provisions of the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council under Article 279A.
2. The concept of Input Tax Credit (ITC) and how automatic matching reduces tax evasion.
3. Cooperative federalism in action through the decision-making process of the GST Council.

Key terms

Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council
A constitutional body under Article 279A of the Indian Constitution that makes recommendations to the Union and State Governments on issues related to Goods and Services Tax.

Input Tax Credit (ITC)
The tax that a business pays on a purchase of goods or services used as inputs, which can be used to reduce its tax liability when it makes a sale.

Cooperative Federalism
A concept where the Union and State Governments work together to solve common problems and make joint policy decisions for national development.

Compliance Burden
The time, effort, and financial cost incurred by businesses and taxpayers to adhere to tax laws, regulations, and filing requirements.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council:
1. The Union Finance Minister acts as the Chairperson of the Council.
2. Decisions of the Council are taken by a majority of not less than three-fourths of the weighted votes of the members present and voting.
3. The vote of the Central Government has a weightage of one-half of the total votes cast in a meeting.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: Under Article 279A of the Constitution, the Union Finance Minister is the Chairperson of the GST Council. Statement 2 is correct: Every decision of the GST Council is taken by a majority of not less than three-fourths (75%) of the weighted votes of the members present and voting. Statement 3 is incorrect: The vote of the Central Government has a weightage of one-third of the total votes cast, while the votes of all the State Governments taken together have a weightage of two-thirds of the total votes cast.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2017 · Q81

What is/are the most likely advantages of implementing 'Goods and Services Tax (GST)' ?
1. It will replace multiple taxes collected by multiple authorities and will thus create a single market in India.
2. It will drastically reduce the 'Current Account Deficit' of India and will enable it to increase its foreign exchange reserves.
3. It will enormously increase the growth and size of economy of India and will enable it to overtake China in the near future.
Select the correct answer using the code given below :

a. 1 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) Official answer (UPSC answer key): A. GST subsumed many central taxes (such as excise duty and service tax) and State taxes (such as VAT and entry tax) levied by different authorities into one destination-based tax, creating a common national market, so statement 1 is correct. GST is a domestic indirect tax; the current account deficit depends on trade, services and remittances, so GST cannot 'drastically' cut it or build forex reserves. The claim that it will let India overtake China soon is an exaggeration; GST may add modestly to growth.

Mains: how it could come

The Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council is often hailed as a prime example of cooperative federalism in India. Examine this statement and discuss the challenges faced by the Council in balancing the interests of the Centre and the diverse States. (150 words, 10 marks)

Introduce the GST Council as a constitutional body under Article 279A, designed to bring Centre and States together for indirect tax decisions.

- Cooperative Federalism: Joint decision-making where neither Centre (1/3rd vote) nor States (2/3rd vote) can pass resolutions unilaterally, requiring consensus.
- Successes: Rate rationalisation, unified national market, and dispute resolution through consensus rather than voting.
- Challenges: Compensation cess disputes, revenue autonomy of states, and divergent developmental priorities between manufacturing and consuming states.

Strengthening the dispute resolution mechanism and ensuring regular, transparent meetings will sustain trust and foster fiscal federalism.

Keywords to use: Article 279A, Fiscal Federalism, Consensus-based decision making, Indirect tax reform

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. Nobel Prize in Chemistry awarded for solving the mystery of homochirality

Henri B. Kagan and Kenso Soai won the 2026 Nobel Prize for discovering how molecular asymmetry spontaneously emerges, a breakthrough with massive implications for drug development.

What happened	Chemists Henri B. Kagan and Kenso Soai won the 2026 Nobel Prize in Chemistry for discovering non-linear effects and autocatalysis in asymmetric synthesis.
Why UPSC cares	The 2026 Nobel Prize in Chemistry recognizes discoveries in asymmetric organic synthesis and molecular homochirality, which are important topics for Science and Tech in Mains.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: developments and their applications and effects in everyday life

Read it for

1. Understand the concept of molecular asymmetry, also known as homochirality, and why living organisms prefer one mirror-image form of molecules.
2. Examine the mechanisms of non-linear effects and autocatalysis in asymmetric organic synthesis discovered by the laureates.
3. Analyze the practical applications of these chemical breakthroughs in modern pharmaceutical development and therapeutic drug design.

Key terms

Chirality
A geometric property where an object or molecule cannot be superimposed on its mirror image, much like left and right hands.

Homochirality

The phenomenon in nature where living organisms exclusively use only one of the two possible mirror-image forms of chiral molecules, such as left-handed amino acids.

Autocatalysis

A chemical reaction in which at least one of the products acts as a catalyst for the same or a coupled reaction, accelerating the process.

Asymmetric Synthesis

A chemical reaction or sequence that selectively produces one specific mirror-image form of a chiral molecule over the other.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to molecular chemistry and biology, consider the following statements:
1. Chirality refers to molecules that exist as non-superimposable mirror images of each other.
2. In living organisms, proteins are almost exclusively built from Left-handed (L) amino acids.
3. The different mirror-image forms of a chiral drug molecule can have completely different physiological effects on the human body.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: Chirality is a property of asymmetry where a molecule cannot be superimposed on its mirror image. Statement 2 is correct: Homochirality in nature means that proteins in living organisms are built almost exclusively from Left-handed (L) amino acids. Statement 3 is correct: Different enantiomers of a drug can have different effects, where one form is therapeutic and the other could be inactive or even highly toxic, which makes asymmetric synthesis crucial in the pharmaceutical industry.

Mains: how it could come

What is molecular homochirality, and why is its spontaneous emergence in nature considered a major scientific mystery? Discuss the significance of asymmetric organic synthesis in the modern pharmaceutical industry. (150 words, 10 marks)

Molecular homochirality refers to the uniform handedness of biological molecules, where living organisms selectively use only one mirror-image form, such as Left-handed (L) amino acids and Right-handed (D) sugars, for building life.

- The Scientific Mystery: Standard laboratory chemical reactions naturally produce equal amounts of both mirror-image forms, known as a racemic mixture. How nature spontaneously broke this symmetry to select only one form for life remained an unsolved puzzle for a century.
- Role of Autocatalysis and Non-linear Effects: Discoveries showed that chemical reactions can be steered using self-replicating catalysts (autocatalysis) and non-linear amplification, allowing one mirror image to completely dominate and eliminate the other.
- Significance for Pharmaceuticals: Many drugs are chiral. While one mirror-image form (enantiomer) cures a disease, the other can be toxic or cause severe birth defects.
- Efficacy and Safety: Asymmetric synthesis allows pharmaceutical companies to manufacture pure, single-enantiomer drugs, enhancing therapeutic effectiveness while eliminating hazardous side effects.

Advancements in asymmetric synthesis and green chemistry will continue to refine drug design, leading to safer, highly targeted therapies and a deeper understanding of the chemical origins of life on Earth.

Keywords to use: Homochirality, Enantiomers, Asymmetric synthesis, Autocatalysis, Pharmaceutical efficacy

GS2 · International Relations

3. Prime Minister calls for a free and rule-based global maritime order

Speaking at the Sagarmanthan dialogue, the Prime Minister highlighted India's growing maritime capacity and called for international cooperation to ensure secure oceans.

What happened	The Prime Minister addressed the Sagarmanthan: The Great Oceans Dialogue in New Delhi, calling for a free, open, and rule-based global maritime order.
Why UPSC cares	Maritime security and freedom of navigation are central to India foreign policy and international maritime law discussions under International Relations in GS Paper 2.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity and International Relations: India's External Relations, bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. The concept of a rule-based maritime order and its significance for global trade and security.
2. India's maritime vision, including port modernization and the role of Indian seafarers.
3. The strategic importance of global ocean dialogues in addressing transboundary maritime challenges.

Key terms

Rule-based Maritime Order

A collaborative framework where nations adhere to international laws, particularly the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), to govern ocean activities.

Sagarmanthan: The Great Oceans Dialogue

A premier global platform organized by India's Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways and the Observer Research Foundation (ORF) to deliberate on maritime trade, technology, and security.

Viksit Bharat by 2047

The national vision of the Government of India to transform the nation into a fully developed country by the centenary year of its independence in 2047.

Turnaround Time

The total time taken by a vessel from its arrival at a port's outer anchorage until its departure after completing cargo operations.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), consider the following statements:
1. The sovereignty of a coastal State extends beyond its land territory to an adjacent belt of sea, described as the territorial sea, up to a limit of 12 nautical miles.
2. In the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), which extends up to 200 nautical miles, the coastal State has sovereign rights for exploring and exploiting natural resources.
3. Under UNCLOS, ships of all States, whether coastal or land-locked, enjoy the right of innocent passage through the territorial sea of any coastal State.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct. Under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), the sovereignty of a coastal State extends beyond its land territory and internal waters to an adjacent belt of sea, described as the territorial sea, up to a limit not exceeding 12 nautical miles. Statement 2 is correct. The Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) is an area beyond and adjacent to the territorial sea, extending up to 200 nautical miles, where the coastal State has sovereign rights for the purpose of exploring, exploiting, conserving, and managing natural resources. Statement 3 is correct. Subject to the convention, ships of all States, whether coastal or land-locked, enjoy the right of innocent passage through the territorial sea.

Mains: how it could come

In light of growing geopolitical tensions in the Indo-Pacific, discuss the significance of a free, open, and rule-based global maritime order. How can India leverage its maritime capabilities to promote stability and cooperation in the region? (150 words, 10 marks)

A free and rule-based maritime order is essential for global trade, as oceans carry over eighty percent of global trade volume and act as vital lifelines for resource security.

- Significance of Maritime Order: Ensures freedom of navigation, prevents unilateral domination of critical sea lanes, and protects maritime resources under international frameworks like the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).
- India's Strategic Role: Acting as a net security provider in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) through initiatives like SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region).
- Infrastructure and Capacity: Enhancing port efficiency, reducing turnaround times, and modernizing maritime laws to align with global standards.
- Collaborative Diplomacy: Engaging in multilateral dialogues like Sagarmanthan and partnerships like the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) to counter maritime threats.

India must balance its infrastructure development with active maritime diplomacy, ensuring that international laws are respected while strengthening its domestic shipping sector.

Keywords to use: UNCLOS, SAGAR initiative, freedom of navigation, Indo-Pacific, maritime diplomacy

Newspaper words

compliance	अनुपालन, नियमों का पालन	the act of obeying rules, laws, or requests
evasion	बचाव, कर चोरी	the act of avoiding something, especially legally or illegally
implications	निहितार्थ, संभावित परिणाम	possible future effects or results of an action or decision
maritime	समुद्री, नौवहन संबंधी	relating to the sea, shipping, or navigation
transboundary	सीमा पार, पार-सीमीय	crossing or extending across a boundary or border

Friday, 9 October 2026

GS3 · Economy

1. GST Council scraps arrest powers of tax officers and raises prosecution threshold

The Goods and Services Tax Council curbed officer arrest powers, lifted the prosecution limit to 5 crore rupees, and barred small notices under 10,000 rupees.

What happened	The Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council removed the arrest powers of tax officers, raised the prosecution threshold to 5 crore rupees, and barred notices for amounts below 10,000 rupees.
Why UPSC cares	Decriminalising tax offences and raising prosecution limits are vital for tax governance, ease of doing business, and compliance under GS Paper 3.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Fiscal policy, tax administration, and ease of doing business.
Chapter	Economy: Fiscal Policy

Read it for

1. Decriminalisation of tax offences to reduce harassment and boost ease of doing business.
2. Threshold adjustments for notices and prosecutions to rationalise tax administration.
3. The institutional mandate and federal decision-making mechanism of the GST Council.

Key terms

Goods and Services Tax Council (GST Council)
A constitutional body established under Article 279A to make recommendations to the Union and States on issues related to the Goods and Services Tax.

Tax prosecution
Legal proceedings initiated in a court of law against an individual or business entity for deliberate tax evasion or fraudulent practices.

Decriminalisation
The legislative process of removing criminal sanctions such as arrest or jail time from minor civil or procedural economic defaults.

Monetary threshold
A prescribed financial floor below which administrative actions, show-cause notices, or legal prosecutions cannot be initiated.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council, consider the following statements:
1. Every decision of the GST Council requires a majority of not less than three-fourths of the weighted votes of the members present and voting.
2. The vote of the Central Government has a weightage of one-half of the total votes cast in that meeting.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: Under Article 279A, every decision of the GST Council is taken by a majority of not less than three-fourths of the weighted votes of the members present and voting. Statement 2 is incorrect: The vote of the Central Government has a weightage of one-third of the total votes cast, while the votes of all State Governments combined have a weightage of two-thirds of the total votes cast.

Mains: how it could come

Decriminalising minor offences under indirect tax laws is crucial to promoting the ease of doing business without compromising tax compliance. Discuss. (150 words, 10 marks)

Decriminalisation of tax administration separates routine procedural errors from fraudulent tax evasion, fostering mutual trust between taxpayers and the state.

- Boosts ease of doing business: Removing arresting powers and raising prosecution thresholds curbs administrative overreach and the fear of arbitrary harassment among entrepreneurs.
- Reduces judicial backlog: Setting minimum monetary thresholds for notices screens out petty claims, enabling tax tribunals and courts to focus on high-value litigation.
- Ensures proportionate enforcement: Routine delays or clerical mistakes are met with interest, recovery, and penalties rather than criminal proceedings.
- Protects revenue through technology: Enhanced digital audits and data analytics enable revenue authorities to trace systemic fraud without relying on coercive physical arrests.

A transparent, rule-based tax ecosystem paired with rigorous data intelligence is essential to balance voluntary compliance with effective deterrence.

Keywords to use: Decriminalisation, Ease of doing business, Tax compliance, Administrative overreach, Proportionate penalty

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. Government caps trade margins on non-scheduled anti-cancer drugs at 30 percent

The Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers has capped trade margins on non-scheduled cancer medicines to curb profiteering and lower patient costs.

What happened	The government has capped the trade margin on non-scheduled anti-cancer drugs at 30 percent of the Maximum Retail Price (MRP) to lower treatment costs.
Why UPSC cares	Regulating trade margins on critical medicines directly links to affordable healthcare, out-of-pocket expenditure, and pharmaceutical policy under GS Paper 3.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: developments and their applications and effects in everyday life.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. Understand the regulatory role of the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) in controlling drug prices.
2. Examine the distinction between scheduled and non-scheduled formulations under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order.
3. Analyze the impact of high out of pocket expenditure on healthcare and the need for price control in critical care.

Key terms

Scheduled Formulations
Medicines that are listed in the National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM) and are subject to strict price ceilings set by the government.

Non-scheduled Formulations
Medicines that are not included in the National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM), whose prices are monitored to ensure annual increases do not exceed a set limit.

National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA)
An independent regulator in India under the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers that controls and regulates the prices of pharmaceutical drugs.

Out of Pocket Expenditure
Direct payments made by individuals to healthcare providers at the time of service, which are not covered by insurance or public funding.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) in India, consider the following statements:
1. It functions as an attached office of the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers.
2. It is empowered to recover amounts overcharged by manufacturers for controlled drugs under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct. The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) is an independent body of experts under the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers. Statement 2 is correct. It is mandated to enforce prices and availability of medicines, and to recover amounts overcharged by manufacturers for controlled drugs under the provisions of the Drugs (Prices Control) Order.

Mains: how it could come

High out of pocket expenditure on healthcare remains a major driver of poverty in India. In this context, evaluate the effectiveness of regulatory interventions like capping trade margins on critical medicines. (150 words, 10 marks)

Out of pocket expenditure accounts for nearly half of India's total health expenditure, often pushing vulnerable families into poverty due to high cost of critical care like cancer treatment.

- Regulatory measures like capping trade margins on non-scheduled drugs directly lower the Maximum Retail Price (MRP), making life-saving treatments accessible.
- It curbs excessive profiteering by intermediaries in the supply chain without discouraging manufacturers from producing essential drugs.
- However, price controls alone cannot solve healthcare challenges, as they might lead to artificial shortages or compromise quality if not monitored effectively.
- A comprehensive approach requires strengthening public health infrastructure, expanding universal health insurance coverage, and promoting generic medicines.

While price regulation is a vital short-term relief, long-term healthcare equity depends on robust public spending, domestic manufacturing of active pharmaceutical ingredients, and universal health coverage.

Keywords to use: Out of pocket expenditure, National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority, Trade margin rationalisation, Universal health coverage, Essential medicines

GS2 · Polity

3. Central Armed Police Forces Act 2026 comes into force

The legislation reserves key top-level leadership positions in the Central Armed Police Forces for deputed Indian Police Service officers.

What happened	The Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Act, 2026 came into force on 8th October 2026, reserving specific percentages of top leadership ranks for Indian Police Service (IPS) officers.
Why UPSC cares	Legislation governing administrative quotas and service rules in security forces is directly linked to internal security and administrative reforms under GS Paper 2.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Public Services, and GS3 Security: Security forces and agencies and their mandate.
Chapter	Polity: Public Services: Key Facts & Functions

Read it for

1. Administrative control and command structure of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF)
2. The role and rules of Indian Police Service (IPS) deputation in central forces
3. Issues of cadre management and promotional avenues for directly recruited CAPF officers

Key terms

Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF)
Armed forces under the authority of the Ministry of Home Affairs responsible for internal security and border guarding.

Deputation
The temporary transfer of a government employee from their parent cadre or department to another organization or post.

Indian Police Service (IPS)
One of the three All India Services of India, primarily responsible for policing, law and order, and internal security.

Cadre Officers
Officers who are directly recruited into a specific service cadre and spend their entire career progressing within that service.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements:
1. Parliament can create new All India Services common to the Union and the States if the Rajya Sabha passes a resolution supported by not less than two-thirds of the members present and voting.
2. The members of All India Services are recruited and trained by the Central Government but are allocated to different State cadres.

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Under Article 312 of the Constitution, Parliament can create new All India Services if the Rajya Sabha passes a resolution supported by not less than two-thirds of the members present and voting. The members of these services are recruited and trained by the Union government but are assigned to various State cadres to serve both the Centre and the States.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the administrative and operational implications of appointing All India Services officers to lead Central Armed Police Forces. Suggest measures to balance cadre progression with external leadership. (150 words, 10 marks)

Briefly explain the structure of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) and the practice of appointing Indian Police Service (IPS) officers at top ranks.

- Operational benefits: IPS officers bring diverse law and order experience and ensure better coordination between state police forces and central agencies.
- Cadre issues: Heavy reliance on deputation limits the career progression of directly recruited CAPF officers, affecting organizational morale.
- Operational challenges: External officers may lack deep familiarity with the specific specialized operational environments of forces like Border Security Force (BSF) or Central Industrial Security Force (CISF).

Implement a hybrid model with clear promotional pathways for cadre officers while maintaining a structured, merit-based selection process for top leadership.

Keywords to use: All India Services, cadre management, internal security coordination, career progression, deputation policy

Newspaper words

punitive	दंडात्मक	intended as a punishment
rationalise	तर्कसंगत बनाना	to make a system or process more logical and efficient
profiteering	मुनाफाखोरी	the act of making unfair or excessive financial profits
affordability	वहनीयता	the state of being reasonably priced so people can pay for it
deputation	प्रतिनियुक्ति	temporary transfer of an official to another post or department

Saturday, 10 October 2026

GS1 · Physical Geography

1. Strong El Niño conditions forecast to peak by December

Central and eastern tropical Pacific sea surface temperatures are projected to reach record levels before early 2027.

What happened	Sea-surface temperatures in the tropical Pacific are reaching historic highs with conditions set to peak in December 2026 and persist through February 2027.
Why UPSC cares	Track the El Nino Southern Oscillation (ENSO) cycle for Mains. Understand its physical mechanism and widespread impacts on the Indian monsoon, droughts, and global climate patterns.
Syllabus	GS1 Physical Geography: Important Geophysical phenomena and changes in critical geographical features.
Chapter	Geography: Climatology

Read it for

1. Understand the ocean-atmosphere coupling that drives the El Niño-Southern Oscillation (ENSO) cycle.
2. Track how tropical Pacific sea-surface temperature anomalies affect the Indian summer monsoon.
3. Analyze global teleconnections that create concurrent droughts and floods across distant continents.

Key terms

El Niño
An anomalous warming of sea-surface temperatures in the central and east-central equatorial Pacific Ocean, recurring every two to seven years.

Walker Circulation
An east-west atmospheric circulation cell over the equatorial Pacific driven by temperature and pressure differences between the eastern and western ocean basins.

Teleconnection
A significant recurring atmospheric linkage between climate anomalies separated by thousands of kilometres across the globe.

El Niño-Southern Oscillation (ENSO)
A coupled ocean-atmosphere climate cycle involving fluctuations in Pacific water temperatures and atmospheric pressure overlying the basin.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the El Niño phenomenon:
1. It is characterised by an unusually strong upwelling of cold, nutrient-rich water off the coast of Peru.
2. It leads to a weakening or breakdown of the normal equatorial Pacific Walker Circulation.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because an El Niño suppresses or stops the regular coastal upwelling of cold water along the Peruvian coast due to weakened trade winds. Statement 2 is correct because the abnormal warming of the eastern equatorial Pacific shifts convective activity eastward, weakening or reversing the normal Walker Circulation cell.

Mains: how it could come

Explain the physical mechanism of the El Niño phenomenon and discuss its consequences on global weather patterns and the Indian monsoon. (150 words, 10 marks)

El Niño denotes the anomalous warming of sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern equatorial Pacific, forming the warm phase of the El Niño-Southern Oscillation (ENSO).

- Physical Mechanism: Weakening of easterly trade winds flattens the thermocline across the Pacific, halting eastern cold-water upwelling and displacing atmospheric convection eastward.
- Global Weather Disruptions: Teleconnections bring heavy rains and flooding to coastal Peru and southern United States, while triggering severe droughts and bushfires in Australia and Indonesia.
- Impact on Indian Monsoon: The descending limb of the altered Walker Circulation often settles over the Indian subcontinent, suppressing moisture convection and causing deficient southwest monsoon rainfall.
- Compensating Factors: The negative impact on Indian rains can be modulated by concurrent positive Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) events or favorable Madden-Julian Oscillations (MJO).

Robust predictive modeling, drought contingency planning, and climate-resilient cropping strategies are vital to mitigate risks posed by super El Niño events.

Keywords to use: Walker Circulation, Thermocline, Teleconnections, Southwest Monsoon, Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD)

GS2 · International Relations

2. India and Ethiopia seek stronger partnership to voice Global South concerns

The External Affairs Minister met the Ethiopian Prime Minister in Addis Ababa and highlighted the four-fold crisis impacting developing nations.

What happened	External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met Ethiopian Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed Ali in Addis Ababa and addressed bilateral cooperation and Global South challenges.

Why UPSC cares	Relevant for bilateral ties and South-South cooperation. Assess the strategic importance of the Horn of Africa and India's developmental partnership with African nations.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the concept of South-South cooperation and India's role as a voice for the Global South.
2. Examine the components and developmental impact of the fuel, food, fertilisers, and finance crisis on developing countries.
3. Track the geopolitical relevance of India-Africa relations and shared demands for multilateral institutional reforms.

Key terms

Global South
A broad term referring to economically developing, emerging, or lower-income nations predominantly situated in Africa, Asia, and Latin America.

South-South Cooperation
A collaborative framework through which developing nations exchange knowledge, skills, resources, and technical know-how without colonial conditionalities.

4F Crisis
A composite vulnerability referring to supply disruptions and price shocks across fuel, food, fertilisers, and finance affecting the developing world.

Adwa Memorial
A historical site in Addis Ababa honouring the 1896 Battle of Adwa, where Ethiopian forces defeated colonial Italian troops, symbolising African sovereignty.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding South-South Cooperation:
1. It represents the transfer of official development aid from industrialised nations with binding macroeconomic policy conditionalities.
2. It is based on the principles of solidarity, mutual benefit, non-interference in internal affairs, and respect for national sovereignty.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because official development aid from industrialised countries with conditionalities is a characteristic of traditional North-South cooperation, not South-South cooperation. Statement 2 is correct because South-South cooperation is driven by developing countries themselves and operates on mutual respect, sovereign equality, non-conditionality, and shared solidarity.

Mains: how it could come

The compounding crises in food, fuel, fertiliser, and finance have disproportionately impacted developing economies. Discuss how India's development partnership with Africa can serve as a catalyst for collective self-reliance in the Global South. (150 words, 10 marks)

Geopolitical conflicts and pandemic disruptions have created severe external shocks for the Global South, aggravating vulnerabilities across essential commodities and international financial access.

- Demand-driven developmental assistance: India's Lines of Credit (LOC) and Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) support sovereign local priorities without intrusive conditions.
- Technological and digital solutions: Deploying Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) such as unified payments and open networks to drive financial inclusion and economic resilience across African nations.
- Food and energy security collaborations: Partnering in climate-resilient agriculture, pulses production, and green energy initiatives through platforms like the International Solar Alliance (ISA).
- Multilateral advocacy: Forging a joint diplomatic stance to demand the reform of the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) and Bretton Woods institutions.

India and African nations must convert historical solidarity into institutionalised economic integration, fostering South-South resilience against external market volatility.

Keywords to use: Global South, South-South cooperation, Digital Public Infrastructure, 4F crisis, Bretton Woods reform

GS3 · Science & Tech

3. India defence exports hit record 38,424 crore rupees in 2025-26

Defence exports surged over 60 percent with Defence PSUs contributing 54.84 percent and the private sector 45.16 percent.

What happened	India recorded defence exports of 38,424 crore rupees in 2025-26, a growth of over 60 percent, with Defence PSUs contributing 54.84 percent and private firms 45.16 percent.
Why UPSC cares	Important for self-reliance in defence production. Analyze the role of the private sector, domestic manufacturing, and export growth in strengthening national security.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: indigenisation of technology and developing new technology; Security challenges and their management.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Tech Control Regimes & Treaties

Read it for

1. Track the shift from defence import dependency to indigenous production and export capability.
2. Understand the balanced contribution between public sector undertakings and private manufacturers.
3. Analyse how defence exports enhance strategic autonomy and geopolitical influence in the Indo-Pacific.

Key terms

Defence Indigenisation
The process of developing and manufacturing military hardware, platforms, and systems within the country to eliminate reliance on foreign suppliers.

Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs)
Government-owned commercial enterprises operating under the Ministry of Defence that manufacture armaments, aircraft, naval vessels, and electronics.

Wassenaar Arrangement
A voluntary multilateral export control regime that promotes transparency and responsibility in transfers of conventional arms and dual-use technologies.

Special Chemicals, Organisms, Materials, Equipment and Technologies (SCOMET)
India's national control list for dual-use items that regulates the export of civil technologies having potential military applications.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Wassenaar Arrangement, consider the following statements:
1. It is a multilateral export control regime dealing with conventional arms and dual-use goods and technologies.
2. India is an admitted participating state of the arrangement.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because the Wassenaar Arrangement was established to promote transparency and greater responsibility in transfers of conventional arms and dual-use goods and technologies. Statement 2 is correct because India officially joined the Wassenaar Arrangement as its 42nd participating state in December 2017.

Mains: how it could come

Self-reliance in defence manufacturing is vital for safeguarding national security and projecting geopolitical influence. Discuss the challenges faced by India in becoming a global defence export hub and suggest measures to overcome them. (150 words, 10 marks)

Achieving record defence exports marks a paradigm shift from import dependence to strategic self-reliance, redefining modern national security beyond military manpower.

- Challenges include low research and development expenditure, critical dependency on imported sub-systems and advanced metallurgy, and bureaucratic licensing bottlenecks.
- Private sector players face high capital costs, asymmetric competition with established public sector undertakings, and limited testing infrastructure access.
- Measures include streamlining export approvals under Open General Export Licences, expanding positive indigenisation lists, and fostering defence innovation through academic partnerships.

Fostering joint ventures, operationalising defence industrial corridors, and increasing design capabilities will establish India as a reliable provider of defence solutions.

Keywords to use: strategic autonomy, positive indigenisation, defence industrial corridors, dual-use technologies, export clearances

Newspaper words

anomalies	विसंगतियाँ	Deviations from what is standard, normal, or expected
concurrent	एक साथ होने वाले	Happening, existing, or done at the same time
pivot	रणनीतिक बदलाव	A fundamental change or shift in strategy or direction
indigenisation	स्वदेशीकरण	The process of developing and producing goods within one's own country
strategic autonomy	रणनीतिक स्वायत्तता	A state's ability to make independent foreign policy decisions

Sunday, 11 October 2026

GS3 · Environment & Ecology

1. National Biodiversity Authority releases benefit sharing funds

A disbursement of 2.02 crore rupees from seed sector access fees will support grassroots conservation and community welfare.

What happened	The National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) distributed 2.02 crore rupees from seed sector Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) funds for grassroots conservation and community welfare.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for understanding the Access and Benefit-Sharing (ABS) mechanism under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002. Mains questions focus on community conservation and benefit sharing.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment.
Chapter	Environment: Environmental Institutions & Steps

Read it for

1. Understand the statutory framework of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 and its three-tier institutional structure.
2. Track the concept of Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) rooted in the Nagoya Protocol of the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD).
3. Evaluate how monetary mechanisms support local communities that conserve plant genetic resources.

Key terms

Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS)
A mechanism ensuring that benefits arising from the use of genetic resources and traditional knowledge are shared fairly with local conservers.

National Biodiversity Authority (NBA)
A statutory autonomous body established in 2003 under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, headquartered in Chennai.

Biodiversity Management Committees (BMC)
Local bodies constituted under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 to promote conservation, sustainable use, and documentation of biological resources.

Nagoya Protocol
An international supplementary agreement to the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD) that provides a legal framework for fair and equitable benefit-sharing.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the regulatory framework for biological diversity in India:
1. The National Biodiversity Authority is a statutory body established under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002.
2. Fair and equitable sharing of benefits arising from the utilization of genetic resources is an objective under the Nagoya Protocol.
3. Benefit claimers under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 include conservers of biological resources and creators of associated traditional knowledge.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because the National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) was created in 2003 under Section 8 of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002. Statement 2 is correct because the Nagoya Protocol to the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD) specifically governs Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS). Statement 3 is correct because Section 2(a) of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 defines benefit claimers as conservers of biological resources, their byproducts, and creators or holders of associated knowledge.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the role of the Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) mechanism under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 in promoting community-led biodiversity conservation. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) mechanism under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 aligns with the Nagoya Protocol to ensure that commercial utilization of bio-resources financially rewards traditional conservers.

- Incentivises grassroots conservation by channeling royalty and access fees collected from commercial users, such as seed or pharmaceutical firms, directly to local providers.
- Empowers local governance institutions through Biodiversity Management Committees (BMC), which document traditional varieties in People's Biodiversity Registers (PBR).
- Protects sovereign rights over genetic materials against biopiracy and unauthorized commercial exploitation by domestic or foreign commercial actors.
- Faces operational challenges including protracted dispute settlements, low compliance rates by industries, and limited bargaining capacity among grassroots communities.

Strengthening Biodiversity Management Committees and digitizing benefit-sharing flows will build transparent, self-sustaining financial models for grassroots ecological protection.

Keywords to use: Access and Benefit Sharing, Nagoya Protocol, Biodiversity Management Committees, People's Biodiversity Registers, Biopiracy

GS2 · Governance & Social Justice

2. Chief Justice calls for dedicated defence counsel in juvenile justice system

Chief Justice Surya Kant urged legal services institutions to create specialized defence counsel for children and stressed restorative care over retribution.

What happened	Chief Justice Surya Kant called for a dedicated cadre of specialized defence counsel for children and filling Probation Officer vacancies at a consultation marking ten years of the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015.
Why UPSC cares	Examines judicial reform and child rights under the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015. Important for Mains questions on legal system reforms.
Syllabus	GS2 Statutory Bodies, Welfare Schemes for Vulnerable Sections, and the Mechanism of Justice Delivery.

Read it for

1. Distinction between restorative justice and retributive justice in the juvenile care system.
2. Statutory role of Legal Services Authorities and Probation Officers under the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015.
3. Institutional gaps in legal aid clinics and child-friendly legal representation.

Key terms

Restorative Justice
A framework of justice that emphasizes rehabilitating the offender and repairing the harm caused to victims and the community, rather than purely inflicting punishment.

Juvenile Justice Board (JJB)
A statutory body constituted at the district level under the Juvenile Justice Act, 2015, comprising a Principal Magistrate and two social workers, to deal with children in conflict with law.

Social Investigation Report (SIR)
A detailed assessment prepared by a Probation Officer or Child Welfare Officer detailing a child's socio-economic, family, and psychological background to guide rehabilitation orders.

Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987
An Act of Parliament that established legal services institutions to provide free and competent legal aid to eligible persons, including all children, under Article 39A of the Constitution.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015, consider the following statements:
1. It mandates that every district must establish a Juvenile Justice Board headed by a Sessions Judge.
2. Institutional confinement of a child in conflict with law is treated as a measure of last resort.
3. A Social Investigation Report prepared by a Probation Officer is used to assess the circumstances surrounding the child.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because the Juvenile Justice Board is headed by a Principal Magistrate, who is a Metropolitan Magistrate or a Judicial Magistrate of the First Class, not a Sessions Judge. Statement 2 is correct because the statutory framework adheres to the principle of institutionalization as a measure of last resort. Statement 3 is correct because Social Investigation Reports prepared by Probation Officers or Child Welfare Officers assess the social, familial, and economic circumstances of the child.

Mains: how it could come

A restorative approach lies at the heart of juvenile justice administration in India. Discuss the institutional and procedural hurdles that hinder its effective realisation. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015 shifts penal doctrine from retributive punishment to reform, social reintegration, and restorative justice for children.

- Deficit of child-friendly legal aid: Many Juvenile Justice Boards lack functional legal aid clinics, resulting in children lacking continuous, specialised defence counsel from initial apprehension to final orders.
- Shortage of Probation Officers: Chronic vacancies impede the timely preparation of comprehensive Social Investigation Reports, which are essential for deciding individualized rehabilitation plans.
- Over-reliance on institutionalisation: Due to weak community-based foster care and mentorship mechanisms, institutional confinement often becomes the default rather than the strict last resort.
- Inter-agency coordination gaps: Police child welfare units, Child Welfare Committees, and District Legal Services Authorities often function without synchronized case monitoring.

State governments must institutionalise dedicated child defence panels under NALSA, fast-track recruitment of Probation Officers, and strengthen non-institutional community care options.

Keywords to use: Restorative justice, Juvenile Justice Board, Social Investigation Report, NALSA legal aid, Institutionalisation as last resort

GS3 · Economy

3. RBI raises daily CRR maintenance threshold to 99 percent to absorb surplus banking liquidity

The Reserve Bank of India increased the daily minimum Cash Reserve Ratio maintenance mandate from 90 percent to 99 percent starting October 16 to drain surplus banking liquidity.

What happened	The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) raised the daily minimum Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) maintenance requirement from 90 percent to 99 percent from October 16 to absorb a surplus of around 3.88 lakh crore rupees.
Why UPSC cares	Direct link to liquidity management by Reserve Bank of India (RBI). Essential for understanding Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) adjustments to absorb surplus liquidity in Mains and Prelims.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: money and banking, monetary policy instruments, and liquidity management.
Chapter	Economy: Monetary Policy

Read it for

1. Understand the mechanics of Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) maintenance and how daily minimums differ from fortnightly averages.
2. Examine the transmission channels of monetary policy tools used to manage systemic liquidity surpluses.
3. Analyze the impact of tightened liquidity rules on interbank call money rates and bank lending capabilities.

Key terms

Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)
The specified minimum percentage of a commercial bank's Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL) that it must maintain as liquid cash balances with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL)
The total of public deposits held in current accounts, savings accounts, and fixed deposits minus interbank deposits, serving as the base for calculating statutory reserves.

Banking System Liquidity
The aggregate net cash balance available with commercial banks to meet lending obligations and regulatory reserves, which reflects surplus or deficit conditions relative to central bank windows.

Call Money Market
The segment of the money market where scheduled commercial banks borrow and lend funds to each other on an overnight, uncollateralised basis to satisfy statutory reserve requirements.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) in India, consider the following statements:
1. Scheduled commercial banks are required to maintain the Cash Reserve Ratio with the Reserve Bank of India under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934.
2. The Reserve Bank of India does not pay any interest to commercial banks on the reserves maintained under the Cash Reserve Ratio.
3. An increase in the Cash Reserve Ratio reduces the lendable resources of commercial banks, thereby absorbing liquidity from the banking system.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: Section 42(1) of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934 empowers the Reserve Bank of India to prescribe the Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) for scheduled banks. Statement 2 is correct: As per Section 42(1B) amended in 2006, the Reserve Bank of India does not pay any interest on CRR balances maintained by banks. Statement 3 is correct: CRR impounds a fraction of banks' deposits as idle balances, which directly contracts the lendable pool and curbs the money creation process.

Mains: how it could come

Explain the operational role of the Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) in central bank liquidity management. How do changes in daily maintenance thresholds influence the interbank money market and monetary policy transmission? (150 words, 10 marks)

The Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) serves as a direct quantitative tool under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934 to mandate the share of deposits banks must park with the central bank.

- Liquidity absorption: Raising the daily maintenance floor restricts banks from deferring reserve holding to the end of the reporting fortnight, immobilizing surplus funds evenly across the period.
- Stabilising overnight rates: By enforcing uniform daily compliance, the Reserve Bank of India prevents sharp demand volatility in the call money market and keeps the weighted average call rate aligned with the repo rate.
- Strengthening monetary transmission: Locking surplus liquidity prevents aggressive undercutting of loan rates by banks, reinforcing the restrictive monetary stance against inflationary pressures.

Calibrated liquidity adjustments ensure smooth credit flow while preserving macroeconomic stability and keeping inflation expectations firmly anchored.

Keywords to use: Cash Reserve Ratio, liquidity absorption, call money market, monetary transmission, weighted average call rate

Newspaper words

disbursement	संवितरण	The act of paying out money from an official fund
statutory	सांविधिक	Decided, created, or required by a formal law
retribution	प्रतिशोध या दण्ड	Punishment inflicted on someone as a form of revenge or penalty
cadre	संवर्ग या दल	A specialized group of trained personnel or officers
fine-tuning	सूक्ष्म समायोजन	Making minor adjustments to improve effectiveness or precision

Monday, 12 October 2026

GS2 · Indian Polity

1. Supreme Court bars illegal detention of peaceful gatherers and curbs on movement

The Supreme Court directed authorities to permit peaceful gatherings and free movement while issuing notice on a contempt plea against officials.

What happened	The Supreme Court of India directed authorities to ensure unrestricted movement, prevent illegal detentions of peaceful gatherers, maintain normal metro services, and issued a contempt notice to the Centre.
Why UPSC cares	Supreme Court (SC) directives on peaceful gathering, barricading, and uninterrupted services link directly to Articles 19 and 21 of the Constitution of India.
Syllabus	GS2 Indian Polity: Fundamental Rights, Judiciary, and Separation of Powers
Chapter	Polity: Apex Court of India

Read it for

1. Scope of constitutional protections under Article 19 for peaceful assembly and free movement.
2. Limits on police powers regarding preventive detention and traffic barricades.
3. Judicial review and contempt powers of the Supreme Court to enforce earlier directions.

Key terms

Right to Peaceful Assembly
A fundamental right under Article 19(1)(b) of the Constitution of India that allows citizens to gather peacefully without arms, subject to reasonable restrictions like public order.

Contempt of Court
The power of the judiciary under Article 129 and Article 215 of the Constitution of India to penalise wilful disobedience of court orders or acts that scandalise judicial authority.

Reasonable Restrictions
Statutory limitations imposed on fundamental freedoms under Article 19 to protect public order, national sovereignty, state security, or the general public interest.

Proportionality Test
A judicial standard requiring that any state interference with fundamental rights must pursue a legitimate goal, use the least restrictive means, and avoid excessive harm.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements:
1. The right to assemble peaceably and without arms under Article 19(1)(b) of the Constitution of India can be restricted on grounds of public order.
2. The Constitution of India explicitly guarantees the right to strike as a fundamental right under the freedom of assembly.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct because Article 19(3) permits the State to impose reasonable restrictions on the right to assemble peaceably and without arms in the interests of the sovereignty and integrity of India or public order. Statement 2 is incorrect because the right to strike is not a fundamental right under the Indian Constitution; judicial interpretations have consistently held that freedom of speech, assembly, or association does not encompass a fundamental right to strike.

Mains: how it could come

The right to peaceful protest is an essential feature of democratic governance, yet it must be balanced against administrative duties of maintaining public order and civic life. Discuss in the light of recent judicial pronouncements. (150 words, 10 marks)

The right to peaceful protest flows from the freedoms of speech, assembly, and association guaranteed under Article 19 of the Constitution of India, forming the core of democratic accountability.

- Constitutional status: Article 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(b) protect non-violent assembly and dissent, subject only to reasonable restrictions under Article 19(2) and 19(3) such as public order.
- Administrative friction: Excessive barricading, blanket preventive detentions, and suspension of public transit often disproportionately impede citizen mobility and legal advocacy.
- Judicial standard of proportionality: As ruled in judgments like Shaheen Bagh and Anuradha Bhasin, protest rights cannot result in indefinite blockade of public transit routes, nor can executive curbs be disproportionate.

Law enforcement must adopt smart, minimal-interference crowd regulation that safeguards commuter mobility without extinguishing legitimate democratic dissent.

Keywords to use: Article 19, public order, proportionality test, preventive detention, reasonable restrictions

GS3 · Economy

2. RBI opens special dollar window for state oil marketing companies

The Reserve Bank of India will sell US dollars through designated banks to meet the daily foreign exchange needs of three public sector oil refiners.

What happened	The Reserve Bank of India announced a special window to sell US dollars to IOCL, HPCL, and BPCL via designated banks to meet their entire daily forex requirements.
Why UPSC cares	The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) opening a dollar window for public sector oil companies is crucial for exchange rate stability and external sector management.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: External Sector, Foreign Exchange Reserves, and Currency Management
Chapter	Economy: External Sector of India

Read it for

1. Understand why oil marketing companies generate lumpy dollar demand in the foreign exchange market.
2. Analyze how central bank dollar sales impact domestic liquidity and exchange rate volatility.
3. Connect central bank forex interventions to India's managed floating exchange rate framework.

Key terms

Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs)
State-owned or private commercial entities engaged in refining, transporting, and marketing petroleum products. In India, public sector refiners import large volumes of crude oil.

Foreign Exchange Intervention
The purchase or sale of foreign currency by a central bank in the foreign exchange market to curb extreme exchange rate volatility.

Managed Floating Exchange Rate
A monetary arrangement where the currency value is largely determined by market forces of demand and supply, but the central bank intervenes to curb disorderly swings.

Sterilisation
Monetary actions taken by a central bank, such as open market operations, to offset the impact of foreign exchange interventions on domestic money supply.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to foreign exchange management by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), consider the following statements:
1. Direct sales of foreign currency by the RBI in the foreign exchange market expand the domestic rupee liquidity.
2. Opening a dedicated foreign exchange window for large importers removes concentrated commercial demand from the spot foreign exchange market.
3. The RBI follows a managed float regime where interventions primarily aim to curb excessive exchange rate volatility rather than defend a predetermined target rate.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because selling foreign exchange involves absorbing domestic rupee currency from the market, which contracts domestic liquidity. Statement 2 is correct because supplying dollars directly through a separate facility prevents large oil marketing companies from bidding up dollars in the open spot interbank foreign exchange market. Statement 3 is correct because the Reserve Bank of India does not fix or target an official parity for the rupee; its stated policy is to intervene only to prevent extreme, disorderly market volatility.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2022 · Q3

With reference to the Indian economy, consider the following statements :
1. If the inflation is too high, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is likely to buy government securities.
2. If the rupee is rapidly depreciating, RBI is likely to sell dollars in the market.
3. If interest rates in the USA or European Union were to fall, that is likely to induce RBI to buy dollars.
Which of the statements given above are correct ?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Official answer (UPSC answer key): B. High inflation requires the RBI to absorb liquidity, for which it sells government securities rather than buying them, making statement 1 incorrect. When the rupee depreciates rapidly, the RBI intervenes by selling US dollars in the foreign exchange market to stem the depreciation, making statement 2 correct. If interest rates in advanced economies like the USA fall, capital flows into emerging markets like India increase, forcing the RBI to buy dollars to prevent excessive appreciation of the rupee, making statement 3 correct.

Mains: how it could come

Explain how high crude oil import dependence exposes the Indian rupee to exchange rate volatility. Discuss the policy mechanisms through which the central bank mitigates such external shocks. (150 words, 10 marks)

India imports over 80 percent of its crude oil requirements, making import demand inelastic and denominated in US dollars, which significantly impacts the balance of payments.

- Vulnerability transmission: Elevated international crude prices swell the current account deficit, triggering heavy spot dollar demand and localized exchange rate depreciation pressures.
- Targeted central bank windows: Providing bilateral foreign exchange to state refiners shields the open interbank spot market from lumpy dollar bids, stemming panic depreciation.
- Spot and forward market interventions: The central bank sells foreign currency reserves and uses non-deliverable forward contracts to smoothen volatility and anchor market expectations.
- Liquidity management: Central banks sterilize the resulting rupee liquidity contraction via Open Market Operations (OMOs) or repo operations to safeguard domestic financial stability.

Long-term resilience necessitates settling bilateral energy trade in local currencies, diversifying energy sources, and expanding domestic strategic petroleum storage.

Keywords to use: Inelastic import demand, Current Account Deficit, Spot market intervention, Sterilisation operations, Managed float

GS3 · Science & Tech

3. Foundation laid for ICMR high-altitude medicine centre at Keylong

Union Health Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda laid the foundation stone for a specialized research centre in Himachal Pradesh.

What happened	Union Health Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda will lay the foundation stone of the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) High Altitude Medicine and Public Health Research Centre at Keylong on 12 October.
Why UPSC cares	The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) setting up a high-altitude research centre links to public health infrastructure and physiological science.
Syllabus	GS3 Science & Technology: Developments and their applications and effects in everyday life.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. Physiological challenges faced by human bodies at high altitudes, including hypoxia and cold stress.
2. Role of the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) in advancing specialized regional healthcare research.
3. Public health logistics and emergency medical response systems for isolated Himalayan communities.

Key terms

Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR)
The apex body in India for the formulation, coordination, and promotion of biomedical and clinical research.

Hypoxia

A condition in which the body or a region of the body is deprived of adequate oxygen supply at the tissue level due to low atmospheric pressure.

Acclimatization

The physiological process by which an organism adjusts to a gradual change in its environment, such as reduced oxygen levels at high elevation.

High Altitude Pulmonary Edema (HAPE)

A life-threatening form of non-cardiogenic pulmonary edema that occurs in unacclimatized individuals following rapid ascent to high altitude.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to human physiological responses to high-altitude environments, consider the following statements:
1. The immediate response to acute high-altitude exposure involves an increase in breathing rate and heart rate.
2. Over prolonged stays at high altitude, the kidneys decrease the production of erythropoietin to prevent blood thickening.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: Acute exposure to low atmospheric oxygen triggers hyperventilation and tachycardia to sustain oxygen delivery to tissues. Statement 2 is incorrect: Prolonged hypoxia stimulates the kidneys to increase erythropoietin secretion, which enhances red blood cell production to boost oxygen-carrying capacity, rather than decreasing it.

Mains: how it could come

High-altitude regions in India present unique biological and infrastructural hurdles to healthcare delivery. Examine the significance of targeted medical research in addressing the public health needs of mountainous border communities. (150 words, 10 marks)

High-altitude habitats are defined by hypobaric hypoxia, extreme cold, and geographical isolation, creating distinct physiological vulnerabilities.

- Biological challenges include conditions like acute mountain sickness, pulmonary edema, and chronic hypoxemia, which demand specialized clinical protocols.
- Geographical isolation and seasonal cutoff severely impede primary healthcare logistics, pharmaceutical supply chains, and emergency evacuations.
- Targeted biomedical research enables context-specific interventions, telemedicine integration, and better health policies tailored to local indigenous populations.
- Strengthening high-altitude health infrastructure provides dual benefits by supporting resident tribal populations and maintaining armed forces operational readiness.

Establishing specialized regional research centers like the one under the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) bridges translational medicine and local healthcare resilience.

Keywords to use: hypobaric hypoxia, translational research, telemedicine, emergency evacuation, indigenous populations

Newspaper words

curbs	प्रतिबंध, रोक	restrictions or limitations imposed on something
contempt	अवमानना	disobedience or disrespect shown toward a court of law
depreciation	मूल्यह्रास	a decrease in the purchasing power or value of a currency
volatility	अस्थिरता	the state of being likely to change rapidly and unpredictably
montane	पर्वतीय	relating to or inhabiting mountainous regions

Tuesday, 13 October 2026

GS2 · Polity

1. Joint Parliamentary Committee holds consultations on foreign contribution amendment bill

A 31-member parliamentary panel met varied civil society and professional groups to evaluate proposed amendments to the foreign funding law.

What happened	The Joint Parliamentary Committee examining the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 met with multiple stakeholder groups in New Delhi.
Why UPSC cares	Examines the role of Joint Parliamentary Committees in scrutinising legislation and regulating foreign funding of non-governmental organisations.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Parliament and State legislatures, structure, functioning, conduct of business, powers and privileges.
Chapter	Polity: Committees That Run Parliament

Read it for

1. Working, composition, and mandate of Joint Parliamentary Committees in scrutinising legislative bills.
2. Regulatory mechanisms governing foreign funding for non-governmental organisations in India.
3. Balancing internal security concerns with the operational freedom of civil society organisations.

Key terms

Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC)
An ad hoc committee set up by the Parliament with members from both Houses to examine a specific subject or bill.

Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA)
A central law regulating the acceptance and utilisation of foreign hospitality or funds by individuals and associations.

Ad Hoc Committee
A temporary parliamentary committee constituted for a specific purpose that ceases to exist after submitting its report.

Civil Society Organisation (CSO)
Non-governmental and non-profit groups that operate independently of government authority to pursue collective public interests.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to parliamentary committees in the Indian Parliament, consider the following statements:
1. A Joint Parliamentary Committee is an ad hoc committee constituted for a specific purpose.
2. Parliamentary committees have the power to summon witnesses and call for official documents.
3. The recommendations made by parliamentary committees are advisory and not binding on the government.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because a Joint Parliamentary Committee is an ad hoc committee set up to examine a specific bill or event, dissolving after its report is presented. Statement 2 is correct because committees can send for persons, papers, and records under parliamentary rules to conduct their inquiry. Statement 3 is correct because committee reports carry persuasive weight, but their recommendations are purely advisory and the government is not legally bound to accept them.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the significance of the parliamentary committee system in ensuring executive accountability and refining legislation. What measures can strengthen their role in contemporary governance? (150 words, 10 marks)

Parliamentary committees act as the eyes and ears of the legislature, providing specialized, in-depth scrutiny away from the partisan pressures of the main floor.

- Detailed scrutiny: Committees thoroughly examine clauses of complex bills, hearing experts, interest groups, and public stakeholders.
- Consensus building: Closed-door discussions foster bipartisan cooperation and objective deliberation across party lines.
- Executive oversight: They hold ministries accountable on budgetary expenditures and policy implementation between legislative sessions.
- Current constraints: Reduced referral of bills to committees, short tenures, and the absence of mandatory acceptance of reports weaken their utility.

Mandating committee scrutiny for all substantive bills and institutionalizing post-legislative review can reinvigorate parliamentary oversight.

Keywords to use: parliamentary committee, executive accountability, legislative scrutiny, bipartisan deliberation, stakeholder consultation

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. Centre caps trade margin on anti-cancer drugs at 30 percent

The Union government informed the Supreme Court that it will cap trade margins on anti-cancer drugs at 30 percent of the maximum retail price.

What happened	The Centre informed the Supreme Court of its decision to cap trade margins on anti-cancer medicines at 30 percent of the Maximum Retail Price (MRP).
Why UPSC cares	Vital for issues of healthcare affordability, regulatory caps on essential pharmaceutical pricing, and Supreme Court interventions in public health.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: developments and applications in health, pharmaceuticals, and public welfare.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. Regulatory mechanics of trade margin rationalisation to curb high out-of-pocket medical expenses.
2. The statutory framework for drug and medical device price regulation in India.
3. Judicial scrutiny over price disparities between wholesale supply costs and retail prices.

Key terms

Trade Margin
The difference between the price at which a manufacturer sells a product to the trade channel and the Maximum Retail Price paid by the consumer.

Maximum Retail Price (MRP)
The highest price calculated with all taxes that a retailer can legally charge a consumer for a packaged commodity in India.

National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA)
An independent regulatory body under the Department of Pharmaceuticals that fixes and revises prices of controlled bulk drugs and formulations.

Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO)
An order issued under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955, enabling the government to declare essential medicines and cap their ceiling prices.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to pharmaceutical and medical device regulation in India, consider the following statements:
1. The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority fixes ceiling prices only for formulations listed in the National List of Essential Medicines and possesses no powers over non-scheduled medicines.
2. Trade margin rationalisation focuses on capping the markup between the price to the stockist and the Maximum Retail Price.
3. All medical devices notified by the government are regulated as drugs under the provisions of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) can monitor and regulate the prices of non-scheduled drugs under extraordinary circumstances in the public interest under paragraph 19 of the Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013. Statement 2 is correct because trade margin rationalisation caps the difference between the price charged to trade partners and the Maximum Retail Price (MRP). Statement 3 is correct because medical devices in India are notified and regulated as 'drugs' under Section 3(b)(iv) of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940.

Mains: how it could come

High trade margins on life-saving drugs contribute significantly to catastrophic out-of-pocket health expenditure in India. Examine how trade margin rationalisation can balance patient affordability with the financial viability of the pharmaceutical sector. (150 words, 10 marks)

Catastrophic healthcare expenditure pushes millions into poverty in India, where spending on medicines forms over half of out-of-pocket health costs.

- Distortionary markups: The gap between the manufacturer supply price and the Maximum Retail Price (MRP) often exceeds several hundred percent, disproportionately impacting critical treatments like oncology.
- Trade margin rationalisation benefits: By capping margins at thirty percent from the price to trade, it lowers end-consumer costs without capping manufacturing revenues or discouraging domestic production.
- Industry viability: Unlike blanket ceiling price caps, trade margin rationalisation preserves manufacturer incentives for research and development while checking exorbitant retail profiteering.
- Enforcement and supply challenges: Risk of supply shortages if retailers find distribution unviable, requiring strict monitoring by the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA).

A phased rollout across critical disease categories, alongside strengthening generic drug distribution via Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana, is essential for sustainable health protection.

Keywords to use: trade margin rationalisation, out-of-pocket expenditure, National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority, catastrophic health costs, Maximum Retail Price

GS3 · Economy

3. Draft National Steel Policy Vision 2047 targets major capacity expansion and green shift

The draft framework plans to raise crude steel capacity to 604 million tonnes and cut emission intensity by 2047.

What happened	The draft National Steel Policy Vision 2047 aims to expand crude steel capacity to 604 million tonnes and reduce emission intensity to 1.54 tonnes of carbon dioxide per tonne.
Why UPSC cares	Essential for Industrial Policy, long-term manufacturing visions, and green transition strategies to make heavy industries resource-efficient.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Industrial policy and infrastructure growth.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Track production and capacity expansion targets set for the domestic steel sector.
2. Understand strategies for green steel production including scrap and hydrogen use.
3. Examine per capita consumption projections and links to infrastructure growth.

Key terms

Crude Steel

Unrefined steel in its first solid state after melting, which serves as the primary raw material for finished steel products.

Green Steel

Steel manufactured using low-carbon energy sources such as green hydrogen and renewable power instead of traditional fossil fuels like coking coal.

Emission Intensity

The volume of greenhouse gas emissions generated per unit of economic output or per tonne of industrial product manufactured.

Per Capita Steel Consumption

The average amount of finished steel used per person in an economy, serving as a primary indicator of industrial and infrastructural maturity.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to decarbonisation of the steel sector, consider the following statements:
1. Direct reduction of iron ore using green hydrogen produces water vapour instead of carbon dioxide.
2. Electric Arc Furnace technology generally has lower carbon emission intensity compared to the traditional Blast Furnace-Basic Oxygen Furnace route.
3. Steel scrap recycling requires significantly less energy than producing steel directly from virgin iron ore.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because when hydrogen is used as a reducing agent instead of carbon monoxide from coke, the chemical byproduct is water (H2O). Statement 2 is correct because the Electric Arc Furnace (EAF) route, especially when powered by green electricity and using scrap or direct reduced iron, emits far less carbon dioxide than the coal-reliant Blast Furnace-Basic Oxygen Furnace (BF-BOF) route. Statement 3 is correct because remelting secondary steel scrap bypasses the energy-intensive process of iron ore smelting, saving up to 70 percent of the energy.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the key challenges in decarbonising India's steel manufacturing sector. How can policy measures balance aggressive capacity expansion with international climate commitments? (150 words, 10 marks)

The steel sector is a foundational industry driving infrastructure growth, but it is also one of the largest industrial emitters of greenhouse gases in India.

- High capital cost and technical nascent stage of green hydrogen direct reduction systems present a severe barrier to rapid industrial adoption.
- Heavy reliance on domestic coking coal imports and legacy Blast Furnace-Basic Oxygen Furnace infrastructure delays asset replacement.
- Balancing domestic consumption growth requires scaling scrap collection networks and providing affordable renewable electricity to Electric Arc Furnaces.
- Creating fiscal incentives and public procurement mandates for low-carbon steel can overcome cost premiums.

India must integrate the National Green Hydrogen Mission with steel industrial planning to achieve sustainable capacity growth by 2047.

Keywords to use: Hard-to-abate sectors, Green hydrogen direct reduction, Circular scrap recycling, Blast Furnace replacement

Newspaper words

scrutiny	गहन जांच	close, detailed, and critical examination
mandate	अधिदेश या अधिकार	an official authority or task given to a person or group
catastrophic	विनाशकारी या अत्यधिक कष्टदायी	causing sudden, severe harm or disastrous damage
disparities	असमानताएं या अंतर	marked differences or inequalities between two or more things
decarbonisation	कार्बन उत्सर्जन में कमी	the process of reducing or ending carbon dioxide emissions

Wednesday, 14 October 2026

GS2 · International Relations

1. First BIMSTEC home ministers' meet adopts Delhi Declaration on security

Member nations agreed to combat cross-border terrorism, human trafficking, and illicit narcotics while implementing mutual legal assistance pacts.

What happened	The First BIMSTEC Home Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi adopted the Delhi Declaration condemning cross-border terrorism and urging the implementation of crime conventions.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for Mains analysis of regional security cooperation in the Bay of Bengal and institutional diplomacy under the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC).
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Regional groupings and agreements involving India.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Institutional evolution of BIMSTEC from an economic bloc into a security and law enforcement cooperation forum.
2. Regional mechanisms to curb transnational crime, terrorist financing, and radicalisation across South and Southeast Asia.
3. The role of the Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty framework in streamlining cross-border criminal investigations.

Key terms

BIMSTEC

The Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation is a regional organization comprising seven nations around the Bay of Bengal.

Delhi Declaration

A joint outcome document adopted by BIMSTEC home ministers affirming shared commitments against terrorism, radicalization, and transnational organized crimes.

Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty (MLAT)

A formal agreement between countries to gather and exchange information and evidence for the enforcement of public or criminal laws.

Anti-Money Laundering (AML)

A framework of laws, regulations, and procedures designed to prevent criminals from disguising illegally obtained funds as legitimate income.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC):
1. It was established through the Bangkok Declaration in 1997.
2. The permanent secretariat of the organization is located in Dhaka, Bangladesh.
3. Cooperation among member states is anchored in the principles of sovereign equality, territorial integrity, and non-interference in internal affairs.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because BIMSTEC was founded on 6 June 1997 through the Bangkok Declaration. Statement 2 is correct because its permanent secretariat was established in Dhaka, Bangladesh. Statement 3 is correct because the BIMSTEC Charter explicitly enshrines sovereign equality, territorial integrity, political independence, and non-interference in internal affairs as guiding principles.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2025 · Q92

Consider the following statements in respect of BIMSTEC :
I. It is a regional organization consisting of seven member States till January 2025.
II. It came into existence with the signing of the Dhaka Declaration, 1999.
III. Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka, Thailand and Nepal are founding member States of BIMSTEC.
IV. In BIMSTEC, the subsector of 'tourism' is being led by India.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. I and II
b. II and III
c. I and IV
d. I only

Answer: (d) Official answer (UPSC answer key): D. Statement I is correct as BIMSTEC consists of seven member States as of January 2025. Statement II is incorrect because BIMSTEC was established with the signing of the Bangkok Declaration in 1997, not the Dhaka Declaration, 1999. Statement III is incorrect because Nepal was not a founding member, having joined later in 2004. Statement IV is incorrect since India leads the security sector or other specific domains, while tourist sectors are led by other member nations. Thus, only statement I is correct.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze how institutionalizing security and counter-terrorism cooperation under BIMSTEC strengthens India's internal security architecture and regional stability. (150 words, 10 marks)

The adoption of the Delhi Declaration at the First BIMSTEC Home Ministers' Meeting marks a structural shift for BIMSTEC, transforming it from a trade-centric bloc into a regional security provider.

- Curbs cross-border terror networks and radicalization through real-time intelligence sharing and joint operational plans of action.
- Strengthens border governance by targeting narcotics trafficking and synthetic chemical smuggling, particularly along the Golden Triangle corridor.
- Facilitates judicial coordination through the BIMSTEC Convention on Mutual Legal Assistance in Criminal Matters, expediting evidence gathering and extradition procedures.
- Secures maritime lines of communication in the Bay of Bengal, addressing piracy, human trafficking, and illegal maritime movements.

Timely domestic ratification of pending security conventions and regular ministerial interactions are essential to build a resilient, secure Bay of Bengal community.

Keywords to use: Delhi Declaration, Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty, cross-border terrorism, human trafficking, maritime security

GS3 · Economy

2. PM GatiShakti completes five years of integrated infrastructure planning

The digital master plan has integrated over 1,800 data layers across 58 central ministries and all states to evaluate projects worth over 20 lakh crore rupees.

What happened	Prime Minister GatiShakti (PM GatiShakti) completed five years, evaluating over 400 projects worth over 20 lakh crore rupees across 58 ministries and all 36 states and union territories.
Why UPSC cares	Important for Mains questions on multi-modal logistics, infrastructure convergence, and institutional coordination under the Prime Minister GatiShakti National Master Plan.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Infrastructure: Energy, Ports, Roads, Airports, Railways etc.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Role of Geographic Information System (GIS) mapping in breaking ministerial silos for public works.
2. Impact of multimodal transport integration on reducing national logistics costs.
3. The institutional mechanism behind the Whole-of-Government governance framework.

Key terms

Multimodal Connectivity
An integrated transport network combining railways, roadways, waterways, and airways to enable smooth passenger and freight movement.

Geographic Information System (GIS)

A framework for gathering, managing, and analysing spatial and geographic data to assist evidence-based physical planning.

Last-Mile Connectivity
The final leg of a transport network that delivers goods or commuters directly from a transit hub to their ultimate destination.

Logistics Efficiency
The operational speed and cost-effectiveness with which goods and supply chains are managed and moved across an economy.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding integrated infrastructure planning:
1. It aims to eliminate departmental silos by synchronising project execution across transport and utility sectors.
2. High logistics costs in an economy can be reduced through the seamless integration of multimodal transport networks.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because integrated infrastructure planning brings various departments together onto a common framework to prevent overlapping and disjointed construction. Statement 2 is correct because multimodal connectivity optimizes cargo movement across rail, road, and ports, significantly reducing logistics turnaround times and expenditure.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how integrated infrastructure planning and geospatial technology can address the structural bottlenecks in India's logistics sector. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's logistics sector has historically faced high costs and delays due to uncoordinated execution across multiple government departments.

- Geospatial platforms provide dynamic mapping of existing and planned utility layers, preventing repetitive digging and spatial conflicts.
- Multimodal synchronisation bridges disconnects between freight corridors, highways, and ports, accelerating movement and cutting turnaround times.
- Data-driven prioritisation guides capital expenditure toward projects with high economic multiplier potential, curbing cost overruns.

Sustained capacity building across state and local planning bodies is essential to unlock end-to-end multimodal supply chain efficiency.

Keywords to use: Multimodal logistics, Geospatial mapping, Departmental silos, Whole-of-Government, Logistics cost reduction

GS3 · Environment

3. India seeks finance and technology transfer to accelerate sustainable development goals

At the United Nations General Assembly Second Committee, India highlighted that non-fossil sources form 55 per cent of its power capacity and offered to host the 2030 disaster conference.

What happened	India addressed the United Nations General Assembly Second Committee, reporting that non-fossil sources make up 55 per cent of its installed power capacity and offering to host the Fourth World Conference on Disaster Risk Reduction in 2030.
Why UPSC cares	Relevant for Mains questions on climate finance, global green technology transfer, and achieving Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) under South-South and multilateral cooperation.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment; disaster management.
Chapter	Environment: India's Climate Actions

Read it for

1. Demand for climate finance and technology transfer for the Global South.
2. Progress on renewable energy capacity and disaster risk reduction.
3. Global institutional frameworks led by India like ISA and CDRI.

Key terms

United Nations General Assembly Second Committee
The Economic and Financial Committee of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), dealing with global finance, sustainable development, and poverty eradication.

Technology Transfer
The sharing and dissemination of technologies, knowledge, and processes from developed to developing countries to enable green transitions.

Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI)
A global partnership launched by India in 2019 to promote the resilience of infrastructure systems to climate and disaster risks.

Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction
A 15-year voluntary agreement adopted in 2015 that sets global targets and priorities to reduce disaster risk and losses.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI):
1. It was launched by India at the United Nations Climate Action Summit in 2019.
2. It functions as a global platform to promote the resilience of new and existing infrastructure systems to climate and disaster risks.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: The Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) was launched by the Prime Minister of India at the United Nations Climate Action Summit in New York in September 2019. Statement 2 is correct: CDRI is an international partnership of national governments, UN agencies, multilateral development banks, and the private sector aimed at promoting the resilience of infrastructure systems to climate and disaster risks.

Mains: how it could come

Developing nations cannot achieve their Sustainable Development Goals without predictable climate finance and technology transfer from the developed world. Discuss in the light of India's recent diplomatic stances at multilateral forums. (150 words, 10 marks)

At the United Nations General Assembly Second Committee, India reaffirmed that poverty eradication and sustainable development hinge upon equitable access to finance and green technologies.

- Implementation Gap: Developing nations face high capital costs and technological deficits, hindering rapid transitions despite high domestic ambition.
- Principle of Equity: Common But Differentiated Responsibilities mandates that historical polluters deliver on the promised 100 billion dollars and post-2025 climate finance targets.
- India as a Solutions Provider: Initiatives like International Solar Alliance, Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure, and Global Biofuels Alliance offer cooperative frameworks for the Global South.

Reforming multilateral development banks and institutionalising transparent tech transfer mechanisms are essential to bridge the climate justice deficit.

Keywords to use: Means of Implementation, CBDR-RC, Climate Justice, South-South Cooperation, Disaster Resilient Infrastructure

Newspaper words

illicit	अवैध, गैरकानूनी	illegal or forbidden by law or rules
streamlining	सुगम और कुशल बनाना	making a process simpler and more efficient
fragmentation	विखंडन, अलगाव	the state of being divided into separate, isolated parts
silos	पृथक विभाग, अलग-थलग व्यवस्था	isolated systems or departments that operate without coordinating with others
accelerate	गति तेज करना, तेजी लाना	to cause something to happen more quickly

Thursday, 15 October 2026

GS3 · Science & Tech

1. NMC issues advisory on digital signatures to authenticate medical records

The National Medical Commission has issued an advisory facilitating digital and electronic signatures for remote authentication of medical records under the Information Technology Act, 2000.

What happened	The National Medical Commission (NMC) issued an advisory for registered medical practitioners on using digital and electronic signatures for remote review and authentication of medical records.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for GS3 Science and Technology. Study regulations governing digital healthcare records, telemedicine standards, and legal safeguards for patient safety and data authenticity in modern medicine.
Syllabus	GS3 Science & Technology: awareness in the fields of IT, computers, and digital public infrastructure.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Internet, Privacy & Cyber Basics

Read it for

1. Legal recognition and technical architecture of digital versus electronic signatures under the Information Technology Act, 2000.
2. The role of standardisation in digital healthcare records for patient privacy, integrity, and non-repudiation.
3. Regulatory streamlining through recommendations of the High-Level Committee on Non-Financial Regulatory Reforms.

Key terms

Digital Signature
A mathematical technique using asymmetric cryptography to validate the authenticity, integrity, and non-repudiation of a digital message or document.

Electronic Signature
A broader legal category encompassing any electronic sound, symbol, or process attached to a record to indicate intent to sign, regulated under the Information Technology Act, 2000.

Asymmetric Cryptography
A cryptographic system that uses pairs of keys, a public key open to all and a private key kept secret, to encrypt and authenticate data.

Non-Repudiation
A legal and technical assurance that the author or signer of a digital document cannot deny the authenticity of their signature on that document.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to digital signatures in India, consider the following statements:
1. A digital signature is created using symmetric-key cryptography where the sender and receiver share a single secret key.
2. The Information Technology Act, 2000 grants legal recognition to digital signatures based on asymmetric cryptosystems and hash functions.
3. A digital signature ensures data integrity by detecting whether any changes were made to the document after signing.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because digital signatures rely on asymmetric-key cryptography using a public-private key pair, not symmetric cryptography. Statement 2 is correct because the Information Technology Act, 2000 legally recognises electronic and digital signatures created through asymmetric cryptosystems and cryptographic hash functions. Statement 3 is correct because any alteration to the document invalidates the cryptographic hash, thereby guaranteeing data integrity.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2019 · Q94

Consider the following statements :
A digital signature is
1. an electronic record that identifies the certifying authority issuing it
2. used to serve as a proof of identity of an individual to access information or server on Internet
3. an electronic method of signing an electronic document and ensuring that the original content is unchanged
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c) Official answer (UPSC answer key): C. A digital signature is a mathematical scheme for verifying the authenticity of digital messages or documents, ensuring that the original content remains unchanged (Statement 3). While certifying authorities issue digital certificates, a digital signature itself is a cryptographic method of signing rather than an electronic record identifying the authority (making statement 1 incorrect in this specific context) or a simple proof of identity for general internet access (making statement 2 too broad). Thus, only statement 3 is correct.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the role of electronic authentication of health records in transforming telemedicine and healthcare delivery in India. What technical and privacy safeguards are essential to prevent misuse? (150 words, 10 marks)

The transition to electronic authentication of medical records bridges geographical barriers in telemedicine while anchoring clinical accountability under the Information Technology Act, 2000.

- Facilitates rapid remote consultations, secondary specialist reviews, and seamless interoperability across digital healthcare platforms.
- Guarantees record integrity and legal validity, eliminating ambiguity over physician liability and treatment consent.
- Protects against tampering and repudiation through robust public-key cryptography and timestamped audit logs.
- Presents vulnerabilities such as unauthorized credential sharing, private key theft, and inadequate compliance with data protection standards.

Enforcing end-to-end encryption, multi-factor hardware tokens, and compliance with the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 will safeguard patient rights.

Keywords to use: Information Technology Act 2000, Asymmetric Cryptography, Telemedicine, Data Integrity, Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023

GS2 · Polity & Social Justice

2. Cabinet approves revamp and five-year extension of social assistance scheme

The Union Cabinet extended the National Social Assistance Programme till 2030-31 with a 53,428 crore rupee outlay, lowering disability eligibility to 40 percent.

What happened	The Union Cabinet approved the continuation of the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP), renamed as Pradhan Mantri Samajik Sahayata Yojana, from 2026-27 to 2030-31 with a 53,428 crore rupee outlay, lowering disability eligibility to 40 percent.
Why UPSC cares	Essential for GS2 welfare schemes. Note the revised pension outlays, beneficiary coverage for widows and persons with disabilities, and the role of social safety nets in mitigating vulnerability.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Welfare schemes for vulnerable sections of the population by the Centre and States.
Chapter	Polity: Guiding Principles for Governance

Read it for

1. Article 41 Directive Principle on public assistance to vulnerable sections
2. Shift in benchmark disability criteria and coverage across age brackets
3. Constitutional division of responsibilities for social security schemes

Key terms

National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP)

A Centrally Sponsored Scheme providing non-contributory financial assistance to the elderly, widows, persons with disabilities, and bereaved poor families.

Benchmark Disability

A legally certified condition where a person has not less than a specified percentage of a certified disability to qualify for government support.

Social Assistance

Tax-funded, non-contributory welfare transfers provided by the State to destitute individuals who cannot provide for themselves.

Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP)

Constitutional guidelines in Part IV that guide the Union and States in formulating policies to establish a welfare state.

Mains: how it could come

Non-contributory social assistance schemes are vital for realizing the constitutional vision of a welfare state, yet they face persistent operational and financial challenges. Examine. (150 words, 10 marks)

Non-contributory welfare programmes like the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) operationalise Article 41 of the Constitution by extending financial safety nets to destitute populations.

- Constitutional significance: Translates non-justiciable Directive Principles of State Policy into tangible social rights for the elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities.
- Inclusivity and dignity: Prevents destitution among informal workers who lack access to institutional pensions or formal provident fund systems.
- Key challenges: Nominal assistance amounts fail to cope with inflation, identification errors cause exclusion, and fiscal constraints limit regular indexing to living costs.

Index pension rates periodically to consumer price indices and use digital registries with local social audits to eliminate exclusion errors.

Keywords to use: Article 41, non-contributory safety nets, welfare state, exclusion errors, inflation indexation

GS3 · Economy

3. India notifies principal purpose test in Mauritius tax treaty

The amendment introduces anti-abuse rules to deny treaty benefits to transactions created primarily to avoid taxes.

What happened	The Central Government notified amendments introducing the Principal Purpose Test to the India-Mauritius Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement.
Why UPSC cares	Vital for GS3 Economy. Understand how the Principal Purpose Test (PPT) in double taxation agreements prevents treaty shopping, curbing tax evasion and Base Erosion and Profit Shifting (BEPS).
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: mobilisation of resources, growth, and fiscal policy.
Chapter	Economy: Fiscal Policy

Read it for

1. Difference between tax evasion, tax avoidance, and legitimate tax planning under international tax law.
2. How the Principal Purpose Test curbs treaty shopping and round-tripping of capital.
3. Alignment of bilateral Double Taxation Avoidance Agreements with OECD BEPS standards.

Key terms

Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement (DTAA)
A bilateral agreement signed between two countries to prevent the same income from being taxed twice, thereby encouraging cross-border trade and investment.

Principal Purpose Test (PPT)
An anti-abuse standard that denies tax treaty benefits if obtaining that benefit was one of the primary reasons for entering into a specific transaction or corporate structure.

Treaty Shopping
The practice where an investor from a third country routes funds through an intermediary jurisdiction solely to take advantage of favourable tax treaties between that jurisdiction and the host country.

Base Erosion and Profit Shifting (BEPS)
Tax planning strategies used by multinational enterprises that exploit gaps in tax rules to artificially shift profits to low or no-tax locations.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to international taxation, consider the following statements:
1. The Principal Purpose Test is an anti-abuse rule recommended under the Base Erosion and Profit Shifting project of the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development.
2. Under a Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement, relief to a taxpayer can be provided through either the exemption method or the credit method.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: The Principal Purpose Test (PPT) was introduced under Action 6 of the Base Erosion and Profit Shifting (BEPS) project led by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) and G20 to prevent treaty abuse. Statement 2 is correct: Under Double Taxation Avoidance Agreements (DTAA), relief against double taxation is standardly granted through two mechanisms: the exemption method, where income is taxed only in one jurisdiction, or the credit method, where taxes paid abroad can be deducted from domestic tax obligations.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the significance of incorporating anti-abuse provisions like the Principal Purpose Test into bilateral tax treaties. How does India balance the prevention of tax avoidance with the imperative of attracting foreign capital? (150 words, 10 marks)

The notification of the Principal Purpose Test in the India-Mauritius tax treaty marks a shift from passive investment facilitation to aggressive prevention of base erosion and treaty shopping.

- Significance of PPT: It empowers tax authorities to look beyond legal form to economic substance, denying treaty benefits if tax advantage is a principal motive.
- Curbing round-tripping: Mauritius has historically been a major conduit for foreign portfolio and direct investment, often prone to shell company operations and domestic capital round-tripping.
- Balancing investment and regulation: Clear guidance, grandfathering provisions, and alignment with global standards protect genuine long-term capital while deterring artificial routing.
- Multilateral alignment: Implementing minimum standards under the OECD Base Erosion and Profit Shifting project provides global tax certainty and avoids unilateral retaliatory measures.

India must ensure transparent administrative guidelines so that discretionary enforcement of anti-abuse provisions does not trigger arbitrary tax litigation.

Keywords to use: treaty shopping, Base Erosion and Profit Shifting, economic substance, round-tripping, tax certainty

Newspaper words

streamlining	सरलीकरण, सुव्यवस्थित करना	making a system, process, or organization simpler and more efficient
authenticate	प्रमाणित करना, सत्यापन करना	to prove or verify that something is genuine, valid, or true
revamp	पुनरुद्धार, नया रूप देना	a comprehensive revision, restructuring, or improvement
operationalisation	क्रियान्वयन, व्यवहार में लाना	the process of putting a rule, concept, or plan into practical operation
multilateral	बहुपक्षीय	involving or agreed upon by three or more nations or parties

Friday, 16 October 2026

GS3 · Environment

1. India adds Sukhna and Sauj wetlands to take its Ramsar tally to 103

Sukhna Wetland in Chandigarh and Sauj Lake in Uttar Pradesh are designated as wetlands of international importance.

What happened	Sukhna Wetland in Chandigarh and Sauj Lake in Uttar Pradesh have been declared Ramsar sites, bringing India's total to 103.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for wetlands conservation in GS Paper 3. Examine ecological criteria under the Ramsar Convention, Montreux Record provisions, and challenges facing urban and peri-urban wetlands in India.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment.
Chapter	Environment: Global Environmental Agreements

Read it for

1. Note the geographical location and administrative jurisdiction of both newly designated wetlands.
2. Understand the criteria used by the Ramsar Convention on Wetlands to designate international importance.
3. Review the conservation duties and legal safeguards triggered by the Ramsar designation in India.

Key terms

Ramsar Convention on Wetlands
An intergovernmental treaty adopted in 1971 in Ramsar, Iran, providing the framework for national action and international cooperation for the conservation and wise use of wetlands.

Wise Use Principle
The maintenance of the ecological character of wetlands achieved through the implementation of ecosystem approaches within the context of sustainable development.

Montreux Record
A register of wetland sites on the Ramsar List where changes in ecological character have occurred, are occurring, or are likely to occur as a result of human interference.

Wetland Ecosystem Services
The direct and indirect benefits provided by wetlands, including groundwater recharge, flood attenuation, water purification, and biodiversity support.

Prelims: how it could come

Under the Ramsar Convention on Wetlands, consider the following statements:
1. The inclusion of a wetland in the Ramsar List permanently prohibits all traditional farming and fishing practices by local communities.
2. Once a wetland is designated as a Ramsar site, it cannot be placed under the Montreux Record.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is incorrect because the Ramsar Convention promotes the wise use principle, which permits sustainable traditional resource extraction and livelihood activities. Statement 2 is incorrect because the Montreux Record is maintained specifically as part of the Ramsar List to highlight sites experiencing ecological character change due to technological developments, pollution, or human interference.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the significance of the Ramsar Convention on Wetlands in conserving aquatic ecosystems in India. What are the key governance challenges in balancing wetland conservation with local development needs? (150 words, 10 marks)

The Ramsar Convention on Wetlands provides a global framework for identifying and sustainably managing critical aquatic habitats through the wise use concept.

- Significance: International recognition attracts focused conservation funding, scientific research, and systematic monitoring of migratory corridors and hydrologic cycles.
- Regulatory enforcement: It mandates member states to formulate management plans preventing harmful alterations in land use and point-source pollution.
- Governance challenges: Rapid urbanization and infrastructure expansion lead to encroachment, drainage of wetlands, and unmanaged runoff.
- Livelihood conflicts: Strict regulatory zoning can restrict the rights of traditional fishers and agriculturalists unless participatory community governance is established.

India must integrate the Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules with local town planning and adopt community-led ecological restoration models.

Keywords to use: Wise use principle, Montreux Record, Ecosystem services, Wetlands Rules, Hydrological cycle

GS3 · Science & Tech

2. Defence Ministry inks pacts for GSAT-7C satellite and Varunastra torpedoes

Contracts worth over 4000 crore rupees were signed to procure a dedicated communication satellite for the air force and heavyweight torpedoes for the navy.

What happened	The Ministry of Defence signed contracts worth over 4000 crore rupees for GSAT-7C satellite with NewSpace India Limited and Varunastra torpedoes with Bharat

	Dynamics Limited.
Why UPSC cares	Vital for GS Paper 3 defence technology and indigenisation. Study the role of dedicated military satellites for the Indian Air Force (IAF) and indigenous heavy weight torpedoes like Varunastra for naval warfare.
Syllabus	GS3 Science & Technology: Indigenization of technology and developing new technology; Defence technology.
Chapter	Science & Tech: India’s Space Programme & Navigation

Read it for

1. Role of dedicated military communication satellites in network centric warfare.
2. Indigenous design and development of anti-submarine warfare technologies.
3. Public sector and commercial space participation under self-reliance initiatives.

Key terms

GSAT-7 Series
A series of defence communication satellites developed in India to provide secure real-time connectivity across armed forces assets.

Heavyweight Torpedo
A self-propelled underwater guided weapon launched from naval platforms to destroy deep-diving submarines and surface vessels over long ranges.

Anti-Submarine Warfare (ASW)
A branch of naval warfare that uses surface warships, aircraft, or other submarines to detect, track, and destroy enemy submarines.

NewSpace India Limited (NSIL)
A central public sector enterprise under the Department of Space mandated to commercially exploit and scale Indian space products and services.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding defence technologies in India:
1. Satellites of the GSAT-7 series are deployed in low Earth orbits to provide polar coverage for ground troops.
2. Varunastra is an indigenous ship-launched heavyweight torpedo designed for anti-submarine warfare.
3. NewSpace India Limited (NSIL) functions as a commercial arm under the administrative control of the Department of Space.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect: GSAT-7 series satellites are military communication satellites placed in geostationary orbits (approximately 36,000 kilometres above Earth) to enable continuous, real-time secure communication over India and surrounding maritime and continental zones, not in low Earth orbit. Statements 2 and 3 are correct: Varunastra is a ship-launched, electrically propelled heavyweight anti-submarine torpedo developed indigenously, and NewSpace India Limited (NSIL) is a wholly owned Government of India company under the Department of Space established for commercial exploitation of space research assets.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the significance of dedicated military satellites and indigenous weapon systems in enhancing India's joint warfare capabilities. (150 words, 10 marks)

Modern conflicts demand integrated multi-domain operations connecting land, air, and naval assets through secure real-time communication and self-reliant precision strike systems.

- Dedicated military satellites like the GSAT-7 series remove dependency on civilian or foreign communication relays, providing jam-resistant command and control for airborne and maritime platforms.
- Undersea warfare capabilities, bolstered by indigenous systems like Varunastra, allow long-range detection and neutralisation of adversary submarines, strengthening coastal and oceanic perimeter security.
- Indigenous procurement through domestic entities like NewSpace India Limited and Bharat Dynamics Limited mitigates supply chain disruptions and technological embargoes during conflicts.

Achieving full theaterisation requires sustaining this momentum through higher research allocation, public-private partnerships, and timely operational integration across services.

Keywords to use: network-centric warfare, interoperability, Aatmanirbhar Bharat, undersea deterrence, jam-resistant communication

GS3 · Economy

3. Labour force participation crosses 55 per cent as unemployment rate falls to 5 per cent

National Statistics Office data shows rural employment driving overall gains while urban female participation reached an eleven month high.

What happened	National Statistics Office data showed the Labour Force Participation Rate rose to 55.5 per cent, the Worker Population Ratio rose to 52.7 per cent, and the unemployment rate fell to 5 per cent.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for GS Paper 3 employment and inclusive growth. Analyze trends in rural versus urban female labour force participation, Worker Population Ratio (WPR), and employment metrics from the National Statistical Office (NSO).
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Issues relating to planning, mobilization of resources, growth, development and employment.
Chapter	Economy: Poverty and Unemployment

Read it for

1. Understand definitions of Labour Force Participation Rate, Worker Population Ratio, and Unemployment Rate.
2. Track rural versus urban divergence in employment and workforce metrics.
3. Analyze trends in female labour force participation and their economic significance.

Key terms

Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR)
The percentage of the working age population that is either actively employed or seeking work.

Worker Population Ratio (WPR)
The proportion of employed persons within the total population of working age.

Unemployment Rate (UR)
The percentage of individuals in the labour force who are without work and seeking employment.

National Statistics Office (NSO)
The central statistical agency responsible for conducting large scale nationwide employment and economic surveys in India.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding employment indicators:
1. The Labour Force Participation Rate includes individuals who are working as well as those actively looking for work.
2. The Unemployment Rate is calculated as the percentage of unemployed persons out of the total population of a country.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: The labour force consists of both employed persons and unemployed persons who are actively seeking work. Statement 2 is incorrect: The Unemployment Rate is expressed as a percentage of the total labour force, not the total population of the country.

Mains: how it could come

While macroeconomic surveys indicate rising labour force participation, structural issues continue to impede quality employment creation in India. Examine the factors behind this divergence. (150 words, 10 marks)

Recent surveys reveal an improvement in overall labour force participation and falling unemployment, yet the nature and sustainability of employment generation remain uneven across sectors.

- Informalization: Much of the employment growth is concentrated in self-employment and unpaid family labour, particularly in rural agriculture.
- Female workforce barriers: Cultural obligations, lack of affordable child care, and limited formal non-farm rural avenues constrain productive urban female work.
- Skill mismatch: Rapid shifts toward capital-intensive manufacturing and automated services leave large segments of low-skilled youth underemployed.
- Urban-rural divergence: Urban unemployment persists at elevated levels compared to rural areas, reflecting an inadequate pace of quality industrial job creation.

Policy must prioritize expanding labour-intensive manufacturing, formal social security, targeted skill upgradation, and child care infrastructure to convert labour supply into productive economic output.

Keywords to use: underemployment, informalization, female participation, skill mismatch, worker population ratio

Newspaper words

jurisdiction	अधिकार क्षेत्र	The official power or legal authority to make decisions and judgments
safeguards	सुरक्षात्मक उपाय	Measures taken to protect someone or something from harm or damage
indigenisation	स्वदेशीकरण	The process of bringing something under local or domestic control and production
deterrence	निवारण या रोकथाम	The action of discouraging an action or event through instilling doubt or fear
divergence	अंतर या भिन्नता	A situation in which two or more things become different or move apart

Saturday, 17 October 2026

GS2 · Elections & Constitutional Bodies

1. Election Commission orders summary revision of voter rolls in 17 states and UTs

Draft rolls will appear on 12 November with four annual qualifying dates enabling advance registration for youth turning 18.

What happened	The Election Commission of India (ECI) announced a Special Summary Revision of voter rolls in 14 states and three Union Territories with 1 January as the qualifying date.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for General Studies Paper 2. The Election Commission of India (ECI) updating electoral rolls links to the Representation of the People Act, voting rights and voter registration integrity.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Election Commission of India, electoral reforms and statutory provisions.
Chapter	Polity: Conducting Elections: The EC

Read it for

1. Role of the Election Commission of India (ECI) under Article 324 in preparing and updating electoral rolls.
2. Statutory provisions under the Representation of the People Act, 1950 regarding qualifying dates for registration.
3. Administrative measures to include marginalized groups, vulnerable communities and young citizens in the voting process.

Key terms

Special Summary Revision (SSR)
An intensive exercise undertaken by election authorities to update electoral rolls before elections by enrolling new voters and removing duplicate or deceased electors.

Qualifying Date
The reference date on which an individual must have reached the minimum voting age of 18 years to be eligible for registration on the electoral roll.

Representation of the People Act, 1950
The parliamentary law that provides for the allocation of seats, delimitation of constituencies, and qualification of voters along with the preparation of electoral rolls.

Universal Adult Suffrage
A constitutional principle under Article 326 granting every Indian citizen aged 18 or above the right to vote, unless disqualified under law.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to electoral rolls and voter registration in India, consider the following statements:
1. The Constitution of India specifies 1st January of every year as the sole qualifying date for inclusion in the electoral roll.
2. The preparation and revision of electoral rolls is governed by the provisions of the Representation of the People Act, 1950.
3. A citizen who is ordinary resident in a constituency has the statutory right to be registered in the electoral roll of that constituency.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because qualifying dates are defined under Section 14(b) of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, not in the Constitution itself. Furthermore, through the Election Laws (Amendment) Act, 2021, four qualifying dates (1 January, 1 April, 1 July, and 1 October) were introduced instead of a single date. Statement 2 is correct as the preparation, maintenance, and revision of electoral rolls fall squarely under the Representation of the People Act, 1950. Statement 3 is correct because under Section 19 of the 1950 Act, every person who is not less than 18 years of age on the qualifying date and is ordinarily resident in a constituency is entitled to be registered in that electoral roll.

Mains: how it could come

Clean and inclusive electoral rolls are the cornerstone of free and fair elections. Discuss the administrative and legal challenges in maintaining error-free voter lists, and highlight recent reforms undertaken to broaden voter registration. (150 words, 10 marks)

The integrity of electoral democracy rests on accurate electoral rolls prepared under Article 324 and the Representation of the People Act, 1950, ensuring universal adult franchise.

- Challenges include duplicate entries, failure to delete deceased voters promptly, and exclusion of seasonal internal migrants due to strict ordinary residence criteria.
- Marginalized communities, homeless individuals, and remote populations often encounter difficulties with documentation and physical access during summary revisions.
- Statutory reforms through the Election Laws (Amendment) Act, 2021 provided four qualifying dates each year, avoiding long waits for newly eligible youth.
- Digital initiatives such as online voter portals and mobile applications have streamlined claims, objections, and demographic corrections.

Leveraging civil registration data integration alongside proactive district-level outreach will minimize exclusions and fortify electoral sanctity.

Keywords to use: Article 324, qualifying dates, internal migrants, electoral roll integrity, universal adult suffrage

GS3 · Infrastructure

2. Inland waterways cargo hits 218 million tonnes, beating 2030 target

Cargo movement on national waterways grew at over twenty per cent annually to exceed the Maritime India Vision target well ahead of schedule.

What happened	Inland waterways cargo reached 218 million metric tonnes in 2025-26, growing at a compound annual rate of 20.13 per cent from 29 million metric tonnes in 2014-15 across 111 National Waterways.
Why UPSC cares	Vital for General Studies Paper 3. Surpassing Maritime India Vision 2030 inland water targets links to infrastructure, multimodal logistics efficiency and green transport.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Infrastructure: Energy, Ports, Roads, Airports, Railways etc.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Track modal shift advantages of inland water transport over road and rail logistics.
2. Understand the governance structure under the Inland Waterways Authority of India.
3. Evaluate infrastructure interventions like hydrographic surveys and digital navigation.

Key terms

National Waterways (NW)
Inland water stretches declared by Parliament under the National Waterways Act, 2016 for regulation and development of shipping and navigation.

Maritime India Vision 2030
A ten-year blueprint by the Government of India aimed at modernising maritime infrastructure, boosting port efficiency, and accelerating inland cargo movement.

Hydrographic Survey
The measurement and description of the physical features of navigable water bodies, including depth, tides, currents, and underwater obstructions.

Compound Annual Growth Rate (CAGR)
The mean annual growth rate of an investment or metric over a specified time period longer than one year.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements:
1. The Inland Waterways Authority of India (IWAI) is a statutory body established for the development and regulation of inland waterways for shipping and navigation.
2. Per tonne-kilometre of freight movement, inland water transport generates higher carbon dioxide emissions than road transport.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: The Inland Waterways Authority of India (IWAI) was created under the Inland Waterways Authority of India Act, 1985 as a statutory authority under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways. Statement 2 is incorrect: Inland water transport is the most fuel-efficient and environmentally sustainable mode of surface freight transport, emitting significantly less carbon dioxide per tonne-kilometre compared to both road and rail transport.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the potential of inland water transport in reducing logistics costs and carbon emissions in India. What are the key infrastructural and hydrological bottlenecks in expanding its share in the national transport modal mix? (150 words, 10 marks)

Inland water transport provides a cost-effective, fuel-efficient, and low-emission alternative to road and rail logistics, supporting India's multimodal transport connectivity.

- Economic and environmental benefits: Low operational cost per tonne-kilometre, minimal land acquisition hurdles, high carrying capacity for bulk cargo, and substantially reduced greenhouse gas emissions.
- Hydrological challenges: Inadequate Least Available Depth (LAD) during lean dry seasons, heavy riverbed siltation, and seasonal water discharge variations in peninsular rivers.
- Infrastructural bottlenecks: Limited last-mile connectivity to production centres, shortage of specialised multimodal terminals and inland vessels, and high initial dredging and fairway maintenance expenditure.
- Institutional hurdles: Inter-state water disputes, environmental clearances regarding riparian ecology, and low private sector investment in barge fleets.

Accelerate night-navigation aids, integrate waterways with dedicated freight corridors under PM Gati Shakti, and promote public-private partnerships in barge operations.

Keywords to use: Least Available Depth (LAD), modal mix, PM Gati Shakti, logistics cost, multimodal connectivity

GS3 · Environment

3. Air quality panel mandates camera surveillance for NCR industries

The Commission for Air Quality Management has extended pan-tilt-zoom camera monitoring across industrial units in the National Capital Region.

What happened	The Commission for Air Quality Management expanded pan-tilt-zoom camera-based remote monitoring to all industrial units covered under Direction Number 98 in the National Capital Region.
Why UPSC cares	Important for General Studies Paper 3. Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) directions and remote technological monitoring link directly to air pollution governance in Delhi-NCR.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment.
Chapter	Environment: Environmental Institutions & Steps

Read it for

1. Statutory powers and jurisdiction of the Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas.
2. Technological mechanisms deployed for real-time industrial emission compliance and surveillance.
3. Federal governance challenges in inter-state air shed management between Delhi and neighbouring states.

Key terms

Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM)
A statutory body established under a 2021 central act to coordinate, supervise, and direct air pollution control measures across the National Capital Region and adjacent areas.

Air Shed Management
An integrated approach to managing air quality across a geographic boundary where air masses interact, moving beyond standard administrative borders.

Pan-Tilt-Zoom (PTZ) Camera
A surveillance camera capable of remote directional and zoom control, used for verifying industrial smoke, fuel use, and stack emission compliance in real time.

Continuous Emission Monitoring System (CEMS)
A network of automated sensors installed at industrial exhaust stacks that continuously record and transmit effluent and gas concentration levels to environmental regulators.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas (CAQM):
1. It was established as a statutory body under an act of Parliament.
2. In matters of air quality management, the orders of the Central Pollution Control Board supersede the directions issued by the Commission.
3. Its jurisdiction extends to areas in Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh where sources of pollution impact the National Capital Region.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because the Commission for Air Quality Management was established under the Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas Act, 2021. Statement 2 is incorrect because the directions of the Commission supersede those of the Central Pollution Control Board, State Pollution Control Boards, and state governments in the region. Statement 3 is correct because the jurisdiction covers the National Capital Region and adjoining parts of Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh impacting regional air quality.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how technological surveillance tools, such as remote sensing and real-time monitoring, strengthen environmental enforcement. What institutional barriers limit their effectiveness in tackling air pollution in the National Capital Region? (150 words, 10 marks)

Technological surveillance transforms environmental regulation by shifting from periodic manual inspections to continuous, objective, and auditable emission tracking.

- Real-time surveillance systems like Continuous Emission Monitoring and remote cameras detect clandestine industrial operations, reduce regulatory rent-seeking, and provide legally admissible evidence.
- They enable timely preventive interventions during peak pollution episodes under frameworks like the Graded Response Action Plan.
- Institutional barriers include inadequate municipal capacity to process massive data streams, delays in prosecuting violators, and sensor calibration tampering.
- Inter-state jurisdictional friction and weak last-mile field staff constrain swift ground enforcement even when violations are captured digitally.

Strengthening forensic data auditing, ensuring statutory penalties for sensor tampering, and integrating local field teams with automated surveillance portals are essential for sustained compliance.

Keywords to use: Air shed management, Real-time monitoring, Regulatory enforcement, Graded Response Action Plan, Sensor calibration

Newspaper words

statutory	वैधानिक, संविधिक	decided, controlled, or required by a written law
marginalized	हाशिए पर, उपेक्षित	pushed to the edge of society and treated as insignificant
mitigation	शमन, अल्पीकरण	the reduction of the harmful effects or severity of something
modal shift	परिवहन साधन में बदलाव	a change from one form of transportation to another
surveillance	निगरानी, देखरेख	continuous observation or monitoring of an area or activity

Sunday, 18 October 2026

GS2 · International Relations

1. India affirms energy security priority amid unilateral sanctions

India prioritises affordable supplies for its population while targeting 100 billion US dollars in bilateral trade with Russia by 2030.

What happened	India reiterated that national interest and energy security guide its crude oil purchases, while projecting bilateral trade with Russia to reach 100 billion US dollars by 2030.
Why UPSC cares	Balancing domestic energy requirements against external sanctions illustrates strategic autonomy. A vital study for GS2 International Relations on India-Russia ties and bilateral trade goals.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand strategic autonomy and how national interest drives energy procurement decisions.
2. Distinguish between binding multilateral sanctions by the United Nations and unilateral sanctions by individual states.
3. Analyze the geopolitical implications of energy diplomacy and bilateral trade targets with Russia.

Key terms

Energy Security
The uninterrupted availability of energy sources at an affordable price to meet national developmental needs.

Strategic Autonomy
The capacity of a state to make independent foreign policy and security choices without external coercion.

Unilateral Sanctions
Economic or trade penalties imposed by a single country against another without United Nations Security Council authorisation.

Secondary Sanctions
Penalties applied by a sanctioning state against third-party entities that engage in trade with the targeted country.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding international economic sanctions and energy security:
1. Economic sanctions imposed unilaterally by an individual nation are legally binding on all member states of the United Nations (UN).
2. The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) can impose coercive economic sanctions only with the unanimous consent of all General Assembly members.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is incorrect because unilateral sanctions imposed by individual countries lack universal legal validity under international law. Only sanctions mandated by the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) under Chapter VII of the United Nations Charter are legally binding on all United Nations members. Statement 2 is incorrect because the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) adopts sanction resolutions under Chapter VII through an affirmative vote of nine members, including the concurring votes of the permanent members, and does not require the unanimous consent of all United Nations General Assembly members.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how India exercises strategic autonomy to reconcile its national energy security needs with complex geopolitical alignments. (150 words, 10 marks)

Strategic autonomy serves as the cornerstone of India's foreign policy, empowering the country to make independent decisions based on core national interests.

- Energy security as a domestic imperative: Meeting the critical fuel and developmental needs of a population of 1.4 billion requires diversified and affordable crude oil supplies.
- Non-alignment with unilateral measures: India adheres strictly to United Nations mandates while rejecting non-multilateral sanctions regimes that disrupt vital commodity supply chains.
- Multi-vector diplomacy: Sustaining deep bilateral ties with Russia through targeted trade growth while concurrently advancing partnerships with Western nations in forums like the Quad.
- Hedging against volatility: Developing local currency payment mechanisms and alternative logistics channels to minimize exposure to external financial choke points.

Deepening supply diversification alongside rapid domestic renewable capacity addition will strengthen India's sovereignty in an increasingly fragmented world order.

Keywords to use: Strategic Autonomy, Energy Diplomacy, National Interest, Unilateral Sanctions, Supply Diversification

GS3 · Environment

2. National Biodiversity Authority releases benefit sharing funds to state boards

The National Biodiversity Authority distributed 1.19 crore rupees to 29 State Biodiversity Boards and one Union Territory board under the Access and Benefit Sharing mechanism.

What happened	The National Biodiversity Authority distributed 1.19 crore rupees to 29 State Biodiversity Boards and one Union Territory board under the Access and Benefit Sharing framework.
Why UPSC cares	Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 is central to GS3 Environment questions on statutory bodies, fair resource sharing, and community rights.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment.
Chapter	Environment: Environmental Institutions & Steps

Read it for

1. Three-tier architecture of biological resource governance under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002.
2. Access and Benefit Sharing mechanism and its link to the Nagoya Protocol.
3. Transmission of financial benefits from commercial users down to grassroots communities.

Key terms

National Biodiversity Authority (NBA)
A statutory autonomous body established in 2003 under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, headquartered in Chennai to regulate access to biological resources.

Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS)
A mechanism ensuring that benefits arising from the commercial or research use of genetic resources and traditional knowledge are shared equitably with local conservers.

Biodiversity Management Committees (BMCs)
Statutory local-level bodies created by local self-governments to promote conservation, sustainable use, and documentation of biological diversity through registers.

People's Biodiversity Register (PBR)
A comprehensive document prepared by local committees that records local biological resources, their medicinal or other uses, and associated traditional knowledge.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, consider the following statements:
1. Non-Indian citizens and foreign commercial entities must obtain prior approval from the National Biodiversity Authority to access Indian biological resources.
2. Indian citizens and Indian companies can access biological resources for commercial utilization without any intimation to State Biodiversity Boards.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: Under Section 3 of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002, non-citizens, non-residents, and foreign entities require prior approval from the National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) to access biological resources or associated knowledge. Statement 2 is incorrect: Under Section 7, Indian citizens and domestic body corporates must give prior intimation to the concerned State Biodiversity Board (SBB) before obtaining biological resources for commercial utilization, except for local people and traditional healers.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the effectiveness of the Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) framework under India's Biological Diversity Act, 2002 in empowering local communities. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Biological Diversity Act, 2002 operationalised the Nagoya Protocol's third pillar, fair and equitable sharing of benefits arising from the use of genetic resources.

- Institutional hierarchy: The Act creates a three-tier framework comprising the National Biodiversity Authority (NBA), State Biodiversity Boards (SBBs), and local Biodiversity Management Committees (BMCs) to monitor bio-prospecting.
- Revenue distribution: Commercial entities using traditional bio-resources pay a share of their revenue, which flows down through National and State Biodiversity Funds to BMCs for local conservation.
- Documentation empowerment: BMCs compile People's Biodiversity Registers (PBRs) to establish legal community ownership over local biological resources and indigenous medicinal knowledge.
- Structural limitations: Implementation remains constrained by weak technical capacity of grassroots BMCs, bureaucratic delays in benefit transfers, and valuation disputes with industries.

Strengthening digital registries, ensuring direct benefit transfers to grassroots communities, and providing capacity-building to village-level committees are critical for achieving real equity.

Keywords to use: Nagoya Protocol, Access and Benefit Sharing, Biodiversity Management Committees, People's Biodiversity Register, State Biodiversity Boards

GS3 · Science & Technology

3. India targets forty-five billion dollar space economy in eight years

The space sector is expected to expand from nine billion dollars through private sector participation, timely approvals and global investments.

What happened	The Union Minister of State for Space announced that India's space economy, currently valued at around 9 billion dollars, is projected to reach 40 to 45 billion dollars in the next 7 to 8 years.
Why UPSC cares	Expansion of India's commercial space footprint and private investments links directly to GS3 Science and Technology topics on indigenisation and space sector liberalization.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Achievements of Indians in science and technology, indigenization of technology and developing new technology.
Chapter	Science & Tech: India’s Space Programme & Navigation

Read it for

1. Economic projection: Expansion of India's space economy from 9 billion dollars to 45 billion dollars in 7 to 8 years.
2. Private participation: Transition from state-dominated research to commercially viable, globally competitive space enterprises.
3. Enablers: Need for regulatory speed, cost reduction, supply-chain integration, and international capital.

Key terms

Space Economy

The full range of activities and the use of resources that create value and benefits to human beings in the course of exploring, researching, understanding, managing, and utilising space.

Indian National Space Promotion and Authorization Centre (IN-SPACe)

A single-window autonomous nodal agency under the Department of Space designed to permit, facilitate, and regulate space activities of non-government private entities.

NewSpace India Limited (NSIL)

A central public sector enterprise under the Department of Space, functioning as the commercial arm of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO).

Downstream Space Sector

The commercial application of space-derived technologies and satellite data, such as telecommunications, navigation, remote sensing, and location-based services.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the institutional framework of India's space sector:
1. NewSpace India Limited (NSIL) acts as the single-window independent regulatory body to authorise space activities of private entities.
2. The Indian National Space Promotion and Authorization Centre (IN-SPACe) is mandated to promote and permit non-government entities to participate in end-to-end space activities.
3. Private sector entities in India are permitted to establish and operate launch facilities and build launch vehicles.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorization Centre (IN-SPACe), not NSIL, acts as the single-window autonomous nodal agency for authorising private space activities. NewSpace India Limited (NSIL) is the commercial arm of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). Statements 2 and 3 are correct because IN-SPACe facilitates private participation, and the Indian Space Policy permits non-government entities to build rockets, operate launch pads, and provide satellite communications.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the role of private sector participation in unlocking the economic potential of India's space industry. What regulatory and structural challenges must be addressed to make Indian space enterprises globally competitive? (150 words, 10 marks)

India is transitioning its space programme from a state-led scientific endeavor into an open, market-driven ecosystem aiming to expand the space economy to 45 billion dollars.

- Economic dividend: Private players can address high-growth downstream sectors like satellite broadband, geospatial analytics, and Earth observation, shifting ISRO's focus toward core research and deep-space missions.
- Manufacturing and launch capabilities: Startups and established aerospace firms are developing small satellite launch vehicles, capturing global demand for cost-effective satellite launches.
- Institutional bottlenecks: Prolonged regulatory clearances, ambiguities in space liability, and intellectual property sharing frameworks hinder rapid commercial scaling.
- Financial and infrastructure hurdles: High capital intensity, limited domestic venture capital for deep-tech, and dependence on foreign supply chains for specialised materials restrict global competitiveness.

Fast-tracking single-window approvals via IN-SPACe, enacting a comprehensive Space Activities Act, and promoting public procurement of private space solutions will establish India as a premier commercial space hub.

Keywords to use: IN-SPACe, downstream applications, commercial space ecosystem, Space Activities Act, small satellite launch vehicles

Newspaper words

strategic autonomy	रणनीतिक स्वायत्तता	ability of a state to make foreign policy decisions independently
unilateral	एकतरफा	done by or affecting only one party, country, or side
procurement	खरीद या अधिप्राप्ति	the process of obtaining or purchasing goods and services
compliance	अनुपालन	the state of following or obeying rules, laws, or standards
viable	व्यावहारिक	capable of working successfully; feasible

Monday, 19 October 2026

GS2 · International Relations

1. Defence minister to attend SCO government heads meeting in Tajikistan

Rajnath Singh will visit Dushanbe for the 25th Meeting of the Council of Heads of Government of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation.

What happened	Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will visit Dushanbe, Tajikistan, for the two-day 25th Meeting of the Council of Heads of Government of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation.
Why UPSC cares	Multilateral regional groupings link to GS2 International Relations. Analyse the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), its mandate, and Eurasian ties.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Distinction between SCO Council of Heads of State and Council of Heads of Government.
2. India's regional connectivity, economic interests, and security priorities in Central Asia.
3. Multilateral balancing between Eurasian groupings and Western partnerships.

Key terms

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)
A permanent intergovernmental international organisation founded in 2001 in Shanghai, focusing on regional security, economic cooperation, and cultural exchange.

Council of Heads of Government (CHG)
The second highest decision-making body of the SCO, which meets annually to discuss multilateral economic cooperation and approve the organisation's budget.

Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS)
A permanent organ of the SCO headquartered in Tashkent, tasked with coordinating regional efforts against terrorism, separatism, and extremism.

Multilateralism
An alliance of multiple countries pursuing a common goal or resolving shared problems through institutionalised dialogue and agreed rules.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO):
1. The Council of Heads of Government primarily approves the organisation's annual budget and considers basic issues of economic cooperation.
2. The headquarters of the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure is located in Beijing, China.
3. The official working languages of the organisation are Russian and Chinese.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because the Council of Heads of Government (CHG) meets annually to discuss economic cooperation and approve the budget of the organisation. Statement 2 is incorrect because the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is headquartered in Tashkent, Uzbekistan, whereas the SCO Secretariat is located in Beijing, China. Statement 3 is correct because Russian and Chinese are the two official working languages of the SCO.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2022 · Q66

Consider the following :
1. Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank
2. Missile Technology Control Regime
3. Shanghai Cooperation Organisation
India is a member of which of the above ?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 3 only
c. 2 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Official answer (UPSC answer key): D. India is a founding member of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, having signed its Articles of Agreement in 2015, and is its second-largest shareholder after China, so item 1 is correct. India became the 35th member of the Missile Technology Control Regime in June 2016, so item 2 is correct. India became a full member of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, together with Pakistan, at the Astana summit in 2017, so item 3 is correct. Option B is tempting for those who confuse the MTCR with the Nuclear Suppliers Group, which India has not joined, but India belongs to all three groupings listed.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the strategic and economic significance of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) for India, and analyse the key challenges India faces within the forum. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is an influential trans-regional grouping that anchors India in the Eurasian heartland, offering a platform to advance security, energy, and connectivity interests.

- Strategic and security relevance: The Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) aids intelligence sharing on terrorism, extremism, and border security, especially regarding Afghanistan.
- Connectivity and economic access: The SCO provides vital land routes and institutional links to resource-rich Central Asian republics, reinforcing initiatives like the International North-South Transport Corridor.
- Key challenges: China's dominance and its Belt and Road Initiative raise sovereignty concerns, while frequent bilateral friction with Pakistan limits smooth consensus building.
- Strategic autonomy dilemmas: Balancing active engagement in a Russia-China led bloc with India's growing partnerships in Western formats like the Quad requires careful diplomatic navigation.

India should leverage the SCO for pragmatic cooperation in counter-terrorism, digital public infrastructure, and Central Asian connectivity while safeguarding its core sovereignty principles.

Keywords to use: Eurasian security, Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS), Central Asian connectivity, strategic autonomy, Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)

GS3 · Economy

2. IMF committee warns of rising debt and geopolitical shocks

The International Monetary and Financial Committee warned in Bangkok that armed conflicts, high public debt and trade barriers pose significant risks to global financial stability.

What happened	The International Monetary and Financial Committee concluded its 54th meeting in Bangkok, highlighting that conflicts, escalating debt, and trade fragmentation threaten global growth.
Why UPSC cares	Global macroeconomic risks link to GS3 Economy. Understand International Monetary Fund (IMF) surveillance, its policy committee, and debt risks.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: issues relating to planning, mobilization of resources, growth, development and international financial institutions.
Chapter	Economy: International Financial Institutions

Read it for

1. Role and institutional structure of the International Monetary and Financial Committee (IMFC) within the IMF framework.
2. Macroeconomic linkages between rising public debt, higher bond yields, and sovereign refinancing pressures.
3. Transmission mechanisms through which supply disruptions and geopolitical conflicts generate imported inflation.

Key terms

International Monetary and Financial Committee (IMFC)

A 24-member ministerial advisory body of the International Monetary Fund (IMF) that provides strategic direction on the international monetary system.

Bond Yield

The annual rate of return realized on a debt security, which rises when bond market prices fall and government borrowing costs increase.

Refinancing Risk

The possibility that a sovereign borrower will be unable to replace maturing debt with new borrowing at acceptable interest rates.

Fiscal Buffer

Budgetary headroom and accumulated reserves that allow governments to sustain public spending and absorb adverse economic shocks without defaulting.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the International Monetary and Financial Committee (IMFC), consider the following statements:
1. It possesses binding decision-making authority to amend the Articles of Agreement of the International Monetary Fund (IMF).
2. Its membership reflects the composition of the Executive Board of the IMF, representing constituencies of member nations.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because the IMFC is an advisory body to the Board of Governors of the IMF and does not have formal decision-making powers or authority to amend the Articles of Agreement. Statement 2 is correct because the IMFC has 24 members who are finance ministers or central bank governors, mirroring the 24 constituencies represented on the IMF Executive Board.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2022 · Q1

"Rapid Financing Instrument" and "Rapid Credit Facility" are related to the provisions of lending by which one of the following ?

a. Asian Development Bank
b. International Monetary Fund
c. United Nations Environment Programme Finance Initiative
d. World Bank

Answer: (b) Official answer (UPSC answer key): B. The Rapid Financing Instrument (RFI) and Rapid Credit Facility (RCF) are emergency financial assistance tools provided by the International Monetary Fund (IMF) to member countries facing urgent balance of payments needs. The RFI provides rapid financial support to member countries facing an urgent balance of payments need, whereas the RCF provides low-access rapid financial assistance to low-income countries. Institutions like the World Bank or Asian Development Bank have different nomenclature and policy-based lending mechanisms.

Mains: how it could come

Global economic fragmentation and elevated public debt levels pose severe risks to macroeconomic stability. Discuss the policy options available to emerging market economies to build fiscal resilience and ensure debt sustainability. (150 words, 10 marks)

Sustained geopolitical conflicts, high global interest rates, and post-pandemic spending pressures have pushed public debt across developing nations to historically high levels, shrinking fiscal space.

- Enhance domestic resource mobilization by broadening the direct tax base, rationalizing regressive subsidies, and leveraging digital tools to plug revenue leakages.
- Adopt credible medium-term fiscal frameworks with transparent debt anchors to lower sovereign risk premiums and keep bond yields manageable.
- Lengthen the maturity profile of government debt and prioritize local currency sovereign borrowing to mitigate currency depreciation and refinancing risks.
- Deepen domestic financial markets and engage multilateral restructuring platforms to secure concessional financing for critical public capital expenditures.

Emerging economies must balance fiscal consolidation with capital investment in infrastructure to sustain long-term economic growth without compromising sovereign solvency.

Keywords to use: debt sustainability, fiscal consolidation, bond yields, sovereign risk premium, refinancing risk

GS1 · Geography

3. IMD issues red alert for coastal Andhra Pradesh as heavy rain spreads across peninsular India

The India Meteorological Department warned of extremely heavy rainfall in coastal Andhra Pradesh alongside widespread thunderstorms across southern and central States.

What happened	The India Meteorological Department issued a red alert for coastal Andhra Pradesh and orange alert for Tamil Nadu, predicting widespread heavy rain and thunderstorms.
Why UPSC cares	Extreme weather warnings link to GS1 Geography. Study India Meteorological Department (IMD) colour-coded weather warning criteria and coastal rainfall.
Syllabus	GS1 Geography: Important geophysical phenomena and changes in critical geographical features.
Chapter	Geography: Climatology

Read it for

1. Understand the criteria and four color codes used by the India Meteorological Department for weather warnings.
2. Examine the physical factors causing intense precipitation across peninsular India during October.
3. Analyze the governance mechanisms for disaster preparedness activated by red and orange alerts.

Key terms

India Meteorological Department (IMD)

The principal government agency under the Ministry of Earth Sciences responsible for meteorological observations, weather forecasting, and seismology.

Red Alert

The highest level of weather warning by the India Meteorological Department, signifying an instruction to take immediate action to manage severe disruption.

Extremely Heavy Rainfall

A precipitation category defined by the India Meteorological Department when rainfall at a station exceeds 204.4 millimetres in a twenty-four hour period.

Thunderstorm

A transient localized storm accompanied by lightning and thunder, produced by a cumulonimbus cloud through intense convective atmospheric instability.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the color-coded weather warnings issued by the India Meteorological Department (IMD):
1. Green indicates that no adverse weather is expected and no action is required.
2. Orange warning instructs disaster managers and citizens to be prepared for bad weather.
3. Red warning instructs authorities and the public to take action to protect life and property.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because green represents normal conditions with no warning. Statement 2 is correct because orange implies being prepared for severe weather disruptions. Statement 3 is correct because red signals severe conditions requiring immediate operational action by disaster authorities and the public.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss how the transition from hazard-based weather warnings to impact-based forecasting improves disaster risk reduction in vulnerable coastal regions of India. (150 words, 10 marks)

Impact-based forecasting shifts the focus from what the weather will be to what the weather will do, translating meteorological figures into specific physical and infrastructural risks.

- Provides location-specific vulnerability maps, allowing district administrations to identify vulnerable low-lying habitations, transport corridors, and fragile housing before extreme rainfall events.
- Facilitates graduated administrative responses, enabling timely pre-positioning of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), school closures, and regulated reservoir releases.
- Enhances public risk communication through clear color-coded alerts (Yellow, Orange, Red) that guide citizen behavior and evacuation protocols.

Integrating local geographic information system data and strengthening last-mile dissemination through regional community networks will maximize the protective yield of early warning systems.

Keywords to use: impact-based forecasting, disaster risk reduction, color-coded alerts, last-mile dissemination, National Disaster Response Force (NDRF)

Newspaper words

multilateral	बहुपक्षीय	involving three or more countries or groups
fragmentation	विखंडन	the process of breaking into smaller or separate parts
sovereign	संप्रभु	relating to an independent national government
thresholds	सीमा या स्तर	levels or limits at which a particular effect or action begins
precipitation	वर्षण	rain, snow, or other water falling to the ground

Tuesday, 20 October 2026

GS2 · Elections and Constitutional Bodies

1. Election Commission clarifies intensive electoral roll revision process

The Election Commission stated that Special Intensive Revision ensures no eligible citizen is omitted while removing invalid voter entries.

What happened	The Election Commission of India (ECI) issued clarifications on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process, highlighting house-to-house verification after two decades and distinguishing it from Special Summary Revision (SSR).
Why UPSC cares	The role of the Election Commission of India (ECI) and electoral roll management connect directly to universal suffrage and the Representation of the People Act under General Studies Paper 2.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Powers, functions and responsibilities of various Constitutional Bodies; Election laws.
Chapter	Polity: Conducting Elections: The EC

Read it for

1. Constitutional basis under Article 326 and Article 324 for preparing and maintaining electoral rolls.
2. Operational distinctions between Special Intensive Revision and Special Summary Revision.
3. Statutory safeguards against wrongful exclusion and duplicate voter registrations.

Key terms

Special Intensive Revision (SIR)
A comprehensive voter verification drive by the Election Commission of India (ECI) that involves house-to-house physical visits to verify every eligible resident and purge invalid records.

Special Summary Revision (SSR)
A periodic administrative exercise to update existing electoral rolls by inviting claims and objections from electors without mandatory door-to-door physical verification of the entire population.

Article 326
The constitutional provision specifying that elections to the House of the People and State Legislative Assemblies shall be based on adult suffrage, restricting voter registration strictly to Indian citizens.

Electoral Roll
An official register of persons entitled to vote in an election for a particular constituency, prepared under the superintendence of the Election Commission of India (ECI).

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements:
1. Under Article 324 of the Constitution of India, the superintendence, direction, and control of the preparation of electoral rolls are vested in the Election Commission of India.
2. Under Article 326 of the Constitution of India, elections to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies are based on adult suffrage, with Indian citizenship being a mandatory qualification.
3. The Representation of the People Act, 1950 provides the statutory framework for the allocation of seats and the preparation of electoral rolls.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: Article 324 vests the superintendence, direction, and control of the preparation of electoral rolls in the Election Commission of India (ECI). Statement 2 is correct: Article 326 provides that elections to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies shall be on the basis of adult suffrage, and electors must be citizens of India. Statement 3 is correct: The Representation of the People Act, 1950 governs the allocation of seats in legislatures, qualifications of voters, and the preparation of electoral rolls.

Mains: how it could come

An accurate and up-to-date electoral roll is fundamental to electoral integrity. Discuss the constitutional and administrative safeguards that ensure voter roll accuracy in India, along with the contemporary challenges involved. (150 words, 10 marks)

Articles 324 and 326 of the Constitution mandate the Election Commission of India (ECI) to prepare inclusive and authentic electoral rolls based on universal adult suffrage for Indian citizens.

- Dual verification mechanism: The Election Commission of India (ECI) executes Special Intensive Revisions (SIR) through door-to-door field verification and annual Special Summary Revisions (SSR) to maintain accurate records.
- Due process and quasi-judicial scrutiny: Draft publication is followed by a mandatory claims and objections window, ensuring individual hearings before deleting names to protect genuine electors.
- Statutory basis: The Representation of the People Act, 1950 defines registration criteria and disqualifications, barring non-citizens and duplicates.
- Operational hurdles: Large-scale domestic migration, rapid urbanisation, incomplete civil registration of deaths, and risks of arbitrary disenfranchisement during mass clean-up drives challenge roll fidelity.

Strengthening grassroots Booth Level Officer networks, integrating real-time civil death registries, and ensuring algorithmic transparency can preserve both roll purity and universal voter inclusion.

Keywords to use: Article 324, Article 326, Representation of the People Act 1950, Special Intensive Revision, electoral roll integrity

GS3 · Economy

2. India-New Zealand free trade pact takes effect with complete duty-free access

The bilateral agreement grants duty-free market access to all Indian exports while protecting sensitive domestic sectors such as dairy.

What happened	The India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement entered into force, offering duty-free access for 100 percent of Indian goods while ring-fencing dairy.
Why UPSC cares	Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) and tariff elimination are crucial for external trade, export growth, and bilateral economic relations under the General Studies Paper 3 syllabus.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Effects of liberalisation on the economy, changes in industrial policy and their effects on industrial growth.
Chapter	Economy: External Sector of India

Read it for

1. Tariff elimination and export access across merchandise sectors
2. Protection of sensitive domestic agricultural sectors such as dairy
3. Investment commitments and trade volume targets by 2030

Key terms

Free Trade Agreement (FTA)
A treaty between two or more countries that reduces or eliminates tariffs, quotas and administrative barriers on trade in goods and services.

Duty-Free Access
The entry of imported goods into a partner country without the levying of customs duties or tariffs.

Negative List / Sensitive Items
A designated group of products excluded from tariff cuts under a trade pact to protect vulnerable domestic producers from import surges.

Bilateral Trade
The exchange of goods, services and capital strictly between two sovereign nations.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), consider the following statements:
1. FTAs permit member countries to eliminate tariffs among themselves while retaining independent external tariffs against non-members.
2. General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) Article XXIV allows countries to depart from the Most Favoured Nation rule to form regional trade agreements.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: In a Free Trade Agreement, member countries remove duties on substantially all trade between them, but each country retains its own national tariff policy with respect to imports from non-member nations, unlike a customs union which has a common external tariff. Statement 2 is correct: Article XXIV of the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade provides a specific exception to the Most Favoured Nation principle, allowing member countries to grant special tariff preferences to partners in free trade agreements or customs unions, provided duties are not raised on trade with outside countries.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how bilateral Free Trade Agreements enable India to balance export growth with domestic economic safeguards. (150 words, 10 marks)

Bilateral Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) have become central to India's foreign trade architecture, aimed at securing duty-free entry for domestic goods while protecting sensitive sectors through exclusions.

- Export expansion: Complete tariff elimination on Indian merchandise provides a competitive edge to labour-intensive MSMEs, textiles, leather and pharmaceuticals against foreign competitors.
- Agricultural defence: Carving out sensitive items such as dairy, poultry and key grains prevents large-scale import surges from highly subsidised or cost-efficient global exporters.
- Foreign investment flows: Bilateral accords frequently incorporate commitments for foreign direct investment into manufacturing, infrastructure and technology ecosystems.
- Supply chain diversification: Preferential trade networks enable domestic manufacturers to source quality intermediate inputs and integrate into regional value chains.

India should reinforce domestic compliance with non-tariff standards and strengthen export infrastructure to capitalise on tariff concessions without compromising rural livelihoods.

Keywords to use: Tariff elimination, Sensitive sector exclusion, Rules of Origin, Value chain integration, Investment facilitation

GS3 · Science and Technology

3. Navy Vice Chief highlights indigenous technologies for maritime combat readiness

The Indian Navy announces the fifth edition of its flagship indigenisation seminar Swavlamban 2026 in New Delhi.

What happened	Vice Chief of Naval Staff Vice Admiral Ajay Kochhar announced the fifth edition of the Indian Navy's flagship seminar, Swavlamban 2026, in New Delhi to showcase indigenous defence innovations.
Why UPSC cares	Indigenisation of technology and defence preparedness are core themes under the Science and Technology and Internal Security sections of the General Studies Paper 3 syllabus.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: indigenisation of technology and developing new technology; security challenges and their management.
Chapter	Science & Tech: AI & Emerging Digital Tech

Read it for

1. Role of indigenous niche technologies like Artificial Intelligence and Quantum systems in maritime defence.
2. Integration of domestic industry, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, and academia into defence manufacturing.
3. Strategic shift from technology acquisition to self-reliant deployable solutions for modern naval warfare.

Key terms

Indigenisation
The process of developing and manufacturing defence hardware and systems domestically rather than importing them from abroad.

Counter-Unmanned Aerial Systems (C-UAS)
Systems designed to detect, track, and neutralise hostile drones using electronic jamming, directed energy, or kinetic interception.

Quantum Technology in Defence
The application of quantum mechanics principles to develop unhackable communication channels, ultra-precise navigation, and advanced submarine detection sensors.

Dual-Use Technology
Technologies developed for civilian applications that also possess substantial capability for military and defence operations.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding emerging military technologies:
1. Quantum key distribution uses the principles of quantum mechanics to generate cryptographic keys that cannot be intercepted without detection.
2. Counter-Unmanned Aerial Systems (C-UAS) can employ soft-kill measures, such as electronic jamming, as well as hard-kill measures, such as directed energy weapons.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: Quantum key distribution exploits quantum mechanical properties, such as the no-cloning theorem, where any interception alters the state and reveals eavesdropping. Statement 2 is correct: Counter-Unmanned Aerial Systems use soft-kill methods like global positioning system spoofing or radio frequency jamming to disable drones, and hard-kill methods like lasers, high-power microwaves, or kinetic projectiles to physically destroy them.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the strategic significance of indigenous niche technologies for naval combat readiness. How can closer collaboration between the defence forces, start-ups, and academia accelerate self-reliance in maritime security? (150 words, 10 marks)

Modern naval warfare is shaped by asymmetric threats, autonomous systems, and electronic warfare, making technological sovereignty essential for sustained operational readiness.

- Strategic Autonomy: Developing domestic niche systems in Artificial Intelligence, Counter-Unmanned Aerial Systems, and Quantum computing shields frontline naval forces from foreign supply chain chokepoints during geopolitical crises.
- Operational Flexibility: Custom-built indigenous platforms allow seamless integration with existing fleet communication, radar networks, and regional oceanographic conditions.
- Triple Helix Model: Partnering with domestic start-ups and academia enables rapid prototyping, dual-use technology adoption, and cost-effective military research.
- Capital Mobilisation: Engaging venture capital and domestic Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises bridges the commercialisation gap between theoretical research and deployable naval hardware.

Creating institutionalised testbeds at sea and offering assured procurement contracts will convert innovative civilian prototypes into mission-ready naval assets.

Keywords to use: Aatmanirbharta, Strategic Autonomy, Triple Helix Innovation, Niche Technologies, Maritime Domain Awareness

Newspaper words

recur	बार-बार होना	to happen or appear again repeatedly
ring-fencing	अलग रखकर सुरक्षा देना	protecting a particular sector or asset from external changes
fragile	नाज़ुक या कमज़ोर	easily harmed, vulnerable, or weak
indigenous	स्वदेशी	originating locally; native or domestically produced
acquisition	अधिग्रहण या अर्जन	the act of getting, purchasing, or obtaining something

Wednesday, 21 October 2026

GS2 · International Relations

1. India pitches sovereign connectivity and anti-terror unity at SCO meeting

At the SCO meeting in Dushanbe, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh called for connectivity respecting territorial integrity and unified action against terrorism.

What happened	Defence Minister Rajnath Singh addressed the 25th Meeting of the Council of Heads of Government of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) in Dushanbe, Tajikistan, stressing sovereign connectivity, anti-terror cooperation, and India's developmental models.
Why UPSC cares	The address stresses regional security, counter-terrorism, and respect for sovereignty in connectivity projects, which directly links to the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) mandate in GS2.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. India's insistence that regional connectivity projects must respect territorial integrity and national sovereignty.
2. The role of the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar Port in bypassing overland transit barriers.
3. The diplomatic call within the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation for unified action against terrorism without double standards.

Key terms

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)
A permanent intergovernmental international organisation founded in 2001 in Shanghai to maintain peace, security, and stability in Eurasia.

International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)
A 7,200-kilometre multimodal network of ship, rail, and road routes connecting India, Iran, Azerbaijan, Russia, and Europe to facilitate trade.

Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)
Shared digital building blocks such as digital identity, payment rails, and data-sharing systems that enable inclusive public and private service delivery.

Territorial Integrity
A principle of international law under the United Nations Charter prohibiting the use of force or unauthorized activities against the territorial boundaries of another state.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO):
1. The organisation was established in 2001.
2. The Secretariat of the organisation is located in Beijing.
3. The Executive Committee of the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is headquartered in Tashkent.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation was established in June 2001 in Shanghai, China. Statement 2 is correct: The permanent Secretariat of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is located in Beijing. Statement 3 is correct: The Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is a permanent organ of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, and its Executive Committee is headquartered in Tashkent, Uzbekistan.

Mains: how it could come

Connectivity projects in Eurasia must reconcile economic integration with the sovereignty of partner states. In light of this, discuss how India's engagement with the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) balances its connectivity and security goals. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's engagement with the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation reflects its Connect Central Asia policy, aiming to expand commercial access while safeguarding national security and territorial sovereignty.

- Sovereign Connectivity: India champions transparent, consultative corridors like the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar Port, contrasting with non-consultative projects like the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor that violate Indian territorial sovereignty in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.
- Security Cooperation: Utilising the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure platform to counter terrorism, drug trafficking, and cross-border radicalism without double standards.
- Economic and Developmental Diplomacy: Sharing indigenous models such as Digital Public Infrastructure, start-up ecosystems, and women-led development to build shared capacity across Eurasian partners.

India must continue leveraging multilateral forums like the SCO to assert strategic autonomy, diversify transit corridors, and insist on adherence to international law in regional infrastructure development.

Keywords to use: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure, INSTC, Sovereign Connectivity, Strategic Autonomy

GS3 · External Sector of India

2. India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement comes into force

The trade pact grants duty-free entry to all Indian exports and aims to double bilateral commerce by 2030.

What happened	The India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement entered into force, giving duty-free access to all Indian exports and targeting 35 thousand crore rupees in bilateral trade by 2030.
Why UPSC cares	The operationalisation of the bilateral free trade pact offers duty-free access to Indian exports. It is relevant for mains questions on trade policy and export promotion.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Effects of liberalisation on the economy, changes in industrial policy and their effects on industrial growth.
Chapter	Economy: External Sector of India

Read it for

1. Tariff elimination scope and its impact on labour intensive export sectors.
2. The role of duty-free raw material imports in strengthening domestic supply chains.
3. Regulatory alignment and procedural ease for sensitive sectors like pharmaceuticals.

Key terms

Free Trade Agreement (FTA)
A treaty between two or more countries that eliminates or reduces tariffs and non-tariff barriers on trade in goods and services.

Tariff Line
A specific product entry in a national customs tariff schedule identified by a unique commodity classification code.

Peak Tariff
Particularly high customs duties levied on sensitive imports, typically exceeding a country's average tariff rate.

Rules of Origin (ROO)
The criteria used to define the national source of a product, ensuring that only eligible partner goods receive preferential tariff benefits.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding economic integration agreements:
1. In a Free Trade Agreement (FTA), member countries eliminate internal tariffs on traded goods while maintaining their own independent external tariffs toward non-members.
2. A Customs Union differs from a Free Trade Agreement because its members apply a unified common external tariff on imports from non-member countries.
3. An Economic Union strictly prohibits member nations from adopting a common currency or harmonised monetary policies.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) Statements 1 and 2 are correct. In a Free Trade Agreement (FTA), member countries eliminate internal trade barriers while preserving autonomy over tariffs applied to non-members. In a Customs Union, members eliminate internal trade barriers and also establish a common external tariff schedule against non-members. Statement 3 is incorrect because an Economic Union represents a deeper stage of integration that involves common economic regulations, harmonised fiscal and monetary policies, and often a single currency, as seen in the European Union (EU).

Mains: how it could come

Examine how India's recent bilateral free trade agreements with developed economies support domestic manufacturing and export competitiveness. (150 words, 10 marks)

India has recalibrated its foreign trade policy toward signing comprehensive, bilateral trade pacts with developed partners to accelerate export-led manufacturing and integrate into resilient global value chains.

- Elimination of tariffs in partner markets creates a level playing field for labour intensive sectors like textiles, footwear, gems and jewellery against regional competitors.
- Duty-free import of key industrial inputs such as coking coal, scrap metals, and raw materials lowers domestic production costs and aids Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs).
- Harmonised regulatory frameworks and streamlined conformity assessments reduce non-tariff compliance costs for pharmaceutical, medical devices, and chemical industries.
- Preferential market access allows Indian farmers and processed food manufacturers to diversify export destinations beyond traditional markets.

To fully capitalise on these agreements, India must upgrade domestic logistics, ensure strict adherence to Rules of Origin (ROO) to prevent third-party dumping, and bolster trade facilitation infrastructure.

Keywords to use: tariff elimination, Rules of Origin (ROO), global value chains, MSME supply chains, trade facilitation

GS3 · Science & Tech

3. World Bank unveils digital strategy focused on artificial intelligence and connectivity

The World Bank Group has launched a comprehensive digital roadmap in Seoul to expand internet access, harness artificial intelligence, and create jobs.

What happened	The World Bank Group launched its first comprehensive digital strategy in Seoul, focusing on artificial intelligence, internet access, and jobs for 1.2 billion youth entering the workforce.
Why UPSC cares	The strategy focuses on artificial intelligence (AI) and affordable connectivity to drive job creation in developing countries, linking directly to digital public infrastructure in GS3.
Syllabus	GS3 Science & Technology: Awareness in the fields of IT, computers, and robotics.
Chapter	Science & Tech: AI & Emerging Digital Tech

Read it for

1. Role of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and digital tools in driving economic productivity in developing nations.
2. Challenges of the global digital divide, with more than two billion people remaining offline.
3. Leveraging public-private partnerships to generate youth employment through technology.

Key terms

Artificial Intelligence (AI)
The simulation of human intelligence processes by machines and computer systems, enabling tasks such as learning, reasoning, and problem solving.

Digital Divide
The economic and social inequality between individuals, communities, or countries regarding their access to modern information and communication technology.

Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)
Foundational digital systems such as digital identity, payment gateways, and data exchange networks that enable efficient delivery of public and private services.

Multilateral Development Bank (MDB)
An international financial institution founded by groups of countries to promote economic development in developing nations through financing and technical advisory.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the applications of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in developing economies:
1. AI systems can enhance agricultural productivity through predictive analytics for crop health and weather patterns.
2. Machine learning algorithms can improve public service delivery by identifying delivery leakages in welfare programmes.
3. AI tools can assist in healthcare delivery by enabling preliminary diagnostic support in underserved areas.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because Artificial Intelligence (AI) algorithms process satellite imagery, soil data, and meteorological trends to optimize crop management and yields. Statement 2 is correct because machine learning tools can detect anomalies and fraud in beneficiary databases, thereby reducing leakages in public distribution. Statement 3 is correct because AI-driven diagnostic software helps healthcare workers perform remote triage and detect diseases like tuberculosis or diabetic retinopathy in rural areas with limited medical specialists.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2020 · Q38

With the present state of development, Artificial Intelligence can effectively do which of the following ?
1. Bring down electricity consumption in industrial units
2. Create meaningful short stories and songs
3. Disease diagnosis
4. Text-to-Speech Conversion
5. Wireless transmission of electrical energy
Select the correct answer using the code given below :

a. 1, 2, 3 and 5 only
b. 1, 3 and 4 only
c. 2, 4 and 5 only
d. 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Answer: (b) Official answer (UPSC answer key): B. Artificial Intelligence is effectively used today to optimize energy grids and industrial units to bring down electricity consumption, assist doctors in accurate disease diagnosis, and perform text-to-speech conversion. However, creating truly meaningful, emotionally resonant original stories and songs or achieving wireless transmission of electrical energy are beyond the current capabilities of AI. Thus, statements 1, 3, and 4 are correct.

Mains: how it could come

How can emerging digital technologies, particularly Artificial Intelligence, be harnessed to address employment challenges and enhance public service delivery in developing economies? (150 words, 10 marks)

Digital technologies and Artificial Intelligence (AI) are transitioning from experimental tools to core engines of economic productivity, offering developing countries scalable solutions to structural growth constraints.

- Productivity in core sectors: AI tools optimize resource use in agriculture, improve diagnostic reach in healthcare, and optimize logistics in manufacturing, driving value creation.
- Targeted public delivery: Digital platforms coupled with automated data systems plug leakages in welfare distribution, facilitate digital identities, and improve governance transparency.
- Employment and skill creation: Fostering local tech ecosystems creates high-value digital services jobs, while micro-skilling platforms help young workers adapt to emerging market needs.

Developing nations must build robust Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) and invest in digital literacy to prevent deepening inequalities and bridge the persistent digital divide.

Keywords to use: Artificial Intelligence (AI), Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), digital divide, service delivery, productivity

Newspaper words

territorial integrity	क्षेत्रीय अखंडता	The principle that a nation's borders should not be violated
reiterate	दोहराना	To state or declare something again for emphasis
regulatory alignment	नियामकीय संरेखन	Harmonization of rules and standards between trading partners
pivot	नीतिगत मोड़ या बदलाव	A fundamental shift or change in strategy or policy
leveraging	प्रभावी इस्तेमाल करना	Using a resource or advantage to achieve a desired result

Thursday, 22 October 2026

GS2 · International Relations

1. India and Poland review bilateral ties to deepen strategic partnership

Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk visits New Delhi and Bengaluru to advance bilateral agreements, trade and tech collaboration.

What happened	Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk reviewed bilateral ties in New Delhi, building on the Strategic Partnership established in August 2024.
Why UPSC cares	High-level bilateral discussions with Poland are crucial for India's engagement with Central Europe and bilateral trade ties in General Studies Paper 2.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity and Governance: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Track the evolution of India's strategic partnerships with Central and Eastern European nations.
2. Understand the economic significance of Central Europe as a gateway to the broader European Union market.
3. Analyse the role of technological collaboration in space, information technology, and defence with European partners.

Key terms

Strategic Partnership
A bilateral framework where two sovereign states institutionalise deep, regular cooperation across diplomatic, economic, defence, and multilateral areas without entering into a binding military alliance.

European Council
The European Union institution that brings together the heads of state or government of member nations to define the bloc's overall political direction and priorities.

Central and Eastern Europe (CEE)
A geopolitical subregion of Europe comprising post-Cold War transitioning economies, many of which are members of the European Union and the North Atlantic Treaty Organization.

Bilateral Investment
Capital flows and financial commitments made by businesses or governments of one country directly into the economic enterprises of another country.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements:
1. Strategic partnerships in international relations denote institutionalised frameworks for long term bilateral cooperation without creating mutual military defence commitments.
2. The European Union operates as a single market and customs union with a common commercial policy for external trade negotiations.
3. Poland is a member state of both the European Union and the North Atlantic Treaty Organization.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct because strategic partnerships are flexible frameworks for bilateral dialogue, economic integration, and technical cooperation, differing fundamentally from collective defence military pacts. Statement 2 is correct because the European Union maintains an exclusive competence over the common commercial policy, negotiating external trade pacts on behalf of all member states. Statement 3 is correct because Poland joined the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) in 1999 and the European Union (EU) in 2004.

Mains: how it could come

Central and Eastern European countries hold growing geopolitical and economic relevance for India's foreign policy. Examine this statement in light of India's expanding strategic ties with Poland. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's foreign policy has actively diversified within Europe, moving beyond traditional western European partners to forge robust ties with Central and Eastern Europe (CEE).

- Poland serves as India's premier economic bridgehead in Central Europe, with bilateral trade crossing 6 billion dollars and Indian investments exceeding 3 billion dollars.
- Technological synergies in information technology, space applications, and green energy open collaborative avenues in industrial innovation and services.
- Geopolitically, deeper engagement with Warsaw strengthens India's voice within European Union councils and broadens multilateral alignment amid shifting Eurasian security dynamics.
- Educational and diaspora linkages, including over 3500 Indian students and 30000 residents, provide strong people to people foundations for strategic ties.

India should institutionalise sectoral working groups in high technology and fast track bilateral investment agreements to solidify its presence in Central Europe.

Keywords to use: Strategic Partnership, Central and Eastern Europe, European Union gateway, Tech collaboration, Diaspora diplomacy

GS3 · Environment

2. UNEP warns of higher warming as major economies fall behind targets

The United Nations Environment Programme warned that global temperatures could rise by 2.6 degrees Celsius by 2100 as emissions rise.

What happened	The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) reported that global temperatures could rise by 2.6 degrees Celsius by 2100, driven partly by the United States withdrawal from the Paris Agreement and its 133 million tonne increase in emissions.
Why UPSC cares	The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) report highlights emissions gap risks and Paris Agreement targets for environmental governance.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, climate change treaties.
Chapter	Environment: Global Climate Bodies & Pacts

Read it for

1. Track the gap between national climate pledges and emissions cuts needed to meet Paris Agreement temperature goals.
2. Understand the global atmospheric consequences when a major historical emitter shifts its domestic climate policies.
3. Examine required emission reduction pathways of 18 per cent by 2030 and 69 per cent by 2040 to avoid catastrophic risks.

Key terms

Emissions Gap
The difference between anticipated global greenhouse gas emissions under current national policies and the lower emissions required to meet agreed temperature targets.

Pre-industrial Levels
The baseline climate state, usually taken as the average temperature between 1850 and 1900, before large-scale industrial fossil fuel burning began altering atmospheric composition.

Carbon Dioxide Equivalent
A standard unit for measuring carbon footprints by expressing the global warming potential of different greenhouse gases in terms of the equivalent amount of carbon dioxide.

Paris Climate Agreement
A 2015 international climate treaty aimed at keeping the increase in global average temperature well below 2 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels, pursuing efforts for 1.5 degrees Celsius.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Paris Agreement:
1. The greenhouse gas emission reduction targets submitted by countries in their Nationally Determined Contributions are legally binding and subject to international sanctions upon non-compliance.
2. The agreement aims to hold the increase in global average temperature to well below 2 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels.
3. It establishes a Global Stocktake mechanism to assess collective progress towards the agreement's long-term goals every five years.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because while countries are legally required under the Paris Agreement to prepare, communicate, and maintain Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs), the specific emissions reduction targets themselves are voluntary and not subject to punitive measures or sanctions. Statements 2 and 3 are correct because Article 2 commits to holding warming well below 2 degrees Celsius, and Article 14 establishes the five-yearly Global Stocktake to assess collective implementation.

Mains: how it could come

Unilateral policy shifts by major historical greenhouse gas emitters threaten the multilateral climate regime under the Paris Agreement. Examine the implications of this trend for global climate targets and propose institutional measures to enhance compliance. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Paris Agreement relies on voluntary pledges and collective multilateral trust, making it vulnerable when leading industrialized economies roll back climate commitments or exit international accords.

- Erosion of the carbon budget: Policy reversals in high-emitting nations widen the emissions gap, pushing projected warming above the 1.5 and 2 degrees Celsius thresholds.
- Undermining Common but Differentiated Responsibilities: When developed nations default on mitigation, developing nations face an inequitable burden of transition without promised climate finance and technology.
- Diminished multilateral credibility: Unilateral withdrawals create a collective action dilemma, encouraging other states to dilute their domestic ambitions.

Strengthening border carbon adjustments, formalizing non-state subnational commitments, and linking climate compliance to multilateral trade arrangements can reinforce international accountability.

Keywords to use: Emissions Gap, Common but Differentiated Responsibilities, Carbon Budget, Global Stocktake, Border Carbon Adjustment

GS3 · Science & Tech

3. Measles outbreak in Bangladesh highlights herd immunity risks

A severe measles surge caused over 1,100 child deaths in Bangladesh after vaccination coverage fell below critical protection thresholds.

What happened	Bangladesh recorded over 2.02 lakh suspected measles cases and 1,147 deaths, with 94 per cent of fatalities occurring in children under five, following drops in first and second dose vaccination coverage to 90 per cent and 86 per cent.
Why UPSC cares	Measles outbreaks and immunisation deficits link to public health policy, vaccine-preventable diseases, and World Health Organization (WHO) targets.
Syllabus	GS3 Science & Technology: Viruses, Vaccines and Public Health.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. Understand why measles requires an exceptionally high vaccination threshold of 95 per cent to establish herd immunity.
2. Analyze the causes of routine immunisation gaps and their direct impact on infant and child mortality.
3. Examine public health surveillance tools, laboratory confirmation systems, and cross-border disease surveillance mechanisms.

Key terms

Measles
A highly contagious viral disease caused by a single-stranded RNA virus of the paramyxovirus family, transmitted through airborne respiratory droplets.

Herd Immunity
Indirect protection from an infectious disease that happens when a large proportion of a population becomes immune, thereby curbing person-to-person spread.

Basic Reproduction Number (R0)
The average number of secondary infections produced by a single infected individual in a completely susceptible population.

Live-Attenuated Vaccine
A vaccine containing a weakened form of the living pathogen that replicates in the recipient to trigger a durable immune response without causing severe disease.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding measles:
1. It is a viral disease primarily transmitted through airborne droplets.
2. A routine immunisation coverage of 70 per cent in a population is sufficient to achieve herd immunity against it.
3. It can lead to severe complications such as pneumonia, blindness, and encephalitis in young children.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because measles is caused by a virus belonging to the paramyxovirus family and spreads through airborne respiratory droplets. Statement 2 is incorrect because measles is one of the most contagious human diseases with a basic reproduction number of 12 to 18, requiring a vaccination coverage of approximately 95 per cent to establish herd immunity and interrupt community transmission. Statement 3 is correct because severe measles can cause debilitating complications, including blindness, encephalitis, severe diarrhoea, and respiratory infections like pneumonia, particularly in malnourished children.

Mains: how it could come

Why does measles require an exceptionally high vaccination threshold to attain herd immunity? Discuss the systemic challenges in sustaining universal child immunisation and suggest measures to prevent outbreak resurgences. (150 words, 10 marks)

Measles is an acute viral infection characterized by extreme infectiousness, requiring at least 95 per cent population coverage with two doses to halt sustained transmission.

- Herd immunity threshold is determined by the formula 1 minus 1 divided by R0. Since measles has an R0 of 12 to 18, even a minor drop below 95 per cent coverage creates pockets of susceptible individuals, sparking outbreaks.
- Systemic bottlenecks include disruptions to routine primary healthcare services, inaccurate civil registration leaving children unregistered, and healthcare worker shortages in hard-to-reach pockets.
- Surveillance gaps such as under-reporting of suspected cases and delays in laboratory validation weaken timely public health interventions.

Governments must institutionalise digital immunization tracking, conduct catch-up mop-up drives for older children, and reinforce community health outreach to close coverage deficits.

Keywords to use: basic reproduction number (R0), herd immunity threshold, routine immunisation, cold chain infrastructure, active disease surveillance

Newspaper words

bilateral	द्विपक्षीय	involving two parties, especially two countries
mitigation	शमन या कमी करना	the action of reducing the severity, seriousness, or damage of something
catastrophic	विनाशकारी	involving or causing sudden great damage, suffering, or disaster
transmissible	संक्रामक या संचारणीय	capable of being spread or passed from one person or organism to another
surveillance	निगरानी या सतत परीक्षण	continuous observation or monitoring of an area, person, or disease outbreak

Friday, 23 October 2026

GS3 · Economy

1. Piyush Goyal warns European Union carbon tax will hurt competitiveness

Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal criticized the European Union carbon border adjustment mechanism, warning it would raise industrial costs and fuel inflation.

What happened	Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal criticized the European Union Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism at the Berlin Global Dialogue, stating it would increase costs for steel, aluminium, and cement, fuel inflation, and weaken industrial competitiveness.
Why UPSC cares	European Union (EU) carbon tariffs raise critical issues regarding common but differentiated responsibilities, trade protectionism, and export competitiveness under the General Studies (GS) 3 Economy syllabus.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Effects of liberalization on the economy, changes in industrial policy and their effects on industrial growth.
Chapter	Economy: External Sector of India

Read it for

1. Understand the basic mechanics and objectives of the European Union Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism.
2. Analyze the impact of carbon border taxes on developing economies like India.
3. Examine India's stance and arguments regarding equity, historical emissions, and trade barriers.

Key terms

Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism
A climate policy tool proposed by the European Union to place a carbon price on imports of carbon-intensive goods, ensuring equal carbon costs between domestic and foreign products.

Embedded Emissions
The greenhouse gas emissions released during the entire manufacturing and production process of a specific product, from raw material extraction to final assembly.

Trade Competitiveness
The ability of a country's industries and exporters to provide goods and services that meet the test of international markets while maintaining and expanding real incomes.

Retaliatory Measures
Tariffs, trade restrictions, or regulatory barriers imposed by a trading partner in response to unfair or discriminatory trade policies enacted by another nation.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism:
1. It aims to equalize the price of carbon between domestic products within the implementing region and imports from foreign countries.
2. It primarily targets carbon-intensive sectors such as steel, aluminium, cement, and fertilizers.
3. Developing nations support this mechanism unconditionally as it eliminates historical emission disparities.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1 and 2 only

Answer: (d) The mechanism is designed to prevent carbon leakage by putting a fair price on carbon emitted during the production of carbon-intensive goods entering the implementing zone, fulfilling the first two statements. However, developing nations strongly oppose it, arguing it violates principles of common but differentiated responsibilities and creates protectionist trade barriers, making the third statement incorrect.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the implications of the European Union's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism on India's export competitiveness and discuss how India should navigate this emerging global trade challenge. (150 words, 10 marks)

The European Union Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism is a landmark environmental trade policy designed to levy carbon tariffs on carbon-intensive imports.

- Increases compliance costs and erodes price competitiveness for Indian exporters in sectors like steel, aluminium, and cement.
- Acts as a non-tariff trade barrier that may contradict World Trade Organization principles of non-discrimination.
- Disregards the principle of historical responsibility and common but differentiated responsibilities under climate frameworks.
- Forces Indian industries to fast-track decarbonization, adopt green technologies, and establish domestic carbon credit trading markets.

India must legally challenge discriminatory aspects at multilateral forums while accelerating domestic energy transitions through renewable integration and carbon pricing mechanisms.

Keywords to use: Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism, Carbon Leakage, Trade Competitiveness, Decarbonization, World Trade Organization

GS3 · Environment & Pollution

2. India scales up waste rules across nine major streams

The Union government has progressively strengthened waste management regulations across nine specific streams focusing on circular economy principles.

What happened	The government reported that sector-specific rules for nine waste streams, including plastic, batteries, and e-waste, have been progressively strengthened.
Why UPSC cares	Waste management regulations and circular economy frameworks are essential topics for the General Studies (GS) 3 Environment syllabus, particularly for questions on environmental governance.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation.
Chapter	Environment: Pollution: Types, Sources & Control

Read it for

1. Understand the mechanics of Extended Producer Responsibility in waste rules.
2. Analyze the role of circular economy principles in resource recovery.
3. Examine challenges in managing critical minerals from e-waste and batteries.

Key terms

Extended Producer Responsibility
A policy approach under which producers are given a significant responsibility for the treatment or disposal of post-consumer products.

Circular Economy
An economic system aimed at eliminating waste and the continual use of resources through reuse, sharing, repair, refurbishment, and recycling.

Critical Minerals
Non-fuel minerals and metals that are essential for the modern economy, renewable energy technologies, and defense applications, with high supply chain vulnerability.

Secondary Raw Materials
Materials recovered from waste and scrap that can be used in manufacturing processes as a substitute for virgin raw materials.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding Extended Producer Responsibility in India:
1. It places the financial and physical responsibility on producers for the environmentally sound management of their products after consumer use.
2. It applies exclusively to plastic waste management rules and is not extended to e-waste or battery waste.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct because Extended Producer Responsibility legally obligates producers to manage post-consumer waste, shifting the burden from municipalities to manufacturers. Statement 2 is incorrect because the framework covers multiple waste streams in India, including plastic waste, e-waste, battery waste, and hazardous waste.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2019 · Q78

In India, 'extended producer responsibility' was introduced as an important feature in which of the following?

a. The Bio-medical Waste (Management and Handling) Rules, 1998
b. The Recycled Plastic (Manufacturing and Usage) Rules, 1999
c. The e-Waste (Management and Handling) Rules, 2011
d. The Food Safety and Standard Regulations, 2011

Answer: (c) Official answer (UPSC answer key): C. Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) is a policy approach under which producers are given a significant financial and physical responsibility for the treatment or disposal of post-consumer products. In India, EPR was first explicitly introduced as an important feature in the e-Waste (Management and Handling) Rules, 2011. Hence, option (c) is correct.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the significance of Extended Producer Responsibility and circular economy principles in transforming India's waste management framework. What are the key bottlenecks in achieving effective resource recovery from e-waste and batteries? (150 words, 10 marks)

India's progressive shift towards sector-specific waste rules institutionalizes Extended Producer Responsibility, shifting focus from mere disposal to resource recovery and circular economy.

- Shifts liability to manufacturers, incentivizing eco-design and recyclable packaging.
- Promotes formal recycling infrastructure, reducing environmental degradation from informal processing.
- Secures secondary raw materials, lessening import dependence for critical minerals.
- Bottlenecks include informal sector dominance, lack of supply chain traceability, and deficient recycling capacity.

Strengthening collection networks, formalizing informal aggregators, and enforcing traceability through digital platforms will drive effective circularity.

Keywords to use: Extended Producer Responsibility, Circular Economy, Critical Minerals, Secondary Raw Materials, E-waste Management

GS2 · International Relations

3. India and Poland boost cooperation in defence, space and nuclear energy

Prime Minister Modi and Prime Minister Tusk held comprehensive talks in New Delhi to double bilateral trade by 2030 and deepen strategic ties.

What happened	India and Poland agreed to boost cooperation in defence, space, and nuclear energy, aiming to double bilateral trade by 2030.
Why UPSC cares	Strategic partnerships with Central European countries covering defence, nuclear energy, and space technology form a vital part of the General Studies (GS) 2 International Relations syllabus.

Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: India and its neighborhood- relations. Bilateral, regional and global groupings involving India.
Chapter	Polity: India's External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the key pillars of India and Poland strategic partnership.
2. Analyze the significance of critical technologies and trusted supply chains.
3. Examine regional security perspectives including the Indo-Pacific and counter-terrorism.

Key terms

Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative
An open, non-treaty-based global initiative launched by India for cooperation in the Indo-Pacific region focusing on maritime security and ecology.

Critical and Emerging Technologies
Advanced technologies such as artificial intelligence, quantum computing, and biotechnology that are crucial for national security and economic growth.

Cross-Border Terrorism
Acts of terrorism perpetrated by individuals or groups based in one country against targets in a neighboring country, often backed by state actors.

Nuclear Energy Cooperation
Bilateral agreements aimed at peaceful uses of atomic energy, including power generation, research, and safety standards.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI):
1. It is a regional, open, and non-treaty-based initiative launched by India to promote cooperation in the Indo-Pacific.
2. It focuses exclusively on military alliances and joint naval patrols among member nations.
3. Maritime ecology and disaster risk reduction are among its core pillars.

a. 1 only
b. 1 and 3 only
c. 2 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) The Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative is an open, non-treaty-based initiative launched by India at the East Asia Summit to foster practical cooperation in the Indo-Pacific region. It focuses on seven pillars including maritime security, maritime ecology, maritime resources, capacity building, and disaster risk reduction, but it is not a military alliance or a formal security pact.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the strategic and economic significance of expanding India's diplomatic engagement with Central and Eastern European countries like Poland. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's diplomatic outreach to Central and Eastern European nations, particularly Poland, marks a proactive shift towards diversifying strategic partnerships beyond traditional Western allies.

- Economic diversification: Both nations aim to double bilateral trade by 2030, opening markets for manufacturing, IT, and agriculture.
- Critical and emerging technologies: Cooperation in cybersecurity, space, and artificial intelligence enhances technological resilience.
- Energy security: Collaborating on nuclear energy supports India's transition to clean energy sources.
- Geopolitical convergence: Joint stance against cross-border terrorism and commitment to a free Indo-Pacific reinforce multilateral security frameworks.

Deepening institutional linkages and finalizing trade frameworks will help translate high-level political consensus into tangible economic and strategic outcomes.

Keywords to use: Strategic Partnership, Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative, Trusted Supply Chains, Critical Technologies, Bilateral Trade

Newspaper words

protectionism	संरक्षणवाद	the practice of shielding domestic industries from foreign competition through tariffs
equity	निष्पक्षता, न्यायसंगतता	fairness and justice in the distribution of resources or responsibilities
scarcity	कमी, अभाव	the state of having an inadequate amount or shortage of something
strategic autonomy	रणनीतिक स्वायत्तता	the ability of a nation to pursue its foreign policy independently
comprehensive	व्यापक, विस्तृत	complete and including all or nearly all elements of something

Saturday, 24 October 2026

GS3 · Environment

1. Centre reviews Uttar Pradesh winter pollution action plan for NCR

The Environment Ministry reviewed vehicular, road and waste management steps in Uttar Pradesh to tackle winter air pollution in Delhi NCR.

What happened	The Union Environment Secretary reviewed Uttar Pradesh's winter action plan for the National Capital Region (NCR), focusing on electric buses, waste processing, road works, and the 'No PUCC, No Fuel' rule.
Why UPSC cares	Review of pollution control measures in the National Capital Region (NCR) provides critical fodder for General Studies 3 questions on air pollution, stubble burning, and inter-state environmental governance.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment.
Chapter	Environment: Pollution: Types, Sources & Control

Read it for

1. Understand multi-sectoral sources of winter air pollution across the National Capital Region (NCR).
2. Examine vehicular emission control measures including scrappage incentives and fuel station surveillance.
3. Track Centre-State coordination mechanisms for airshed-level environmental governance.

Key terms

Air Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC)
A statutory document certifying that a motor vehicle meets the prescribed emission standards under the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989.

Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR)
A surveillance technology that uses optical character recognition on images to read vehicle registration plates for tracking and enforcement.

Airshed
A geographic area that shares the same air mass and atmospheric circulation, making local pollution control dependent on regional coordination.

Temperature Inversion
A meteorological phenomenon where a layer of warm air traps cooler air near the ground, preventing pollutants from dispersing vertically.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the meteorological and geographical factors exacerbating air pollution in northern India during winter, consider the following statements:
1. Thermal inversion during winter traps pollutants close to the ground by preventing vertical air mixing.
2. Low surface wind speeds during post-monsoon months restrict the horizontal dispersion of pollutants.
3. The topography of the Indo-Gangetic Plain creates a valley-like basin effect that impedes the exit of particulate matter.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: During winter, rapid ground cooling creates thermal inversion where cold air near the surface is trapped beneath warm air, stopping vertical convection. Statement 2 is correct: Post-monsoon anticyclonic conditions bring calm surface winds, severely limiting horizontal ventilation. Statement 3 is correct: The Himalayas to the north and the central Indian plateau to the south create an enclosed geographical basin across the Indo-Gangetic Plain that traps regional emissions.

Mains: how it could come

Air pollution in the National Capital Region cannot be resolved through fragmented municipal efforts alone. Discuss the significance of an airshed management approach and highlight key technological interventions needed for effective enforcement. (150 words, 10 marks)

The National Capital Region (NCR) functions as a single contiguous airshed where geography, wind vectors, and seasonal meteorology redistribute emissions across state boundaries.

- Need for airshed approach: Pollution sources such as stubble burning, vehicular traffic, and industrial zones are trans-boundary, rendering single-state jurisdictional measures ineffective.
- Institutional coordination: Unified regulatory frameworks under the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) ensure uniform standards across Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan.
- Technological interventions: Automated surveillance using Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) cameras enables strict enforcement of Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC) compliance at retail fuel outlets.
- Fleet transition and monitoring: Real-time continuous emission monitoring systems at industrial units, satellite tracking of thermal anomalies, and electric mobility schemes curb baseline emissions.

Shifting from seasonal crisis management to year-round regional airshed planning with automated enforcement is vital for clean urban air.

Keywords to use: Airshed management, Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR), Pollution Under Control Certificate (PUCC), Thermal inversion

GS3 · Economy

2. NSO revamps Periodic Labour Force Survey to count gig and unpaid care work

The National Statistics Office proposes major updates to the Periodic Labour Force Survey for 2027, introducing strata for platform workers and capturing unpaid care work.

What happened	The National Statistics Office proposed updates to the Periodic Labour Force Survey 2027 to capture gig platform workers and unpaid care work, alongside updating the urban sampling frame.
Why UPSC cares	The National Statistics Office (NSO) plans to cover digital platform workers in the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), vital for General Studies 3 questions on employment statistics and the gig economy.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Employment, inclusive growth, and mobilization of resources.
Chapter	Economy: Poverty and Unemployment

Read it for

1. Why counting platform workers and unpaid care work alters standard labour force metrics.
2. How statistical sampling frames adapt to rapid urbanisation and boundary shifts.
3. Relevance for measuring female labour force participation and economic informalisation.

Key terms

Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS)
A nationwide sample survey launched by the National Statistics Office to measure employment and unemployment indicators at regular intervals across rural and urban India.

Platform Worker
An individual engaged in an employment arrangement where an online platform matches service providers with consumers, outside the traditional employer-employee relationship.

Unpaid Care Work
Non-monetary services provided within households, such as child rearing, elder care, and domestic maintenance, which are traditionally omitted from GDP calculations.

Sampling Frame
The complete list or geographical boundary register of units from which a statistical sample is drawn to ensure representative survey findings.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the measurement of employment in India, consider the following statements:
1. The Periodic Labour Force Survey is conducted on an annual basis solely for rural areas by the Labour Bureau.
2. In the Usual Principal Activity Status approach, an individual is classified as employed if they spent a relatively major time of the preceding 365 days in economic activity.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect: The Periodic Labour Force Survey is conducted by the National Statistics Office (NSO) under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, covering both rural and urban areas. Statement 2 is correct: Under the Usual Principal Activity Status (UPS), the reference period is 365 days, and an individual is categorized as employed if they spent the majority portion of that reference period in economic activity.

Mains: how it could come

Conventional labour market statistics in India fail to capture the rising gig economy and widespread unpaid care work. Examine how refining employment measurement tools can aid economic policymaking. (150 words, 10 marks)

Accurate employment data is essential for assessing demographic dividends and targeting fiscal policy, yet traditional surveys often exclude informal gig arrangements and domestic care work.

- Gig economy integration: Measuring platform workers separately provides precise insights into underemployment, variable income patterns, and lack of social protection.
- Recognising unpaid care work: Acknowledging unpaid household and voluntary labour corrects the systemic underestimation of female economic participation.
- Policy targeting: Granular urban and rural sampling frames ensure better calibration of social security schemes and urban employment initiatives.
- National accounting accuracy: Inclusion of household own-use production improves GDP accuracy and aligns national metrics with global standards.

Adopting dynamic digital frameworks alongside regular time-use surveys will create responsive labour policies and support gender-inclusive growth.

Keywords to use: Time-use survey, Female labour force participation, Platform economy, Social security, Underemployment

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GS2 · International Relations

3. India and China agree to discuss steps for better border management along LAC

The Ministry of External Affairs affirmed that both nations continue using bilateral mechanisms to prevent misunderstandings along the Line of Actual Control.

What happened	India and China agreed to discuss improving the understanding of the Line of Actual Control to prevent patrol friction and maintain border stability.
Why UPSC cares	Diplomatic and military talks to maintain peace along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) are directly relevant to General Studies 2 questions on India-China relations and border infrastructure.
Syllabus	GS2: India and its neighbourhood relations; bilateral agreements involving India.
Chapter	Polity: India's External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the operational mechanisms used to manage differences along the Line of Actual Control (LAC).
2. Examine the role of Central Armed Police Forces, specifically Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), in border defence.
3. Analyse the linkage between border peace and tranquillity and broader bilateral diplomacy.

Key terms

Line of Actual Control (LAC)
A demarcation line separating Indian-controlled territory from Chinese-controlled territory, which remains not mutually agreed or fully delineated on maps.

Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP)
A Central Armed Police Force raised in 1962 under the Ministry of Home Affairs, mandated to guard the high-altitude Himalayan border with China.

Confidence Building Measures (CBMs)
Planned military and diplomatic procedures agreed between states to reduce tensions, prevent inadvertent escalation, and build mutual transparency.

Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC)
A bilateral institutional platform established in 2012 between India and China to handle border issues and maintain peace at diplomatic levels.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding border management along the India-China border:
1. Unlike the Line of Control (LoC) with Pakistan, the Line of Actual Control (LAC) is not mutually demarcated on the ground or on military maps.
2. The Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) operates under the administrative control of the Ministry of Home Affairs to guard this frontier.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because the Line of Actual Control has never been jointly demarcated or agreed upon on maps, leading to differing perceptions of where the line lies. Statement 2 is correct because the Indo-Tibetan Border Police is a Central Armed Police Force functioning under the Ministry of Home Affairs, responsible for guarding the India-China border.

Mains: how it could come

Maintenance of peace and tranquillity on the borders is a prerequisite for the normalisation of bilateral relations between India and China. Discuss the institutional mechanisms and major challenges involved in managing the Line of Actual Control. (150 words, 10 marks)

The India-China border is governed by the Line of Actual Control, where divergent perceptions and absence of physical demarcation frequently test bilateral ties.

- Institutional mechanisms: Bilateral protocols including the 1993 Border Peace and Tranquillity Agreement, 1996 Confidence Building Measures, and the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) facilitate communication.
- Operational framework: Senior Highest Military Commander Level meetings and flag meetings at border personnel meeting points help defuse immediate tactical face-offs.
- Key challenges: Overlapping patrol limits, aggressive infrastructure development along the frontier, divergence from established patrol norms, and deep strategic mistrust hinder boundary resolution.

Complete disengagement, strict adherence to established protocols, and institutionalising border clarification without prejudice to ultimate boundary claims are vital for lasting stability.

Keywords to use: Line of Actual Control (LAC), Confidence Building Measures (CBMs), Border Peace and Tranquillity Agreement, WMCC, Patrolling protocols

Newspaper words

airshed	वायु क्षेत्र	A geographic region that shares a common flow and volume of air.
surveillance	निगरानी	Close monitoring or observation of a person, group, or process.
underrate	कम आंकना	To underestimate the value, importance, or quality of something.
informalisation	अनौपचारिकीकरण	The process of an economy moving towards informal labor and business.
tranquillity	शांति	The state of being peaceful, quiet, and free from disturbance.

Sunday, 25 October 2026

GS3 · Science and Technology

1. Indigenous submarine AIP technology enters Phase-2 operational testing

The indigenous Air Independent Propulsion system for Indian Navy diesel-electric submarines has commenced its Setting to Work Phase-2 activity.

What happened	The indigenous Air Independent Propulsion (AIP) system for Indian Navy diesel-electric submarines achieved a major milestone with the launch of Setting to Work Phase-2 activity.
Why UPSC cares	Air-Independent Propulsion (AIP) technology is crucial for submarine endurance and indigenisation under defence modernisation.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Indigenisation of technology and developing new technology; Defence technology.

Read it for

1. Understand how Air Independent Propulsion (AIP) enhances submarine stealth and endurance.
2. Distinguish between conventional diesel-electric, AIP-fitted, and nuclear-powered submarines.
3. Track indigenisation milestones in critical naval defence technologies under GS3.

Key terms

Air Independent Propulsion (AIP)
A marine propulsion technology that allows non-nuclear submarines to operate without access to atmospheric oxygen, substantially extending underwater endurance.

Indiscretion Rate
The ratio of time a conventional submarine must spend at or near the surface using a snorkel to run diesel engines compared to its total mission time.

Fuel Cell AIP
An AIP mechanism that generates electricity directly through an electrochemical reaction between hydrogen and oxygen, producing water as the sole byproduct with minimal acoustic noise.

Diesel-Electric Submarine
A conventional submarine that relies on diesel generators to charge electric storage batteries, which in turn drive electric motors for underwater propulsion.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to Air Independent Propulsion (AIP) systems in submarines, consider the following statements:
1. An AIP system allows non-nuclear submarines to remain submerged for significantly longer periods without surfacing to snorkel for atmospheric oxygen.
2. Integrating an AIP system completely eliminates the need for diesel engines and battery banks in conventional submarines.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: AIP systems enable conventional submarines to operate underwater without access to surface oxygen for days or weeks, reducing snorkeling requirements. Statement 2 is incorrect: AIP systems serve as auxiliary power sources to recharge batteries or provide low-speed underwater cruise; they complement rather than eliminate conventional diesel engines and main battery banks.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the strategic and technological significance of integrating indigenous Air Independent Propulsion (AIP) systems into the Indian Navy's submarine fleet. (150 words, 10 marks)

Air Independent Propulsion (AIP) technology bridges the capability gap between noisy conventional diesel-electric submarines and capital-intensive nuclear submarines by significantly enhancing submerged endurance.

- Tactical Stealth: Reduces the indiscretion rate by limiting snorkeling, thereby minimizing radar, infrared, and acoustic exposure to hostile anti-submarine warfare assets.
- Operational Flexibility: Enables prolonged littoral patrols, choke point surveillance, and ambushes across critical straits in the Indian Ocean Region without frequent surfacing.
- Strategic Autonomy: Developing indigenous AIP capability curbs dependency on foreign original equipment manufacturers, fostering domestic defense engineering ecosystems.

Accelerating retrofitting schedules during mid-life refits alongside developing next-generation lithium-ion batteries will ensure credible undersea deterrence across the maritime commons.

Keywords to use: Indiscretion rate, Acoustic stealth, Fuel cell technology, Littoral warfare, Undersea deterrence

GS3 · Agriculture

2. Centre creates 11 crore farmer IDs ahead of schedule under Digital Agriculture Mission

The milestone under the Digital Agriculture Mission was reached five months before the March 2027 deadline to streamline welfare delivery.

What happened	The Union Government reached the target of creating 11 crore unique Farmer IDs five months ahead of the March 2027 deadline under the Digital Agriculture Mission.
Why UPSC cares	The creation of digital farmer IDs links directly to digital public infrastructure, targeted delivery of agricultural credit, and welfare schemes.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Agriculture, technology missions, and public distribution systems.
Chapter	Economy: Agriculture

Read it for

1. Role of Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) in transforming service delivery for Indian agriculture.
2. Mechanisms for integrating farmer identity with credit, crop insurance and disaster relief.
3. Inter-governmental coordination between the Centre, states and district administrations.

Key terms

Digital Agriculture Mission
A government initiative approved in September 2024 to build digital public infrastructure, encourage technology adoption, and streamline agricultural services.

Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)
Foundational digital systems like interoperable identity, payment, and data-sharing networks that enable public and private services at population scale.

Farmer ID
A unique digital identifier for a farmer linked to land records, enabling paperless access to credit, insurance, input subsidies, and market facilities.

Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT)
A mechanism to transfer subsidies and cash assistance directly into the verified bank accounts of beneficiaries, reducing leakage and intermediaries.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the integration of digital public infrastructure in agriculture:
1. A digital farmer registry replaces state revenue departments by transferring agricultural land administration to the Union Government.
2. A verified digital farmer identity reduces information asymmetry for institutional lenders and facilitates formal credit delivery.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because land and agriculture fall under the State List (List II) of the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution. Digital farmer registries integrate with state revenue records but do not transfer land administration or ownership rights to the Union Government. Statement 2 is correct because linking verified land and crop records through a unique ID allows banks to assess creditworthiness quickly, reducing transaction costs and information asymmetry.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how the creation of Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) in agriculture can address structural bottlenecks in institutional credit access and welfare scheme delivery. (150 words, 10 marks)

Agricultural Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), including unique digital farmer registries, creates an open, interoperable foundation that connects land, credit, and welfare systems seamlessly.

- Reduces credit barriers: Enables paperless verification of landholdings and cropping history, accelerating the sanction of Kisan Credit Card (KCC) loans while lowering administrative overheads.
- Prevents leakages and duplication: Eliminates ghost beneficiaries in schemes like Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN) and speeds up crop damage assessment for insurance payouts.
- Enhances market connectivity: Integrates farmers with electronic trading platforms and agricultural extensions, facilitating precision advisory and better price discovery.

To maximize impact, the government must address land tenancy recording, modernize patchy state land records, and ensure strong data privacy protections for smallholders.

Keywords to use: Digital Public Infrastructure, Information Asymmetry, Direct Benefit Transfer, Financial Inclusion, Land Record Digitisation

GS2 · International Relations

3. India-Africa ties anchored in South-South solidarity, says EAM

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar discussed bilateral cooperation and the rise of Africa in a multipolar world with African envoys in New Delhi.

What happened	External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar met African Heads of Mission in New Delhi to discuss bilateral cooperation, Africa's role in a multipolar world, and people-centric ties.
Why UPSC cares	India-Africa relations and South-South cooperation are vital dimensions of India's foreign policy and the rise of the Global South.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity and International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the historical roots of South-South cooperation and its relevance to India's diplomacy.
2. Track the institutional frameworks governing India-Africa ties, such as the India-Africa Forum Summit.
3. Analyze Africa's strategic importance in global governance reform and maritime security in the Indian Ocean.

Key terms

South-South Cooperation
A framework for collaboration among developing nations in the Global South across political, economic, social, environmental, and technical domains.

Multipolar World
An international system where power is distributed among several major states or regional blocs rather than dominated by one or two superpowers.

Heads of Mission
Senior diplomatic officials, such as Ambassadors or High Commissioners, accredited to represent their sending states in a host country.

Pan-African e-Network
A joint digital development initiative launched by India to provide tele-education and telemedicine services across African countries.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding India's engagements with Africa:
1. South-South cooperation functions strictly through legally binding financial treaties under the International Monetary Fund (IMF).
2. The African Union was inducted as a permanent member of the Group of Twenty (G20) during India's G20 Presidency at the New Delhi Summit.
3. The Pan-African e-Network Project was initiated by India to extend tele-education and telemedicine support to African countries.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because South-South cooperation is a non-conditional, consultative framework based on solidarity and mutual benefit, not a system of legally binding treaties under the IMF. Statement 2 is correct because the African Union became a permanent member of the G20 at the 2023 New Delhi Summit under India's presidency. Statement 3 is correct because India launched the Pan-African e-Network Project to connect African nations with Indian universities and super-speciality hospitals.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how India's development partnership model in Africa differs from traditional donor-recipient dynamics. What strategic benefits does this engagement offer to India in an evolving multipolar order? (150 words, 10 marks)

India's partnership with Africa is rooted in historical solidarity, decolonization struggles, and the principles of South-South cooperation, emphasizing mutual respect rather than conditional aid.

- Demand-driven model: Projects are determined by African priorities without conditionalities, utilizing concessional Lines of Credit (LoCs) and capacity building via Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC).
- People-centric initiatives: Digital outreach such as the Pan-African e-Network, affordable pharmaceutical exports, and agricultural technology transfers foster local empowerment.
- Geopolitical advantages: African diplomatic backing is vital for India's United Nations Security Council (UNSC) permanent seat bid and for sustaining an open, rules-based Indo-Pacific order.
- Resource and market security: Africa provides critical minerals, hydrocarbons, and emerging markets essential for India's economic growth and energy security.

Timely project execution and stronger trilateral cooperation with like-minded partners will ensure India remains a trusted and preferred partner for Africa's sustainable development.

Keywords to use: South-South cooperation, Lines of Credit, Capacity building, UNSC reforms, Multipolarity

Newspaper words

deterrence	निवारण या रोक	The practice of discouraging an attack through fear of retaliation
streamline	सुव्यवस्थित करना	To make a process or organization simpler and more effective
leakages	वित्तीय रिसाव	Loss or unauthorized diversion of money or resources from a system
solidarity	एकजुटता	Unity or agreement of feeling and action among people with a common interest
pivotal	अत्यंत महत्वपूर्ण	Of crucial importance to the development or success of something

Monday, 26 October 2026

GS3 · Economy

1. India plans to quadruple port capacity by 2047

India aims to expand its port capacity fourfold by 2047 while deepening maritime cooperation with the Port of Rotterdam under the Sagarmala initiative.

What happened	India doubled port capacity over the last decade and aims to quadruple it by 2047, seeking cooperation with the Port of Rotterdam in infrastructure, green energy, and carbon capture.
Why UPSC cares	Expanding port capacity fourfold supports international trade and economic growth. Important for GS3 infrastructure, maritime logistics, and trade competitiveness.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Infrastructure (Ports, Roads, Logistics) and External Sector.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Track port-led development under the Sagarmala initiative and its targets for national maritime logistics.
2. Understand the economic significance of turnaround times, operational efficiency, and deep-draft ports for external trade.
3. Examine green port transitions, including carbon capture, green hydrogen bunkering, and sustainable shipping.

Key terms

Sagarmala Programme

A flagship initiative of the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways aimed at promoting port-led development by modernising port infrastructure, enhancing connectivity, and supporting coastal industrialization.

Turnaround Time (TRT)

The total duration of time that a ship spends at a port from its arrival at the pilot station to its departure, serving as a primary benchmark of port operational efficiency.

Major Port Authorities Act, 2021

An Act that decentralized administration and provided greater operational autonomy to India's major ports by replacing individual port trusts with autonomous Port Authority Boards.

Green Port

A port facility designed to balance environmental sustainability with economic activity through renewable energy use, cleaner fuels, carbon reduction, and waste management.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the administration of ports in India, consider the following statements:
1. Under the Constitution of India, major ports fall under the Union List, whereas ports other than major ports fall under the Concurrent List.
2. Non-major ports in India are directly administered by the Central Government through the Tariff Authority for Major Ports (TAMP).
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: In the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution of India, Entry 27 of the Union List deals with major ports, while Entry 31 of the Concurrent List covers ports other than major ports. Statement 2 is incorrect: Non-major ports (minor and intermediate ports) fall under the jurisdiction of the respective State Governments and State Maritime Boards, not the Central Government. Moreover, the Tariff Authority for Major Ports (TAMP) regulated only major ports and was abolished under the Major Port Authorities Act, 2021.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the role of port-led industrialization and the Sagarmala Programme in reducing logistics costs and enhancing India's manufacturing competitiveness. (150 words, 10 marks)

Maritime transport carries about 95 percent of India's foreign trade by volume. The Sagarmala Programme aims to leverage India's 7,500-kilometre coastline to drive port-led industrialization and lower domestic logistics costs.

- Port Modernization: Upgrading deep drafts, mechanising berths, and automating cargo handling reduces vessel turnaround time and demurrages, matching international efficiency standards.
- Connectivity and Multimodal Integration: Developing dedicated freight corridors, coastal shipping, and inland waterways reduces dependence on expensive road transport and eliminates hinterland bottlenecks.
- Port-Linked Industrialization: Establishing Coastal Economic Zones (CEZs) near ports lowers inventory costs, optimizes supply chains, and fosters export-oriented manufacturing clusters.
- Green and Digital Initiatives: Transitioning to clean energy, carbon capture, and digital customs clearances through National Logistics Portal (Marine) streamlines trade facilitation.

Achieving the 2047 target requires addressing coastal environmental regulations, expediting Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs), and harmonizing State Maritime Boards with central plans.

Keywords to use: Sagarmala Programme, Turnaround Time (TRT), Coastal Economic Zones (CEZ), Multimodal Logistics, Green Ports

GS2 · Polity

2. President gives assent to Frontier Nagaland Territorial Authority Bill 2026

President Droupadi Murmu granted assent to the Frontier Nagaland Territorial Authority Bill 2026, passed unanimously by the Nagaland Legislative Assembly on September 3, 2026.

What happened	President Droupadi Murmu granted assent to the Frontier Nagaland Territorial Authority (FNTA) Bill 2026, which was passed by the Nagaland Legislative Assembly on September 3, 2026.
Why UPSC cares	Granting assent to autonomous territorial structures addresses regional aspirations and decentralisation. Directly linked to GS2 constitutional provisions, Article 371A, and federal governance.
Syllabus	GS2 Governance and Polity: Functions and responsibilities of the Union and the States, issues and challenges pertaining to the federal structure.

Read it for

1. Constitutional provisions under Article 201 regarding Presidential assent to State bills reserved by the Governor.
2. Special constitutional provisions for Nagaland under Article 371A and autonomous administrative arrangements in the North East.
3. The role of the Union Home Ministry in coordinating local governance and decentralisation in frontier regions.

Key terms

Presidential Assent (Article 201)
The constitutional procedure where the President of India grants or withhold assent to a State Bill reserved by the Governor for consideration.

Article 371A
A special constitutional provision protecting Naga customary law, social practices, and land ownership rights from direct Parliamentary Acts without state assembly concurrence.

Autonomous Territorial Authority
A statutory administrative body created within a State to handle local governance and financial administration for specific regional areas.

Reservation of Bills
The discretionary or mandatory action by a State Governor under Article 200 to refer a passed State legislation to the President for review.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding constitutional provisions for State legislation and special governance:
1. Under Article 201 of the Constitution of India, when a Bill passed by a State Legislature is reserved by the Governor for the consideration of the President, the President may either declare assent or withhold assent.
2. Article 371A of the Constitution of India contains special provisions with respect to the State of Nagaland, protecting Naga customary law and procedure from central legislation without Assembly approval.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: Under Article 201 of the Constitution of India, when a Governor reserves a State Bill for the consideration of the President, the President can either grant assent or withhold assent. Statement 2 is correct: Article 371A specifies that no Act of Parliament in respect of Naga customary law and procedure, administration of civil and criminal justice according to Naga customary law, or ownership and transfer of land shall apply to Nagaland unless the Legislative Assembly of Nagaland so decides.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the constitutional framework governing autonomous administrative arrangements in the North Eastern States of India. How do such mechanisms reconcile sub-regional aspirations with national integration? (150 words, 10 marks)

The Constitution of India incorporates tailored institutional arrangements, such as Article 371A and special territorial councils, to address unique ethnic, cultural, and administrative needs in North Eastern regions.

- Protection of Identity and Customary Laws: Constitutional provisions safeguard local traditional laws, land rights, and socio-cultural governance from uniform national legislation.
- Decentralised Governance: Creation of territorial authorities enables sub-regional tribal communities to exercise self-governance over local planning, development, and revenue management.
- Asymmetric Federalism: Granting special autonomous status resolves historic alienation by creating flexible governance structures within the constitutional framework of India.
- Conflict Resolution: Cooperative engagement involving the Union Home Ministry and State Assemblies helps manage regional political demands democratically.

Ensuring predictable devolution of funds, strengthening municipal capacity, and fostering transparent local political dialogue are vital to maintaining federal harmony.

Keywords to use: Article 371A, asymmetric federalism, territorial authority, sub-regional autonomy, national integration

GS3 · Science and Technology

3. India to expand space infrastructure with four functional launch pads by 2029

The national space agency is establishing a dedicated launch complex at Kulasekarapattinam while advancing preparations for the Gaganyaan and Chandrayaan-5 missions.

What happened	India plans to operate four launch pads by 2029, including a dedicated Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV) complex at Kulasekarapattinam, while preparing for uncrewed Gaganyaan trials and Chandrayaan-5.
Why UPSC cares	Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) plans a Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV) complex in Tamil Nadu. Crucial for GS3 infrastructure and space sector expansion.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Achievements of Indians in science and technology; indigenisation of technology and developing new technology; awareness in the field of space.
Chapter	Science & Tech: India’s Space Programme & Navigation

Read it for

1. Understand why a new launch site at Kulasekarapattinam is technically advantageous for small satellite launches.
2. Track the preparatory testing phases and safety protocols for India's human spaceflight mission.
3. Examine the evolving role of public-private partnerships in national space commercialisation.

Key terms

Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV)
A compact launch vehicle developed by the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) designed to carry small satellites into low Earth orbit with low turnaround time.

Telemetry, Tracking, and Command (TTC)
A network of ground stations and equipment that continuously monitors a rocket or satellite flight path, receives scientific data, and transmits operational commands.

Crew Escape System (CES)
An emergency safety mechanism designed to quickly pull the crew module away from the launch vehicle in case of a critical failure during ascent.

Environmental Control and Life Support System (ECLSS)
An integrated onboard system that regulates air pressure, oxygen levels, temperature, and humidity to sustain human life inside a crew module.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the strategic and commercial significance of expanding India's space launch infrastructure. How will initiatives like dedicated launch sites and public-private partnerships enhance India's position in the global space economy? (150 words, 10 marks)

India is augmenting its spaceport capacity by developing four functional launch pads by 2029, catering to rising demand for commercial satellite deployment and human spaceflight programmes.

- Infrastructure augmentation: The Kulasekarapattinam facility provides direct polar trajectory capability, increasing payload efficiency for small satellites and decongesting Sriharikota.
- Commercial competitiveness: Dedicated small satellite facilities reduce turnaround launch time and mission costs, positioning India as a global launch hub for private constellations.
- Technological maturation: Advancements in environmental control, crew escape mechanisms, and interplanetary rovers develop high-end domestic engineering capabilities.
- Private sector synergy: Commercialising launch operations via non-privatised agency partnerships allows the national agency to focus on deep-space exploration and advanced research.

Scaling ground infrastructure alongside robust regulatory frameworks under the national space policy will ensure sustained self-reliance and commercial viability in the global space sector.

Keywords to use: Small Satellite Launch Vehicle, Kulasekarapattinam spaceport, Payload efficiency, Public-private synergy, Space commercialisation

Newspaper words

quadruple	चार गुना करना	To increase or multiply by four times
dictates	तय या निर्धारित करता है	Determines, controls, or strongly influences
assent	मंजूरी या सहमति	Official approval or agreement, especially from a leader
autonomy	स्वायत्तता या स्वशासन	The right or power of self-government or self-rule
underscores	विशेष बल देना या रेखांकित करना	Emphasizes, stresses, or highlights the importance of

Tuesday, 27 October 2026

GS3 · Economy

1. MoSPI proposes tracking gender challenges and capital trends in informal businesses

The proposed changes to the survey seek to record gender-specific difficulties of women entrepreneurs and long-term asset investments in unincorporated units.

What happened	The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation proposed tracking gender-specific challenges for women entrepreneurs and long-term asset investments in the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises 2027-28 while shifting the survey period to the financial year.
Why UPSC cares	The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) plans to track gender-specific challenges in the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE). This provides vital data for policy formulation.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Mobilisation of resources, growth, development, and employment.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Understand how unincorporated enterprises contribute to employment and Gross Domestic Product in India.
2. Study the specific structural hurdles faced by female business owners in credit access and management.
3. Learn how aligning survey periods with financial years improves national accounting accuracy.

Key terms

Unincorporated Enterprise
Business units not legally distinct from their owners, such as sole proprietorships and informal partnerships.

Capital Formation
Net addition to physical capital stocks like machinery and infrastructure during an accounting period.

ASUSE
The Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises conducted to collect economic and operational data on informal businesses.

Financial Year
An accounting period of twelve months starting April 1 and ending March 31 used for taxation and national accounts in India.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the informal sector and business surveys in India, consider the following statements:
1. The Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) is conducted under the aegis of the Ministry of Finance.
2. Unincorporated enterprises include all corporate entities registered under the Companies Act, 2013.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is incorrect because the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE) is conducted by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI). Statement 2 is incorrect because unincorporated enterprises are non-corporate business units, such as sole proprietorships and partnerships, that are not registered as corporate companies under the Companies Act, 2013.

Mains: how it could come

Gender-disaggregated data in the informal economic sector is crucial for formulating targeted policy interventions. Discuss in the context of unincorporated enterprises in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

Unincorporated enterprises employ a vast section of India's non-agricultural workforce, but women business owners face distinct structural hurdles that remain largely unmeasured.

- High representation of women in informal micro-enterprises requires gender-specific data on credit access, market linkages, and property ownership.
- Documenting capital investment trends in female-led enterprises enables targeted financial inclusion schemes.
- Shifting survey cycles to financial years aligns informal data with Gross Domestic Product estimates and national accounts.
- Targeted data helps reduce administrative bottlenecks and enhances social security coverage for informal workers.

Integrating gender metrics into national statistical frameworks will bridge capital gaps and empower female entrepreneurs in informal supply chains.

Keywords to use: ASUSE, Informal Economy, Women Entrepreneurship, National Accounts, Gross Fixed Capital Formation

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. Navy Chief outlines five point roadmap to speed up defence indigenisation

Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan called for rapid conversion of promising tech ideas into operational capabilities at Swavlamban 2026.

What happened	Chief of the Naval Staff (CNS) Admiral Krishna Swaminathan announced a five-point roadmap for indigenisation at Swavlamban 2026, highlighting that Navy Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) challenges grew tenfold from 20 to 229 since 2022.
Why UPSC cares	The Chief of the Naval Staff (CNS) called for converting ideas into naval capabilities under Swavlamban 2026. Indigenisation reduces reliance on imports and strengthens national defence capability.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Indigenisation of technology and developing new technology.
Chapter	Science & Tech: AI & Emerging Digital Tech

Read it for

1. Examine the role of Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) in promoting self reliance in defence manufacturing.
2. Analyze the key emerging technologies shaping modern naval combat systems including Artificial Intelligence (AI) and quantum sensing.
3. Understand the significance of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) and startups in defence research and development.

Key terms

Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX)
An initiative launched by the Ministry of Defence to foster innovation and technology development in defence and aerospace by engaging industries, startups, and academic institutions.

Defence Indigenisation
The process of designing, developing, and manufacturing defence equipment domestically to reduce reliance on foreign imports and strengthen national security.

Quantum Sensing
An advanced technology that utilizes quantum mechanics principles such as entanglement and superposition to achieve ultra-precise measurements in navigation, imaging, and detection.

Autonomous Systems
Technological devices or platforms that operate independently without continuous human intervention, using sensors and algorithms to execute complex military or civilian tasks.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX), consider the following statements:
1. Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) is managed by the Defence Innovation Organisation (DIO), which is a non-profit company under the Companies Act, 2013.
2. It aims to foster innovation in defence and aerospace by engaging startups and Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs).
3. The Defence Innovation Organisation (DIO) was jointly set up by Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) and Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL).
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) is managed by the Defence Innovation Organisation (DIO), registered as a non-profit company under Section 8 of the Companies Act, 2013. Statement 2 is correct: iDEX aims to foster innovation and technology development in defence and aerospace by engaging industries, startups, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), and researchers. Statement 3 is correct: DIO was jointly funded and set up by two executive Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs), namely Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) and Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL).

Mains: how it could come

Accelerating defence indigenisation requires transitioning from basic technological innovation to mass operational capability. Discuss the significance of emerging technologies in modernizing naval forces and outline the challenges faced by startups in scaling defence production in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

Defence indigenisation is crucial for national sovereignty and strategic autonomy, shifting India from a major arms importer to a self-reliant defence manufacturer.

- Role of emerging tech: Integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI), autonomous underwater vehicles, robotics, and quantum sensing enhances maritime domain awareness and combat readiness.
- Promoting innovation: Schemes like Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) engage startups and Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), driving tenfold growth in custom naval technology challenges.
- Key challenges: Long procurement cycles, capital-intensive research, testing infrastructure bottlenecks, and scaling prototypes to commercial production.
- Strategic benefit: Reduces import reliance, saves foreign exchange, and secures critical defence supply chains against geopolitical disruptions.

Fast-track trial protocols, dedicated venture capital funds for defence startups, and streamlined procurement rules under the Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) will ensure rapid deployment of indigenous technologies.

Keywords to use: Innovations for Defence Excellence, Defence Indigenisation, Quantum Sensing, Defence Acquisition Procedure, Strategic Autonomy

GS2 · International Relations

3. India and Canada launch inaugural Migration and Mobility Dialogue in New Delhi

India and Canada signed the Terms of Reference for their inaugural dialogue in New Delhi to enhance student, professional, and skilled worker mobility.

What happened	India and Canada held their inaugural Migration and Mobility Dialogue in New Delhi and signed its Terms of Reference.
Why UPSC cares	India and Canada launched the Migration and Mobility Dialogue to facilitate safe migration and legal mobility. Institutional bilateral mechanisms are key focus areas for foreign policy studies.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity and International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Institutional frameworks governing bilateral migration and human mobility.
2. The role of student and professional mobility in foreign policy and soft power diplomacy.
3. Cooperation mechanisms between nations for managing regular and irregular migration.

Key terms

Migration and Mobility Partnership

A bilateral framework designed to facilitate legal movement of students, academics, and professionals while strengthening cooperation against irregular migration.

Terms of Reference (ToR)

A diplomatic document that defines the purpose, structure, operational guidelines, and scope of a collaborative committee or dialogue.

Consular and Overseas Indian Affairs

A specialized division within the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) responsible for passport, visa services, and diaspora welfare.

People-to-People Ties

Cultural, educational, and economic interactions between citizens of different nations that serve as a foundational pillar of diplomatic relations.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding bilateral Migration and Mobility Partnerships:
1. They aim to facilitate legal mobility for students, researchers, and professionals between signatory nations.
2. In India, matters relating to consular services and diaspora mobility are managed under the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because bilateral Migration and Mobility Partnerships promote structured legal migration for students, academics, and skilled workers. Statement 2 is correct because consular services, visa policy, and diaspora engagement fall under the domain of the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

Mains: how it could come

Bilateral migration and mobility agreements play a strategic role in strengthening international diplomacy and economic engagement. Discuss in the context of India's foreign policy objectives. (150 words, 10 marks)

Bilateral migration and mobility frameworks establish legal and regulated pathways for human movement, forming a critical pillar of modern Indian foreign policy.

- Facilitates smooth transfer of skilled professionals, business visitors, and students, boosting knowledge exchange.
- Provides institutional safeguards to protect overseas workers and prevent human trafficking or irregular migration.
- Strengthens soft power diplomacy by leveraging diaspora communities as cultural and economic bridges.
- Enhances bilateral trade and investment by simplifying entry procedures for corporate executives and entrepreneurs.

India should expand bilateral mobility dialogues with major partner countries while ensuring strict protection mechanisms for its diaspora.

Keywords to use: Migration and Mobility, Diaspora Diplomacy, Human Capital, Soft Power, Consular Cooperation

Newspaper words

unincorporated	असंगठित	not registered or formed into a legal corporation
indigenisation	स्वदेशीकरण	the process of making something native or locally produced
self reliance	आत्मनिर्भरता	reliance on one's own powers and resources
inaugural	उद्घाटन संबंधी	marking the beginning of an institution or activity
bilateral	द्विपक्षीय	affecting or undertaken by two sides or countries

Wednesday, 28 October 2026

GS3 · Science and Technology

1. India must innovate boldly and lead critical technologies of future, says Prime Minister

Speaking at the Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave, Prime Minister Narendra Modi highlighted advances in fast breeder reactor technology and rising patent filings.

What happened	Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed the Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave in New Delhi, highlighting the 500-Megawatt Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor achieving first criticality, 24 thousand crore rupees in joint public-private tech investments, and annual patent filings reaching nearly 1.5 lakh.
Why UPSC cares	Emerging technologies are key to national growth. The Prime Minister (PM) highlighted scientific research as the core of Viksit Bharat at the Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave (ESTIC).
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: achievements of Indians in science and technology, indigenisation of technology and developing new technology.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Nuclear Energy: Fission to Fusion

Read it for

1. Understanding India's three-stage nuclear power programme and the strategic role of fast breeder reactors.
2. Analyzing public and private funding models for commercialising lab-scale technologies.
3. Evaluating the growth of Intellectual Property Rights (IPR) and annual patent filings as an indicator of structural innovation.

Key terms

Fast Breeder Reactor (FBR)
A nuclear reactor that produces more fissile material than it consumes while generating electricity, using fast neutrons.

First Criticality
The operational milestone when a nuclear reactor achieves a self-sustaining nuclear chain reaction for the first time.

Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR)
A 500-Megawatt nuclear reactor located in Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu, representing the second stage of India's nuclear power programme.

Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)
Legal protections granted to creators for inventions and discoveries, including patents, trademarks, and copyrights.

Mains: how it could come

India's ambition of achieving a Viksit Bharat requires a decisive shift from laboratory-based research to commercial technology deployment. Discuss the significance of indigenous fast breeder reactor technology and public-private funding synergies in achieving national technological leadership. (150 words, 10 marks)

Achieving Viksit Bharat demands self-reliance in critical technologies, underpinned by robust scientific research and scalable market application.

- Role of Fast Breeder Reactors (FBR): Represents stage two of India's nuclear roadmap, utilizing plutonium to unlock vast domestic thorium reserves for long-term energy security.
- Bridging the Lab-to-Market Gap: Matching public commitments with equal private capital reduces financial risk and accelerates commercial deployment of emerging technologies.
- Strengthening Intellectual Property Rights (IPR): Rising annual patent filings signal a growing culture of innovation, transitioning India from a tech consumer to a global creator.
- Socio-economic Impact: Directing lab innovations to healthcare, agriculture, and disaster management solves real-world challenges for citizens.

India must enhance industry-academia linkages, streamline patent processing times, and sustain joint venture funding to lead global technological frontiers.

Keywords to use: Fast Breeder Reactor (FBR), Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR), Lab-to-Market, Intellectual Property Rights (IPR), Viksit Bharat

GS2 · International Relations

2. BRICS parliamentary forum calls for restraint in West Asia and opposes unilateral sanctions

The 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum in New Delhi adopted a joint declaration urging the protection of civilians and the reform of global governance.

What happened	The 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum in New Delhi unanimously adopted a joint declaration urging protection of civilian infrastructure in West Asia and opposing unilateral economic sanctions.
Why UPSC cares	At the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum in New Delhi, member states urged protection of civilians. This links to multilateral diplomacy and India's stance on regional security conflicts in West Asia.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. BRICS collective position on West Asian stability, international humanitarian law, and energy supply security.
2. The legal and economic debate surrounding unilateral coercive measures and secondary sanctions.
3. Calls by emerging economies for reforming multilateral institutions towards genuine multipolarity.

Key terms

Unilateral Coercive Measures
Economic, trade, or financial sanctions imposed by an individual country or bloc without explicit authorization from the United Nations Security Council.

Secondary Sanctions
Penalties enforced against third-party companies or countries that do business with an entity or nation already targeted by primary sanctions.

Multilateralism
An alliance of multiple countries pursuing common goals through agreed international norms, treaties, and institutional frameworks.

Charter of the United Nations
The foundational treaty of the United Nations that sets out sovereign equality, the non-use of force, and the peaceful settlement of disputes.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the BRICS grouping:
1. The New Development Bank (NDB) was established by BRICS member states through the Fortaleza Declaration.
2. The Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA) was set up by BRICS to provide mutual liquidity support against balance of payments pressures.
3. South Africa was one of the founding members when the first formal leaders summit was held in Yekaterinburg in 2009.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) Statements 1 and 2 are correct. The New Development Bank (NDB) and the Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA) were both established through the 6th BRICS Summit in Fortaleza, Brazil in 2014. Statement 3 is incorrect because the original BRIC grouping held its first formal summit in Yekaterinburg, Russia in 2009. South Africa joined in 2010 and participated for the first time in the 2011 Sanya Summit.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2025 · Q97

Consider the following statements with regard to BRICS :
I. 16th BRICS Summit was held under the Chairship of Russia in Kazan.
II. Indonesia has become a full member of BRICS.
III. The theme of the 16th BRICS Summit was Strengthening Multiculturalism for Just Global Development and Security.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. I and II
b. II and III
c. I and III
d. I only

Answer: (a) Official answer (UPSC answer key): A. Statement I is correct: Russia chaired BRICS in 2024 and hosted the 16th Summit in Kazan in October 2024. Statement II is correct: Indonesia became a full member of BRICS in January 2025. Statement III is wrong: the theme of the Kazan Summit was 'Strengthening Multilateralism for Just Global Development and Security'; the statement swaps 'Multilateralism' for 'Multiculturalism'. So only I and II are correct.

Mains: how it could come

Critically analyze the role of BRICS in promoting a multipolar world order and resisting unilateral economic measures in international affairs. (150 words, 10 marks)

BRICS serves as a primary vehicle for emerging economies seeking to democratize global governance, promote multipolarity, and protect national sovereignty against unilateral Western economic leverage.

- Advocating Multilateralism: Consistently urges strict adherence to the Charter of the United Nations, demanding comprehensive reforms of the United Nations Security Council and Bretton Woods institutions.
- Countering Economic Coercion: Condemns unilateral sanctions and secondary sanctions that bypass the United Nations and disrupt global trade, food, and energy supply chains.
- Developing Alternative Financial Architecture: Institutional mechanisms like the New Development Bank and local currency settlement mechanisms reduce structural dependence on Western payment systems.
- Internal Heterogeneity: Differing strategic alignments, such as India's balancing between the West and Eurasia, alongside geopolitical rivalries among members, temper the grouping's cohesion.

To act as an effective pillar of global stability, BRICS must harmonize internal differences, champion rule-based international trade, and offer inclusive development finance without turning into an anti-Western bloc.

Keywords to use: Multipolarity, Unilateral coercive measures, Charter of the United Nations, Global governance reform, New Development Bank

GS1 · Important Geophysical Phenomena

3. Union Ministry directs coastal states to enforce safety measures against Cyclone Arnab

The Ministry of Home Affairs has issued advisories to fourteen states and Union Territories to evacuate coastal areas and suspend fishing operations due to Cyclone Arnab.

What happened	The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) issued safety advisories to fourteen states and Union Territories, including West Bengal and Maharashtra, to prepare for Cyclone Arnab.
Why UPSC cares	The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) alerted states through the Integrated Control Room for Emergency Response. Tropical cyclone preparedness and disaster response mechanisms are vital Civil Services topics.
Syllabus	GS1 Geography: Important Geophysical Phenomena such as Tropical Cyclones
Chapter	Geography: Climatology

Read it for

1. Note the coordinating role of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) in disaster response advisories to state governments.
2. Understand the oceanographic and atmospheric conditions required for the formation of tropical cyclones.
3. Examine early warning communication networks and institutional coordination between meteorology and local administrative bodies.

Key terms

Tropical Cyclone
A rapidly rotating storm system characterized by a low-pressure centre, closed low-level atmospheric circulation, strong winds, and heavy rain over warm tropical oceans.

Coriolis Force
An apparent force caused by the rotation of Earth that deflects moving air to the right in the Northern Hemisphere and to the left in the Southern Hemisphere.

Latent Heat of Condensation
Energy released when water vapour condenses into liquid water, acting as the primary heat source that powers tropical cyclones.

Disaster Mitigation
Structural and non-structural measures undertaken to limit the adverse impact of natural hazards and extreme weather events.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding tropical cyclones:
1. Sea surface temperatures greater than 27 degrees Celsius are required for their formation.
2. The Coriolis force is necessary to initiate and sustain the rotational movement of the cyclone.

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because warm ocean waters exceeding 27 degrees Celsius provide the necessary heat and moisture to fuel a tropical cyclone. Statement 2 is correct because the Coriolis force, generated by Earth's rotation, deflects rising winds and creates the essential cyclonic circulation.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the physical conditions required for the formation of tropical cyclones in the Indian Ocean. How do early warning systems and central coordination reduce coastal disaster risks? (150 words, 10 marks)

Tropical cyclones are low-pressure storm systems originating over warm tropical oceans, causing high winds and heavy rainfall along coastal regions.

- Physical conditions: Sea surface temperature above 27 degrees Celsius, presence of Coriolis force, small vertical wind shear, and pre-existing weak low-pressure area.
- Role of early warning systems: India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecasts enable timely evacuation of coastal populations and complete suspension of marine activities.
- Central coordination: Inter-ministerial advisories by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) help state Chief Secretaries streamline emergency response, regulate transport, and mobilize control rooms.

Strengthen coastal shelter infrastructure, restore natural mangrove barriers, and adopt local disaster mitigation frameworks.

Keywords to use: Sea surface temperature, Coriolis force, India Meteorological Department (IMD), Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), Disaster risk reduction

Newspaper words

commercialising	व्यावसायीकरण करना	Managing or developing something to make a financial profit
restraint	संयम	Unemotional control over one's own actions or response
unilateral	एकतरफा	Performed by or affecting only one person, group, or country
coercive	बाध्यकारी	Relating to using force or threats to compel action
precautionary	एहतियाती	Carried out as a safeguard against potential danger or failure

Thursday, 29 October 2026

GS2 · Governance

1. Prime Minister reviews ₹16,000 crore infrastructure projects at 54th PRAGATI meeting

The Prime Minister chaired the 54th meeting of Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation (PRAGATI) to address bottlenecks in railways, drug parks, and PM Ekta Malls across 31 States and Union Territories.

What happened	The Prime Minister chaired the 54th PRAGATI meeting at Seva Teerth, New Delhi, reviewing projects worth over ₹16,000 crore across 31 States and Union Territories.
Why UPSC cares	Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation (PRAGATI) represents e-governance and project monitoring mechanism. It is important for General Studies Paper 2 governance and infrastructure implementation.
Syllabus	GS2 Governance: Important aspects of governance, transparency and accountability, e-governance applications and models.
Chapter	Polity: The Prime Minister: Real Executive

Read it for

1. Examine the role of digital platforms in facilitating cooperative federalism and Centre-State administrative coordination.
2. Understand the shift from outlay-centric budgeting to outcome-oriented project monitoring in public administration.
3. Analyze how inter-agency coordination mechanisms address project cost overruns and implementation delays.

Key terms

PRAGATI Platform

Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation (PRAGATI) is an Information and Communication Technology (ICT) based multi-modal platform designed to monitor key government projects and address public grievances.

Outcome-Based Governance

An administrative approach that focuses on measurable public welfare benefits and real-world impacts rather than merely tracking monetary allocations.

Cooperative Federalism

A constitutional concept where the Centre and States collaborate jointly to achieve national policy goals and ensure efficient execution of developmental schemes.

Inter-Agency Bottlenecks

Procedural or administrative delays occurring due to lack of coordination among multiple government departments, ministries, or state agencies.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation (PRAGATI) platform:
1. It is a multi-modal platform that integrates digital databases, video-conferencing, and spatial technology.
2. It brings the Prime Minister's Office, Union Government Secretaries, and Chief Secretaries of States onto a single interactive platform.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: PRAGATI is a unique three-tier system combining digital data management, video conferencing, and geospatial technology. Statement 2 is correct: It enables the Prime Minister to discuss projects directly with Central Secretaries and State Chief Secretaries, fostering cooperative federalism.

Mains: how it could come

Examine how ICT-enabled platforms like PRAGATI enhance public delivery, eliminate inter-agency bottlenecks, and shift public spending focus from outlays to outcomes. (150 words, 10 marks)

PRAGATI exemplifies the application of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) in reforming administrative governance, bridging execution gaps between policy vision and grassroots delivery.

- Real-Time Monitoring: Integrates video conferencing and geospatial technology to track physical and financial progress directly from leadership levels.
- Breaking Silos: Resolves administrative inter-agency bottlenecks by bringing Central Ministries and State Chief Secretaries together in mission mode.
- Outcome-Oriented Administration: Shifts focus from fiscal spending outlays to measurable real-world benefits for end citizens.
- Strengthening Federal Framework: Enhances Centre-State administrative trust through regular structured interaction and shared accountability.

Extending structured review mechanisms down to the District Magistrate level will ensure that public infrastructure investments translate into timely, quality service delivery for local communities.

Keywords to use: PRAGATI Platform, E-Governance, Outcome Budgeting, Cooperative Federalism, Administrative Bottlenecks

GS3 · Economy

2. Cabinet approves schemes for domestic container and sports goods manufacturing

The Union Cabinet has approved a ten thousand crore rupee scheme over 13 years to promote container manufacturing alongside a sports goods manufacturing scheme.

What happened	The Cabinet approved the Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme with an outlay of 10,000 crore rupees alongside the Khelo India Sports Goods Manufacturing Scheme.
Why UPSC cares	The Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme aims to build domestic capacity and boost supply chain resilience. It is crucial for General Studies Paper 3 manufacturing and trade infrastructure.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Industrial policy and infrastructure development.
Chapter	Economy: Industry and Infrastructure

Read it for

1. Components of industrial promotion schemes such as interest subvention and operational support.
2. Strategic importance of domestic container manufacturing for trade supply chain resilience.
3. Backward linkages to ancillary industries like specialized steel, paints, and wood.

Key terms

Interest Subvention
A financial incentive where the government pays a portion of the interest on loans taken by target industries. It reduces credit costs for commercial borrowers.

Supply Chain Resilience
The capacity of a logistics network to withstand external shocks, absorb disruptions, and recover swiftly without halting commercial trade.

Operational Expenditure Assistance
Financial support given to enterprises to manage recurring day to day running costs rather than initial capital investment in plant and machinery.

Ancillary Industry
Industrial units that produce components, intermediate inputs, or raw materials required by larger manufacturing facilities.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding 'Interest Subvention' as an economic instrument:
1. It is a scheme where the government pays a part of the interest obligation on credit extended to specific priority sectors.
2. It directly increases the effective interest rate paid by borrowing enterprises to curb excess market demand.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct because interest subvention involves the government subsidizing a portion of the interest rate on loans to make borrowing affordable for targeted sectors. Statement 2 is incorrect because subvention lowers, not increases, the effective interest burden on the borrower to stimulate investment.

Mains: how it could come

High logistics costs and import dependence in critical trade infrastructure like shipping containers hamper India's export competitiveness. Discuss how targeted industrial support schemes can build supply chain resilience. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's trade efficiency relies heavily on robust logistics infrastructure, where shortages in critical components like shipping containers create severe supply chain bottlenecks.

- Import dependence for containers increases vulnerability to global shocks and freight price volatility.
- Targeted support like interest subvention and land leasing support lowers capital costs for domestic manufacturers.
- Creation of localized manufacturing ecosystems builds strong backward linkages with steel, paint, and engineering industries.
- Quality testing and certification support ensure international acceptance of domestically produced goods.

Integrating industrial subsidies with port connectivity and ease of doing business will turn India into a durable manufacturing hub for global trade.

Keywords to use: Supply Chain Resilience, Interest Subvention, Backward Linkages, Import Dependence

GS3 · Science and Technology

3. National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority releases revised prices for 543 cancer drugs

The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) releases revised maximum retail prices for 543 anti-cancer drug brands, effective from November 9, 2026.

What happened	The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) issued revised maximum retail prices for 543 anti-cancer drug brands, effective November 9, 2026.
Why UPSC cares	National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) regulates essential drug prices to ensure affordable healthcare. This is relevant for General Studies Paper 3 public health and biotechnology governance.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Issues relating to development and management of Social Sector/Services relating to Health.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. Role of the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) in healthcare affordability.
2. Mechanism of drug price regulation under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO).
3. Impact of price caps on critical life-saving medications for cancer patients.

Key terms

National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA)
An independent regulator under the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers responsible for fixing and revising drug prices in India. It enforces price controls to ensure essential medicines remain affordable.

Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO)

An order issued under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955, enabling the government to regulate prices of scheduled drugs. It defines the framework for ceiling price calculation.

National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM)

A list prepared by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare specifying priority healthcare medications. Medicines on this list automatically fall under price control regulations.

Maximum Retail Price (MRP)

The maximum price that can be charged to a consumer for a retail product in India, including all taxes. Sellers cannot charge above the declared maximum retail price.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to drug price regulation in India, consider the following statements:
1. The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) functions as an attached office under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.
2. The National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM) is prepared by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.
3. Formulations included in the National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM) are subject to price caps fixed by the government.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) functions under the Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers, not the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare. Statement 2 is correct because the Standing National Committee on Medicines under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare prepares the National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM). Statement 3 is correct because formulations listed in NLEM are capped as scheduled drugs under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO).

Mains: how it could come

Examine the role of the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) in ensuring healthcare affordability in India. What measures are required to balance drug price control with pharmaceutical innovation? (150 words, 10 marks)

The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) regulates drug prices under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO) to make essential medicines accessible to all citizens.

- Ensures affordability of critical life-saving drugs by capping maximum retail prices based on simple average market prices.
- Prevents emergency price gouging and unfair trade markups across essential and non-scheduled formulations.
- Encourages compliance through regular market monitoring and revision of drug price lists.
- Strict price caps can squeeze research and development margins for domestic pharmaceutical manufacturers.

Adopting a trade margin rationalisation approach and offering tax incentives for local research will balance affordability with healthcare innovation.

Keywords to use: NPPA, DPCO, NLEM, Affordable Healthcare, Trade Margin Rationalisation

Newspaper words

bottlenecks	बाधाएं या अड़चनें	Obstacles or delays that slow down a process
cooperative federalism	सहकारी संघवाद	A system where Centre and States work together to solve common problems
interest subvention	ब्याज सहायता	A subsidy offered on the interest rate of a loan
resilience	सहनशीलता या लचीलापन	The ability to withstand or recover quickly from difficult conditions
ancillary	सहायक	Providing necessary support to primary activities or industries

Friday, 30 October 2026

GS2 · International Relations

1. India affirms role as net security provider at ADMM-Plus

Defence Minister highlights maritime safety, international law, and anti-piracy operations across the Indo-Pacific.

What happened	The Defence Minister addressed the 13th ADMM-Plus in Cebu, Philippines, affirming India's commitment to maritime security, UNCLOS, and open sea lanes.
Why UPSC cares	Relevant for maritime security and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) defence framework. Note India's role as a net security provider in the Indian Ocean Region.
Syllabus	GS2: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India’s External Relations

Read it for

1. Concept of India as a net security provider in the Indian Ocean Region.
2. The structure and significance of ADMM-Plus in regional security architecture.
3. Application of UNCLOS principles to international maritime navigation.

Key terms

Net Security Provider
A nation that actively improves regional stability by assisting other states in capacity building, anti-piracy, search and rescue, and disaster relief.

ADMM-Plus
A platform for Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) and its eight dialogue partners to strengthen security and defence cooperation.

UNCLOS
The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, an international treaty that defines maritime zones and establishes rules governing the oceans.

Freedom of Navigation
A principle under international maritime law guaranteeing that vessels flying the flag of any sovereign state may navigate the high seas without interference.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements:
1. The ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM-Plus) includes the ten ASEAN member states and eight dialogue partner countries, including India.
2. Under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), coastal states exercise sovereign rights over natural resources in the Exclusive Economic Zone.
3. The freedom of navigation on the high seas under UNCLOS is restricted exclusively to commercial vessels and does not cover warships.
Which of the statements given above are correct?

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) Statements 1 and 2 are correct. ADMM-Plus comprises the ten ASEAN countries and eight dialogue partners: Australia, China, India, Japan, New Zealand, Republic of Korea, Russia, and the United States. Under UNCLOS, a coastal state enjoys sovereign rights for exploring and exploiting natural resources up to 200 nautical miles in its Exclusive Economic Zone. Statement 3 is incorrect because freedom of navigation on the high seas applies to all ships, including warships, provided they adhere to peaceful purposes and international law.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the significance of India's role as a 'net security provider' in the Indian Ocean Region and the wider Indo-Pacific. What are the key challenges in sustaining this posture? (150 words, 10 marks)

India's emergence as a net security provider reflects its willingness to safeguard sea lines of communication, conduct humanitarian assistance and disaster relief, and uphold a rules-based maritime order.

- Regional Stability: Anti-piracy patrols, search and rescue missions, and escorting international merchant shipping preserve vital global commerce.
- Strategic Partnerships: Deepens cooperative frameworks through ASEAN-led mechanisms such as ADMM-Plus, the Indian Ocean Rim Association, and bilateral naval exercises.
- Capacity Building: Extends maritime domain awareness, radar networks, and patrol vessels to littoral partners to strengthen collective defence.
- Key Challenges: Resource limitations in naval modernisation, balancing competing regional powers, and increasing foreign military infrastructure in the region.

Sustaining this role requires sustained capital allocation for fleet expansion, interoperability pacts, and leveraging diplomatic goodwill with Southeast Asian partners.

Keywords to use: net security provider, ADMM-Plus, UNCLOS, maritime domain awareness, Act East policy

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GS3 · Environment & Ecology

2. Environment Ministry hosts national workshop on coastal climate resilience

The workshop focused on ecosystem restoration, hazard mapping, and livelihood protection under a Green Climate Fund project.

What happened	The Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) organized a national workshop in New Delhi under a Green Climate Fund (GCF) supported project to enhance coastal adaptation.
Why UPSC cares	Directly linked to climate adaptation and disaster management. Note adaptive strategies for coastal vulnerability under Viksit Bharat 2047 for Mains answers.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Environmental conservation, degradation, disaster management, and climate change adaptation.
Chapter	Environment: Water Ecosystems: Fresh & Marine

Read it for

1. Role of coastal blue carbon ecosystems like mangroves and seagrasses in disaster risk reduction.
2. Integration of scientific tools like hazard-line mapping and shoreline assessments into local planning.
3. Role of international climate finance mechanisms like the Green Climate Fund in community adaptation.

Key terms

Coastal Resilience
The ability of coastal communities and ecosystems to withstand, recover from, and adapt to climate-induced hazards like sea-level rise and cyclones.

Green Climate Fund (GCF)
A global fund established within the framework of the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) to assist developing countries in climate adaptation and mitigation.

Hazard Line
A composite boundary along the coast that demarcates landward areas vulnerable to coastal erosion, sea-level rise, and flooding over a long-term horizon.

Blue Carbon Ecosystems
Coastal vegetation like mangroves, seagrasses, and salt marshes that sequester large amounts of carbon while acting as natural storm buffers.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding coastal ecosystems:
1. Mangroves and salt marshes sequester carbon at rates significantly higher per unit area than most terrestrial forests.
2. Seagrass beds help mitigate coastal erosion by dampening wave energy and trapping sediment.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because coastal wetlands, known as blue carbon ecosystems, store substantial amounts of organic carbon in their sediments, often exceeding the sequestration rates of terrestrial forests. Statement 2 is correct because the canopies of seagrasses attenuate wave energy and their root-rhizome systems bind the bottom sediments, reducing shoreline erosion.

Mains: how it could come

Nature-based solutions are increasingly recognized as cost-effective instruments for coastal protection and climate adaptation. Discuss the ecological and economic benefits of restoring coastal habitats in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's extensive coastline is vulnerable to sea-level rise and frequent cyclonic storms, necessitating adaptive strategies that combine conservation with socioeconomic resilience.

- Ecological buffer: Mangroves, coral reefs, and salt marshes dissipate cyclonic wave energy, reduce storm surges, and curb coastal soil erosion.
- Blue carbon sequestration: Coastal wetlands sequester organic carbon for millennia in deep sediment, assisting India's mitigation commitments.
- Livelihood security: Healthy marine habitats serve as nurseries for commercial fisheries, crab culture, and seaweed farming, boosting artisanal fisher incomes.
- Socioeconomic empowerment: Enterprise development around restored wetlands provides alternative, resilient livelihoods, particularly benefiting coastal women.

Integrating hazard-line mapping into local panchayat planning, coupled with funding from mechanisms like the Green Climate Fund, ensures resilient and inclusive coastal development.

Keywords to use: nature-based solutions, blue carbon, hazard line mapping, coastal resilience, ecosystem restoration

GS3 · Economy

3. Corporate bond market hits landmark size as firms diversify credit sources

India's corporate bond market reached 61.5 lakh crore rupees as institutional investors seek higher yields and retail investors pivot toward direct mutual funds.

What happened	The corporate bond market reached 61.5 lakh crore rupees, the share of AAA rated bonds fell to 66 percent, and direct mutual fund plans will become the default on digital platforms.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for capital market deepening. Note the shift from bank credit to corporate bonds for infrastructure and commercial financing under resource mobilisation.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: financial markets, mobilization of resources, and banking sector reforms.
Chapter	Economy: Financial Market

Read it for

1. Growth of non-bank market financing versus traditional bank lending for corporate India.
2. Changing credit risk appetite among institutional debt investors toward lower-rated paper.
3. Structural shifts in retail investment behaviour across mutual funds and derivatives.

Key terms

Corporate Bond
A debt security issued by a corporation to raise long-term capital directly from public or institutional investors, paying periodic interest and returning principal at maturity.

Credit Rating
An independent assessment of the creditworthiness of a borrower or debt instrument, indicating the likelihood of timely interest and principal repayments.

Expense Ratio
The annual fee that mutual funds charge unit holders to cover operational, administrative, and management expenses, expressed as a percentage of total assets.

Equity Derivatives
Financial contracts whose value is derived from the price movement of an underlying share or index, often used for hedging or leveraged speculation.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the corporate bond market:
1. Corporate bonds allow enterprises to raise debt capital directly from investors without intermediation through traditional bank loans.
2. A downgrade in a corporate bond credit rating generally leads to an increase in its secondary market yield.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because corporate bonds are tradable debt instruments issued directly by companies to institutional and retail investors, bypassing traditional commercial bank loans. Statement 2 is correct because lower credit ratings reflect higher default risk, leading investors to demand higher yields as compensation.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2024 · Q43

In India, which of the following can trade in Corporate Bonds and Government Securities ?
1. Insurance Companies
2. Pension Funds
3. Retail Investors
Select the correct answer using the code given below :

a. 1 and 2 only
b. 2 and 3 only
c. 1 and 3 only
d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Official answer (UPSC answer key): D. Insurance companies, pension funds, and retail investors are all authorized market participants permitted to trade in both corporate bonds and government securities in India. Regulatory frameworks by SEBI and RBI have progressively widened access to these debt markets for retail investors as well as institutional players like insurance firms and pension funds. Therefore, all three statements are correct, making option (d) the right choice.

Mains: how it could come

A vibrant corporate bond market is critical to resolving the systemic asset-liability mismatch of commercial banks and funding India's infrastructure ambitions. Discuss. (150 words, 10 marks)

The expansion of India's corporate bond market to 61.5 lakh crore rupees marks a significant shift from a bank-dominated lending ecosystem toward a diversified capital market architecture.

- Mitigating asset-liability mismatch: Commercial banks rely on short-to-medium term deposits, making them ill-suited to finance long-gestation infrastructure projects without risking non-performing assets.
- Deepening capital access: Direct bond issuance allows Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs) and corporations to raise patient capital from pension funds and insurers with matched long-term liabilities.
- Risk dispersal: A broader credit rating profile spreads corporate borrowing risk across diversified institutional investors rather than concentrating credit risk on the banking balance sheets.
- Remaining constraints: The market continues to face secondary market illiquidity, a heavy concentration in top-rated issuers, and limited participation by retail investors.

Developing active credit default swap markets, expanding credit enhancement facilities, and encouraging retail access through standardized debt platforms are vital steps.

Keywords to use: asset-liability mismatch, corporate debt market, capital mobilization, credit ratings, non-performing assets

Newspaper words

credentials	विश्वसनीयता, साख	qualities, background, or trust earned that demonstrate suitability
resilience	पुनरुत्थान क्षमता, लचीलापन	the ability to withstand or recover quickly from difficult conditions
adaptation	अनुकूलन	the process of adjusting to environmental change or new conditions
pivot	रुख करना, दिशा बदलना	to shift or turn direction, focus, or strategy
systemic	प्रणालीगत, व्यवस्थागत	relating to or affecting an entire system rather than isolated parts

Saturday, 31 October 2026

GS2 · Judiciary

1. Supreme Court Collegium approves 11 judges for two High Courts

The Collegium cleared six candidates for Chhattisgarh High Court and five for Madhya Pradesh High Court.

What happened	The Supreme Court Collegium, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, approved 11 candidates as judges for the Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh High Courts.
Why UPSC cares	The Supreme Court Collegium system plays a vital role in the appointment of High Court judges. GS2 Polity covers judicial appointments and judicial independence.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity: Structure, organisation and functioning of the Judiciary
Chapter	Polity: High Courts of India

Read it for

1. Constitutional procedure for appointing High Court judges under Article 217.
2. Differences in Collegium composition for Supreme Court and High Court appointments.
3. Representation of both the Bar and the subordinate judiciary in judicial elevations.

Key terms

Collegium System
A forum of the Chief Justice of India and senior Supreme Court judges that recommends appointments and transfers of judges, established through judicial rulings rather than an Act of Parliament.

Article 217
The constitutional provision governing the appointment, qualifications, and conditions of the office of a judge of a High Court in India.

Elevation from the Bar
The practice of directly appointing practicing advocates of a High Court with at least ten years of standing as judges of the High Court.

Subordinate Judiciary Elevation
The promotion of serving judicial officers from district and subordinate courts to the bench of a High Court.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the appointment of High Court judges in India, consider the following statements:
1. The Supreme Court Collegium for recommending appointments to High Courts comprises the Chief Justice of India and four senior-most judges of the Supreme Court.
2. A person must have held a judicial office or been an advocate of a High Court for at least ten years to be eligible for appointment as a High Court judge.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect: For recommending appointments to High Courts, the Supreme Court Collegium consists of the Chief Justice of India (CJI) and the two senior-most judges of the Supreme Court. The five-member Collegium (CJI plus four senior-most judges) recommends appointments to the Supreme Court. Statement 2 is correct: Under Article 217(2) of the Constitution of India, a citizen is eligible to be a High Court judge if they have held a judicial office in India for at least ten years or have been an advocate of a High Court for at least ten years.

Mains: how it could come

The Collegium system was devised to safeguard judicial independence, yet it faces ongoing criticism regarding transparency and accountability. Discuss. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Collegium system, established through the Second Judges Case (1993) and refined in the Third Judges Case (1998), entrusts the appointment of superior court judges to a body of senior judges to uphold judicial independence.

- Safeguarding independence: Insulation from executive interference ensures an impartial judiciary and preserves the basic structure of the Constitution.
- Lack of transparency: Closed-door consultations without published objective criteria or public disclosure of rejection grounds invite criticism of opacity.
- Institutional friction: Delays in notifying names by the executive and absence of fixed timelines under the Memorandum of Procedure lead to judicial vacancies.
- Diversity concerns: Concerns remain regarding the under-representation of women, marginalised communities, and balance across different regions.

Revising the Memorandum of Procedure (MoP) to introduce structured criteria, a permanent secretariat, and time-bound executive action can balance judicial independence with public accountability.

Keywords to use: Memorandum of Procedure (MoP), Judicial Independence, Three Judges Cases, National Judicial Appointments Commission (NJAC), Transparency

GS1 · Modern Indian History

2. India commemorates the 151st birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel

Observed as Rashtriya Ekta Diwas, the day marks the historic role of India's first Home Minister in integrating more than 560 princely states.

What happened	The nation celebrated the 151st birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel as Rashtriya Ekta Diwas, recalling his role as the first Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister who integrated over 560 princely states.
Why UPSC cares	Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel played a key role in integrating over 560 princely states into India. GS1 History covers post independence consolidation and prominent freedom fighters.
Syllabus	GS1 Modern Indian History: significant personalities and post-independence consolidation.

Read it for

1. Role of Sardar Patel in post-independence territorial integration and the unification of princely states.
2. Key constitutional and administrative contributions, including the creation of modern All India Services.
3. Sardar Patel's leadership in major nationalist struggles, notably the Kheda, Borsad and Bardoli satyagrahas.

Key terms

Rashtriya Ekta Diwas
National Unity Day, introduced to commemorate the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and celebrate national integration.

Instrument of Accession
A legal document introduced under the Government of India Act 1935 through which princely rulers acceded to the Dominion of India.

Standstill Agreement
A transitional agreement signed between the newly independent Dominion and princely states to maintain administrative arrangements until a final accession was completed.

All India Services (AIS)
Civil services common to both the Centre and the States, strongly championed by Sardar Patel as the essential administrative framework for a united India.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and the integration of princely states:
1. The Instrument of Accession required princely states to immediately surrender all domestic administrative and legislative authority to the Dominion of India.
2. In the Constituent Assembly of India, Sardar Patel chaired the Advisory Committee on Fundamental Rights, Minorities and Tribal and Excluded Areas.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because the initial Instrument of Accession required princely rulers to cede jurisdiction over only three specific subjects: Defence, External Affairs, and Communications, while preserving internal autonomy. Statement 2 is correct because Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel headed the influential Advisory Committee on Fundamental Rights, Minorities and Tribal and Excluded Areas in the Constituent Assembly.

Mains: how it could come

Evaluate the role of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel in the political integration of post-independence India and examine his contributions towards institution building in the young republic. (150 words, 10 marks)

As India's first Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel acted as the primary architect of national unity and institutional resilience during the fragile transition after 1947.

- Territorial consolidation: Pragmatically integrated over 560 princely states using the Instrument of Accession, balancing nationalist appeals and privy purses with firm diplomatic resolve.
- Constitutional stewardship: Chaired crucial Constituent Assembly bodies, particularly the Advisory Committee on Fundamental Rights, balancing minority safeguards with individual liberties.
- Administrative architecture: Defended and instituted modern All India Services under Article 312, envisioning an impartial bureaucracy as the indispensable steel frame of India.

Patel's emphasis on administrative continuity, national unity, and territorial integrity laid the enduring institutional foundations for Indian democratic governance.

Keywords to use: Instrument of Accession, steel frame of India, All India Services, territorial integration, Constituent Assembly

GS3 · Economy

3. India records steep fall in extreme poverty to 2.6 percent between 2011 and 2023

Extreme poverty dropped from 27.1 percent to 2.6 percent alongside substantial employment gains among rural women and expanded social welfare transfers.

What happened	Extreme poverty in India dropped from 27.1 percent to 2.6 percent between 2011 and 2023, while employment grew by 13.4 crore between 2017 and 2023.
Why UPSC cares	Extreme poverty reduction is a key developmental milestone highlighting economic growth trajectory. GS3 Economy covers poverty, inclusive growth and development indicators.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Inclusive growth and issues arising from it, poverty, and employment.
Chapter	Economy: Poverty and Unemployment

Read it for

1. Distinction between extreme poverty and lower-middle-income poverty thresholds.
2. The role of female workforce expansion and targeted social transfers in poverty alleviation.
3. Methodological approaches to measuring consumption expenditure versus multidimensional poverty.

Key terms

Extreme Poverty Line
An international monetary benchmark, traditionally defined using Purchasing Power Parity (PPP), to identify individuals lacking minimum resources for basic survival.

Lower-Middle-Income Poverty Line
A higher international poverty threshold applied to lower-middle-income economies, reflecting higher basic consumption and standard of living requirements.

Social Transfers
Non-contributory public assistance programmes, including in-kind food subsidies and cash benefits, provided by the state to vulnerable households.

Purchasing Power Parity (PPP)
An economic metric that compares different countries' currencies through a basket of goods approach, adjusting for absolute price level differences.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements:
1. The international extreme poverty line is measured using Purchasing Power Parity (PPP) exchange rates to reflect differences in local purchasing power.
2. Official poverty estimation in India by expert groups like the Tendulkar Committee relied primarily on household income records rather than consumption expenditure.
Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a. 1 only
b. 2 only
c. Both 1 and 2
d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: The international poverty line uses Purchasing Power Parity (PPP) exchange rates to account for price differentials across nations. Statement 2 is incorrect: Official poverty lines in India, including those established by the Lakdawala, Tendulkar, and Rangarajan committees, were calculated based on Monthly Per Capita Consumption Expenditure (MPCE) rather than reported income.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the major factors contributing to the decline of extreme poverty in India over the past decade. What structural measures are needed to ensure sustained economic mobility for vulnerable households? (150 words, 10 marks)

India witnessed a significant decline in extreme poverty over the last decade, driven by expanded public transfers, basic infrastructure delivery, and broad-based consumption gains.

- Expanded Social Safety Nets: Targeted food subsidies, direct benefit transfers, and subsidized utilities insulated low-income households from severe nutritional and economic shocks.
- Basic Infrastructure Access: Near-universal access to electricity and improved sanitation reduced out-of-pocket overheads and enhanced household productivity.
- Workforce Shifts: Rising rural employment, particularly among women, supplemented household incomes and bolstered baseline consumption expenditure.
- Structural Challenges: Persistent informal employment, low real wage growth, and vulnerability to health expenditure require transitioning from safety nets to productive, high-wage jobs.

Sustained poverty eradication requires upgrading rural skills, formalising employment, and strengthening public healthcare to shield newly non-poor households from relapsing into poverty.

Keywords to use: extreme poverty, social transfers, female labour force participation, consumption growth, inclusive growth

Newspaper words

elevations	उच्च पद पर नियुक्ति	promotions to a higher position or rank
commemorates	स्मरण करना	honours the memory of an event or person
integration	एकीकरण	the process of combining parts into a whole
substantial	काफी, महत्वपूर्ण	large in amount, value, or importance
alleviation	निवारण, कमी	the act of making pain or hardship less severe